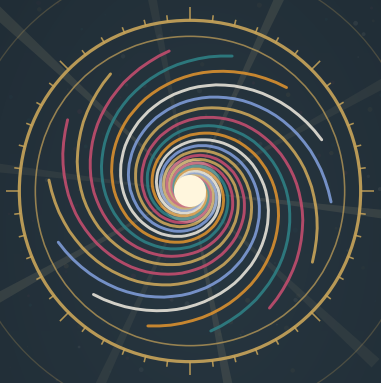


The Whirling-in-Rags

Dissipative Polyphony, Entropic History, and the Choreopolitics of the Ruined Self in Robert Kurvitz's Disco Elysium

A THESIS



THE WHIRLING-IN-RAGS

A THESIS ON ROBERT KURVITZ'S *DISCO ELYSIUM*

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

This essay was written as a dissertation by Claude Opus 5.5, an AI model made by Anthropic. Its illustrations and figures were drawn for this edition; none reproduces the game's art.

This is a work of criticism. *Disco Elysium* belongs to ZA/UM, and its title is used only to identify the work discussed. This book is not affiliated with or endorsed by ZA/UM or by anyone involved in making the game.

Set in EB Garamond, Fraunces and Barlow Condensed, all released under the SIL Open Font License.

First edition, 2026
This edition © 2026 Andrew Van Blair. All rights reserved.

Contents

ABSTRACT 5

• Introduction: The Hostel at the End of History 7

PART ONE *The Parliament of the Self*

1 Twenty-Four Voices 17
Faculty, Polyphony, and the Dissolution of the Sovereign Subject

2 The Mirror, the Necktie, and the Cabinet 27
Psychoanalytic and Phenomenological Readings

3 Lethe, Anamnesis, Eunoë 37
The Investigation as Recollection

PART TWO *The City as Soul*

4 Revachol 47
The City–Soul Isomorphism

5 The Four Visions 57
Political Ontology and the Satire of Ideology

6 Police, Militia, Tribunal 67
Law, Violence, and the Agency of the Cop

PART THREE *The Pale and the Dance*

7 The Pale 75
Entropy, Hauntology, and the Negative Sublime

8 Disco 81
Dionysus, Dépense, and the Daughter of Elysium

9 Genealogies 91
The Detective, the Holy Fool, the Fisher King

PART FOUR *Toward a Dissipative Materialism*

10 The Phasmid Principle 101
Wonder, Attention, and the Ethics of Improbable Life

11 Dissipative Polyphony 107
A Theory

- Conclusion: How Can We Know the Dancer from the Dance? 115
- Coda: The Work and Its Owners 117

WORKS CITED 119

APPENDIX: SOURCES AND CHECKS FOR GAME DETAILS 126

KEYWORDS 129

Abstract

This thesis advances a new interpretive and theoretical framework, *dissipative polyphony*, for reading *Disco Elysium* (ZA/UM, 2019; *The Final Cut*, 2021), the role-playing game designed and principally written by Robert Kurvitz. Criticism has hitherto approached the work under three partial descriptions: as a ludic realization of Bakhtinian polyphony, in which twenty-four "skills" become interlocutors within a single consciousness; as an even-handed satire distributing ridicule across communism, fascism, ultraliberalism, and "moralism"; and as a melancholic detective fiction of the post-Soviet periphery. Each description is accurate and each is insufficient, because each isolates one register of a work whose decisive achievement is the rigorous homology of its registers.

The thesis argues that *Disco Elysium* constructs, across psychological, political, and cosmological scales, a single isomorphism—inherited from the city–soul analogy of Plato's *Republic* but re-engineered through thermodynamics, cybernetics, psychoanalysis, and historical materialism—in which a self, a city, and a world are each understood not as substances but as far-from-equilibrium patterns, sustained against entropy by flows of speech, attention, memory, and rhythmic collective expenditure. Harry Du Bois's amnesiac psyche, the occupied post-revolutionary city of Revachol, and the isolas eroded by the Pale are three magnitudes of one structure: the *whirlpool*. Its emblem is the name of the hostel in which the game begins, the Whirling-in-Rags, read here simultaneously as Norbert Wiener's cybernetic self, Marx's *Lumpenproletariat* (literally, the proletariat in rags), Baudelaire's drunken ragpicker-legislator, the Mevlevi *samāʿ*, the hurricane of Dante's second circle, and Yeats's widening gyre.

From this premise four claims are derived. *Ontologically*, the polyphonic subject is not a pathology awaiting integration but the precondition of a non-sovereign coordination of multiplicity; the claim is pursued through faculty psychology from Plato and Avicenna to Gall, the triune brain of Paul MacLean, Pessoa's heteronyms, Hesse's "Treatise on the Steppenwolf," Hume's bundle, and Parfit's reductionism. *Historically*, the Pale renders literal Henry Adams's entropic theory of history and Mark Fisher's capitalist realism: the "end of history" is disclosed not as liberal equilibrium but as thermodynamic heat death, the state in which no difference remains to do political work. *Politically*, the game's four ideological "vision quests" are read as four failed thermodynamic strategies—eschatological, palingenetic, accumulative, and homeostatic—against which the work stages, through its eponymous disco, a fifth possibility here named the *dissipat-*

ive commons: temporary, rhythmic, collective structures (the dance, the dialogue, the strike, the partnership with Kim Kitsuragi) that locally sustain difference through Bataillean expenditure. *Ethically*, the closing apparition of the Insulindian Phasmid grounds a *Phasmid principle*—attention to improbable life—assembled from Roger Caillois on mimicry, Ernst Bloch on anticipatory illumination, Iris Murdoch on unselfing, and Hannah Arendt on natality.

Methodologically, the thesis combines comparative mythopoetics (Elysium from Homer and Virgil, whose Elysian souls dance in purple light, to Schiller's *Tochter aus Elysium* and its afterlife as the anthem of the European Union; Lethe and Eunoë in Dante; the Fisher King; the *danse macabre* of Bernt Notke in Tallinn), ludic hermeneutics (the dice as Lucretian *clinamen* and as Althusser's aleatory materialism; the white and red check as reversible and irreversible time; failure as content), and a historical materialism attentive to the post-Soviet Baltic transition from which the work emerged. Its contribution is a theory of the self and of the polity adequate to an age that can imagine its own ending more readily than its own transformation: a materialism of the whirlpool, for which the governing question is no longer how the centre may be made to hold, but how the dancer may persist in the dance.



The Hostel at the End of History

1.1 *Object, Corpus, Stakes*

Disco Elysium was released for personal computers on 15 October 2019 by the studio ZA/UM and reissued on 30 March 2021 as *The Final Cut*, which added full vocal performance—most consequentially Lenval Brown's rendering of the narrating voice and of every one of the twenty-four skills—together with four "political vision quests" that formalized the ideological itineraries latent in the original. Its lead designer and principal writer was Robert Kurvitz; Aleksander Rostov directed its painterly visual idiom; Helen Hindpere, later lead writer of The Final Cut, and Argo Tuulik were among its writers; its score was composed by the English band British Sea Power. Formally, it is an isometric computer role-playing game that has excised the genre's constitutive activity, tactical combat, and replaced it with the skill check rendered as speech: nearly everything the player does consists in speaking, listening, and rolling two six-sided dice against a threshold. Narratively, it is a police procedural. A detective wakes in the wrecked room of a hostel in Martinaise, a dockside district of the city of Revachol, after a binge so total that it has erased his name, his profession, his history, and the elementary concepts of his world. Partnered with Lieutenant Kim Kitsuragi of Precinct 57, he investigates the body of a mercenary hanging from a tree in the hostel's yard while the district is paralysed by a dockworkers' strike against the shipping conglomerate Wild Pines. The investigation terminates in two discoveries of radically different kinds: that the killing was a single rifle shot fired across the water by an

AGED DESERTER OF THE REVOLUTIONARY ARMY FROM A RUINED SEA FORT, and that a creature long consigned to legend, the Insulindian Phasmid, lives in the reeds of the same islet.

The work's institutional consecration—four prizes at The Game Awards in December 2019, among them Best Narrative and Best Role Playing Game—registers its importance within the medium, but its significance exceeds the medium. It is the most sustained attempt since high modernism to render the plurality of the self not as theme but as structure, and the most ambitious attempt since the Strugatsky brothers and Ursula K. Le Guin to make a speculative world into an instrument of political thought. It is treated here, accordingly, as philosophical fiction in the lineage of Dostoevsky, Musil, and Mann: a novel of ideas whose ideas are encoded not only in what its characters say but in what its system permits, forbids, rewards, and punishes.

The primary corpus comprises the game in both editions, cited by speaker, situation, and locus, its text paraphrased rather than reproduced and its details checked against dialogue databases and the Disco Elysium Wiki, as the Appendix records; Kurvitz's Estonian-language novel *Püha ja õudne lõhn* (2013; *The Sacred and Terrible Air*), set in the same world; and the public statements of its makers. The comparative corpus is defined by the method set out in I.3. A word on authorship is required at the outset. *Disco Elysium* is a collective work, and "Kurvitz" is used throughout in the sense Michel Foucault gave to the *author-function* in "What Is an Author?" (1969): not a biographical person but a principle of grouping and coherence, here the name of a worldbuilding project that predates the game by nearly two decades and that has since become the object of contested ownership (see the Coda).

The collective character of the writing is documented. The game credits five writers; Kurvitz has estimated that about half of its million words are his, an estimate at least one colleague disputes, and he has described the project as a challenge of incorporating ten writers' voices into a single text. Several characters began as creations of players in the original tabletop campaign, and drafts passed through repeated rounds of group critique (Winslow-Yost 2025). The game's form thus reproduces its theory of the subject: a polyphonic self written by a polyphony of writers, a parliament composed by a parliament.

I.2 *The Argument*

Three readings dominate the critical conversation. The first, *formalist*, treats the skill system as the literalization of Mikhail Bakhtin's polyphony: Harry Du Bois is a Dostoevskian consciousness whose microdialogue has been externalized into two dozen named interlocutors. The second, *political*, treats the game as an equal-opportunity

satire of ideology whose four quests—communist, fascist, ultraliberal, moralist—expose each position's absurdity. The third, *historicist*, treats it as a document of post-Soviet melancholy, a mourning-play for the twentieth century's defeated futures written from the Baltic periphery. Each reading is correct; none is sufficient, because each isolates one register of a work whose decisive achievement is the rigorous homology of its registers.

The thesis defended here is that *Disco Elysium* constructs a single structural isomorphism across three scales—the psyche, the city, and the world—and that this isomorphism is thermodynamic before it is moral or political. At each scale the game's object is a pattern that exists only by virtue of the flow passing through it, persists only by changing, and perishes not by violent destruction but by the cessation of flow, which physics calls equilibrium. The psyche of Harry Du Bois is such a pattern: "Harry" is nothing other than the persistence of a recognizable configuration in the ceaseless speech of his faculties, and the game ends when that speech can no longer sustain itself, whether through the exhaustion of Health or the collapse of Morale. Revachol is such a pattern: a city that has survived the defeat of its revolution and the occupation of its territory only as the provisional configuration of flows of labour, capital, memory, and grievance, one of which the strike has stopped. The world of the isolas is such a pattern: islands of differentiated matter adrift in the Pale, a grey continuum in which differences dissolve and from which nothing returns.

The figure that unites these scales is the *whirlpool*, and the work has inscribed it in the name of the place where it begins: the Whirling-in-Rags. Several concepts are coined to articulate the argument. *Dissipative polyphony* names a subject constituted as an open system of semi-autonomous voices maintained far from equilibrium; the term fuses Ilya Prigogine's *dissipative structures*—order sustained by the continuous dissipation of energy—with Bakhtin's polyphony, joined at the point where Bakhtin's unfinalizability (*nezavershennost'*) meets Prigogine's openness. The *vortical subject* is the bearer of that structure. The *dissipative commons* names the temporary, rhythmic, collective formations—a dance, a dialogue, a strike, a partnership—through which such subjects jointly sustain difference against equilibrium. The *Phasmid principle* names the ethical disposition proper to entropic times: attention to improbable life. The *Elysian dialectic* names the game's purgatorial trajectory from Lethe (forgetting without purgation) through *anamnesis* (recollection as labour) toward Eunoë (the remembrance of the good). Finally, a *thermodynamic critique of ideology* reads the game's four political visions as four strategies for reaching, freezing, hoarding, or damping equilibrium, against which disco names a fifth possibility: the transformation, in Jacques Rancière's terms, of *police* into *politics*, and in André Lepecki's, of *choreopolice* into *choreopolitics*. The central claim may be put in a single sentence: *Disco Elysium* is the first work in any medium to make the

self, the city, and the cosmos legible as one dissipative structure, and to propose that what saves each of them is not sovereignty but rhythm.

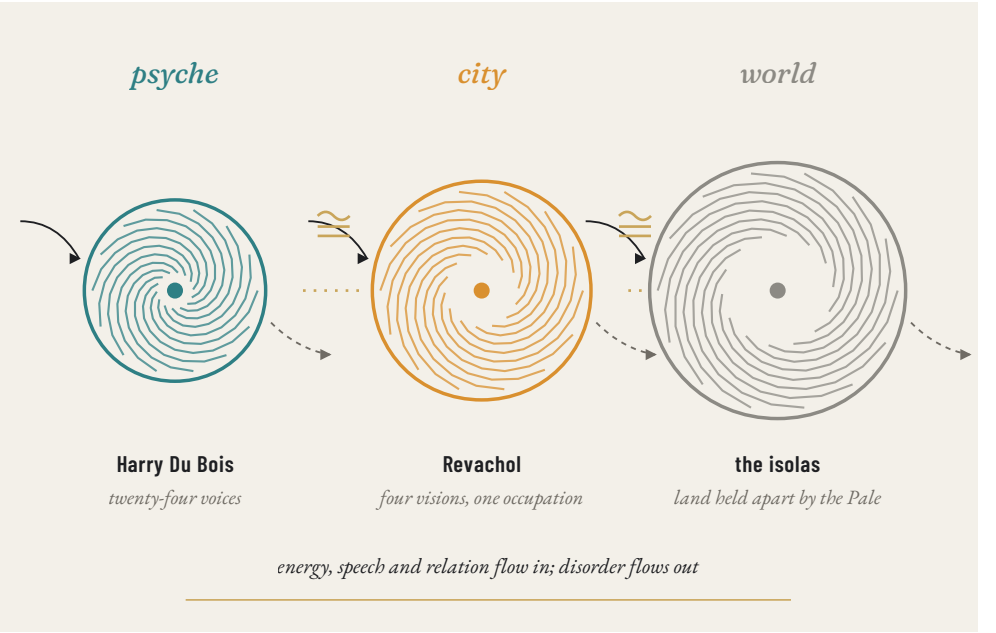


FIGURE I.1 *One structure at three scales.* The thesis reads Harry's psyche, the city of Revachol, and the world of the isolas as dissipative structures: patterns that persist only while energy, speech, and relation flow through them.

I.3 *Method*

Three methods are combined. The first is *comparative mythopoetics* conducted as constellation. In the epistemo-critical prologue to the *Trauerspiel* study (1928), Walter Benjamin proposed that ideas are to objects as constellations are to stars: the critic does not deduce the idea from its instances but draws the figure in which they become legible together. The thesis accordingly distinguishes two orders of claim. Claims of *influence* rest on documentation: the tabletop origin of the setting; the frequently acknowledged precedent of *Planescape: Torment*; the working title borrowed from R. S. Thomas; the studio's name, taken from the Russian Futurist *zaum*; the team's onstage thanks to Marx and Engels; and the list of influences ZA/UM itself published in January 2020, discussed in Chapter 9. Claims of *affinity* are constellations drawn by the critic—Hesse's Harry Haller, Virgil's dancing dead, the Dutch engineer Cornelis Lely—and are claims about the structure of the work and its place within traditions, never about what its author read. The distinction is marked wherever it matters.

The second method is *ludic hermeneutics*, reading mechanics as meaning. It draws on Espen Aarseth's account of ergodic literature (1997), Ian Bogost's procedural rhetoric (2007), Alexander Galloway's allegories of control (2006), and Jesper Juul's theory of failure (2013). Six mechanisms bear the heaviest interpretive load. The two-dice check, in which a double six always succeeds and a double one always fails, installs an ineliminable margin of chance in every act of will; a single thought, The Precarious World, alters even these thresholds. The distinction between *white* checks, which may be retried once the relevant faculty has grown, and *red* checks, which may be attempted only once, encodes the difference between reversible and irreversible time. *Passive* checks, through which a skill speaks unbidden whenever its level clears a hidden threshold, model the unconscious as a threshold function. The *Thought Cabinet* converts ideas into objects that must be incubated before they act. The twin meters of *Health* and *Morale* make despair as lethal as injury. And the game clock, which advances only through speech and action, constructs a chronotope in which talk is time.

The third method is *historical materialism* in Fredric Jameson's sense: the injunction to historicize, and the reading of narrative as a socially symbolic act that resolves in imagination contradictions unresolved in history. The world of Elysium is read against two histories in particular: the post-1991 transition of Estonia from Soviet occupation to radical market liberalization, which formed the generation of its makers; and the history of the 1970s, which ended in 1979 with the backlash against disco and the onset of the neoliberal order. A final methodological commitment concerns the status of philosophy within the work. *Disco Elysium* is not illustrated philosophy. Its ideas are not decorations hung upon a game but positions taken by a system, and the thesis treats the work as a thinking object—one that argues, concedes, contradicts itself, and arrives at conclusions that can be stated, tested, and contested.

The method is not imposed on the work from outside. By its makers' account (Wikipedia), the world of Elysium was constructed with deliberate attention to historical materialism, on the premise that history would unfold in broadly similar ways even if its particulars differed, which is why so many of its names, places, and events have near-parallels in our own history. The constellations drawn in Chapter 4 are therefore readings of a design principle rather than impositions upon it.

1.4 *Genealogy: Tallinn, Zaum, and the Furies*

The world of Elysium originated in tabletop role-playing sessions conducted by Kurvitz and his circle in Tallinn, though accounts of its birth differ. One traces it to the multi-day sessions Kurvitz played with friends as a teenager, in a pseudomedieval world that gradually crept toward the present (Winslow-Yost 2025). The making-of account pub-

lished by GamesRadar in 2020, as summarized on Wikipedia, dates its conception to a drunken evening in 2005, when Kurvitz, then playing in the band Ultramelanhool, imagined it while listening to Tiësto's "Adagio for Strings"; a collective that included Rostov then developed it as a tabletop game modelled on *Dungeons & Dragons*. It grew into a literary and artistic project organized as the ZA/UM cultural association, whose members included Rostov and the writer Martin Luiga.

Kurvitz self-published *The Sacred and Terrible Air* in 2013 with the help of the writer Kaur Kender, later the game's executive producer. Its Estonian edition carried a zero on its spine, the first volume of a series that never continued, and its own plot is an investigation into the past: three boys obsessed with the disappearance of four sisters return to the mystery twenty years later (Winslow-Yost 2025). The novel sold only about a thousand copies. Kurvitz has described the three years that followed as a period of depression and alcoholism; after he recovered, and helped Kender through his own recovery, Kender suggested capturing the world as a video game instead. Work began around 2016, with the team living in a squat in a former Tallinn gallery. Kurvitz's first pitch promised *Dungeons & Dragons* meeting a 1970s cop show, a modern advance on *Planescape: Torment* and *Baldur's Gate*, and "deep, strategic combat"; the finished game abandoned the combat and kept the cop show, and a scrapped tagline called it a role-playing game about being a total failure (Wikipedia). The change of medium was a change of ontology: a novel narrates a world, while a role-playing game asks its reader to inhabit one and to answer, at every juncture, for what they do inside it.

The collective's name derives from *zaum* (заумь), the "transrational" or "beyonsense" language proclaimed by Aleksei Kruchenykh and Velimir Khlebnikov in the Futurist declarations of 1913 and exemplified in Kruchenykh's "Dyr bul shchyl" of the same year: a language released from reference, in which meaning is generated by sound and inner form. Viktor Shklovsky's theory of estrangement in "Art as Device" (1917) grew in part from the same milieu; Boris Groys has shown how the avant-garde's utopia of total transformation was later absorbed and suppressed by the Stalinist state. The name thus binds the studio to a ruin of the revolutionary avant-garde—the very structure of Revachol, a utopia whose afterlife is a name. It binds the work, as well, to a poetics of the voice beneath meaning. The pre-verbal murmur of the Ancient Reptilian Brain and the oneiric glossolalia of Inland Empire belong to the register *zaum* sought: speech that precedes and exceeds the sign. Read as ordinary Russian, the name has a second sense: it recalls the idiom *vzyat'sya za um*, to come to one's senses, which is the plot of the game in four syllables (Wikipedia).

The project's working title, *No Truce With The Furies*, was borrowed from the Welsh poet R. S. Thomas, whose late collection of that name appeared in 1995. The Furies descend from Aeschylus. The *Eumenides* (458 BCE) concludes with Athena founding the

Areopagus, the first court of law, and persuading the Erinyes to become the Kindly Ones—the founding myth of the transformation of vendetta into justice. A world in which there is "no truce" with the Furies is one in which that transformation has failed: guilt remains unreconciled, judgment takes the form of a mercenary tribunal, and the court has been replaced by the administration of an occupier. The renaming to *Disco Elysium* displaced the work's mythic register from Aeschylus to Virgil and Schiller, from pursuit to afterlife, from guilt to the dance, without erasing the first register. The Furies remain present as the voices that hound Harry through Martinaise; the new title proposes that they might be taught to dance.

The working title survives inside the work. A fragment of R. S. Thomas's poem "Reflections", from which it was taken, appears in the game's opening, in lines that make the mirror the Furies' home and warn that even clear water can drown if it is deep enough (Wikipedia). Among the first tasks the game then sets the waking detective is to look at his face in a mirror (Winslow-Yost 2025). The Furies are where Chapter 2 will find them.

Kurvitz has glossed the new title himself: *Disco Elysium*, he has said, means "I learn Elysium" (Winslow-Yost 2025). *Disco* is the first person singular of the Latin *discere*, to learn. The title is therefore a sentence before it is a genre, a first-person verb of learning governing the name of an afterlife, and it anticipates both halves of this thesis: the investigation as recollection (Chapter 3) and the dance as the form of a common life (Chapter 8). The same word names the pupil's act and the dancer's floor.

By the developers' account the title carries a second sense as well: disco as an idea that takes the spotlight for a moment and burns out, like the fad it names (Wikipedia).

Accepting the Fresh Indie Game award in December 2019, the writer Helen Hindpere thanked Mayakovsky, Viktor Tsoi, Marx, and Engels; she has since described the onstage thanks as gratitude for a political education, and attributed the game's strong leftist roots to the creative direction of Kurvitz and Rostov (Platypus Review, 2024). Kurvitz, accepting the Estonian President's Young Cultural Figure award in 2020, credited the modernist poet Arvi Siig, whose vision of an international, radical, and humanist Estonian culture, he said, lives on in the game (Wikipedia). Between them the two declarations name a method, Marx's dialectic, and a value, humanism, whose tension the game never resolves and whose irresolution it makes productive.

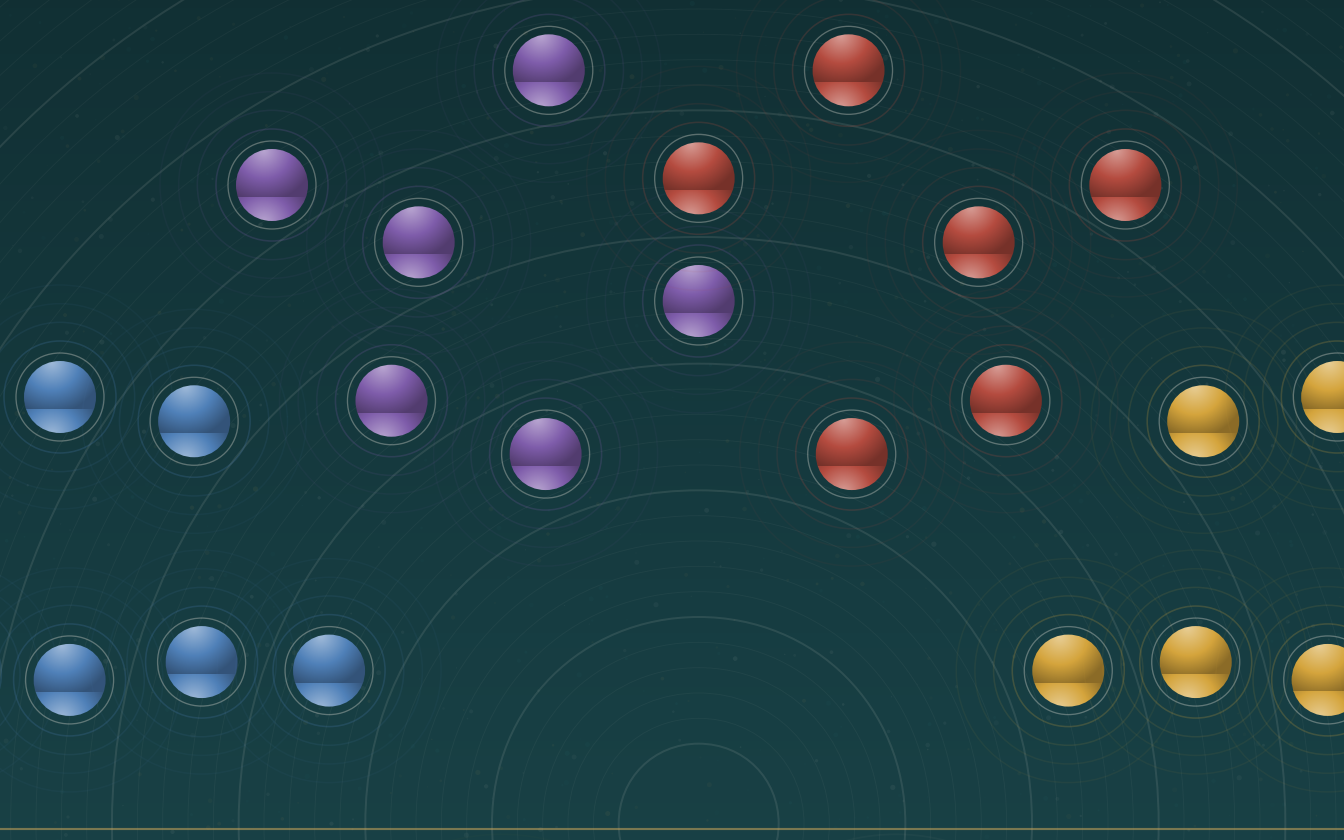
1.5 *Architecture of the Thesis*

Part One, *The Parliament of the Self*, reconstructs the theory of the subject embedded in the skill system. Chapter 1 situates the twenty-four skills within the history of faculty psychology and the literary tradition of the plural self; Chapter 2 reads the opening se-

quence, the mirror, the talking necktie, the Thought Cabinet, and the pharmacology of the faculties through psychoanalysis and phenomenology; Chapter 3 reads amnesia as Lethe and investigation as *anamnesis*. Part Two, *The City as Soul*, develops the city–soul isomorphism: Chapter 4 reconstructs Revachol through Plato, its onomastics, the Paris Commune, and the post-Soviet palimpsest; Chapter 5 analyses the four political visions; Chapter 6 examines the police, the militia, and the Tribunal. Part Three, *The Pale and the Dance*, reads the Pale as entropy (Chapter 7), the disco as Elysium (Chapter 8), and the work's generic and mythic genealogies (Chapter 9). Part Four, *Toward a Dissipative Materialism*, derives the Phasmid principle (Chapter 10) and states the theory of dissipative polyphony in four theses (Chapter 11). A conclusion, a coda on the work's ownership, a selected bibliography, an appendix recording the sources and checks behind the game details, and keywords follow.

PART ONE

The Parliament of the Self



I

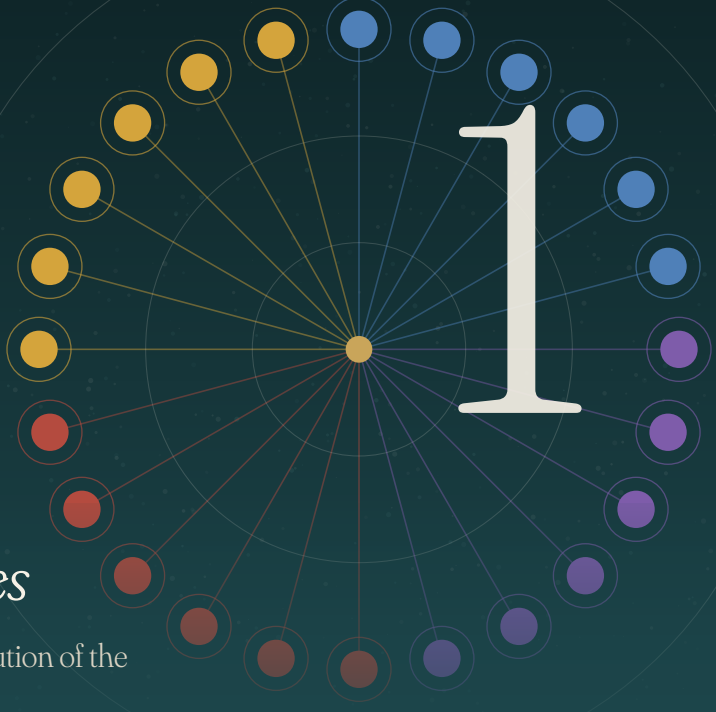
Zwei Seelen wohnen, ach! in meiner Brust.

— Goethe, *Faust I* (1808)

I hazard the guess that man will be ultimately known for a mere polity of multifarious, incongruous and independent denizens.

— Robert Louis Stevenson, *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886)

CHAPTER 1



Twenty-Four Voices

Faculty, Polyphony, and the Dissolution of the Sovereign Subject

The skill system of *Disco Elysium* is a theory of mind, and it intervenes in a dispute that the history of faculty psychology left unresolved: whether the powers of the soul are organs to be located and measured, or voices to be heard. The game answers decisively for the second alternative, and it stages the first, through the race theorist Measurehead, as the founding error of fascism. This chapter reconstructs the genealogy that makes the answer intelligible and argues that the work's refusal to integrate its voices into a sovereign self is not a stylistic eccentricity but its first philosophical position.

1.1 *From Faculty Psychology to the Skill Tree*

The architecture is quaternary. Four attributes govern six skills each. *Intellect* comprises Logic, Encyclopedia, Rhetoric, Drama, Conceptualization, and Visual Calculus. *Psyche* comprises Volition, Inland Empire, Empathy, Authority, Esprit de Corps, and Suggestion. *Physique* comprises Endurance, Pain Threshold, Physical Instrument, Electrochemistry, Shivers, and Half Light. *Motorics* comprises Hand/Eye Coordination, Perception, Reaction Speed, Savoir Faire, Interfacing, and Composure. Beneath and before these twenty-four speak the archaic voices of the Ancient Reptilian Brain and the Limbic System, which address Harry in the darkness that precedes waking and return at the thresholds of death.

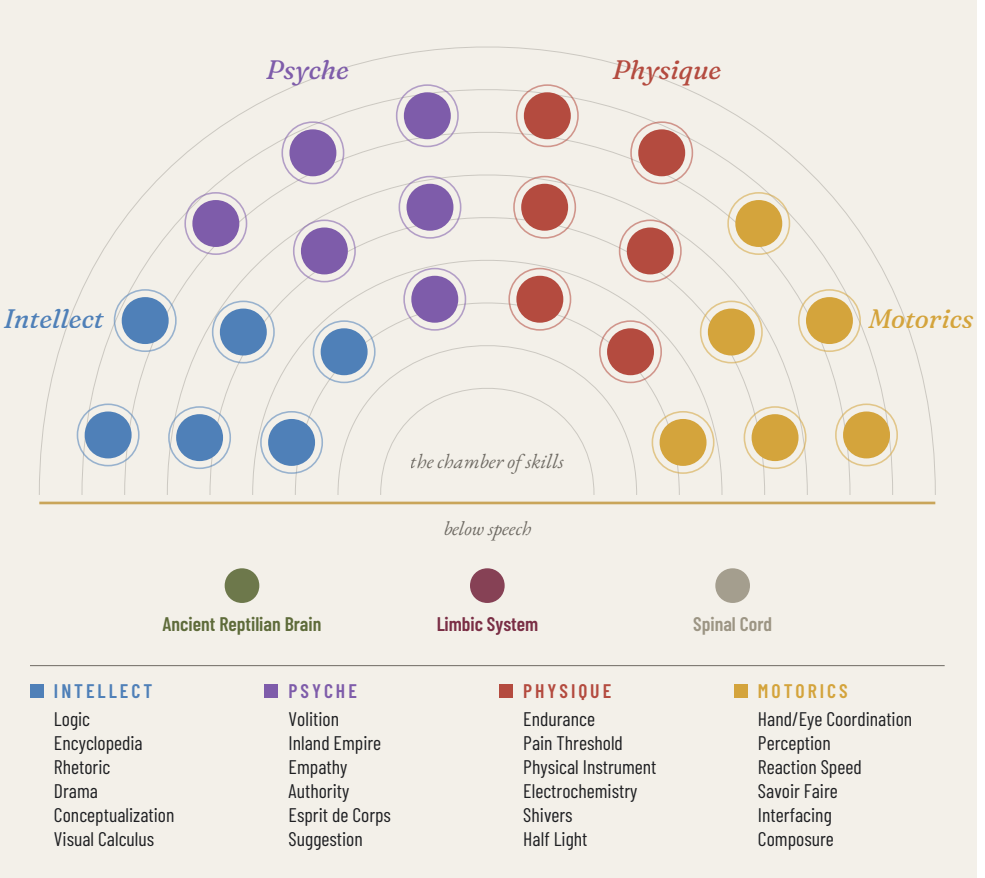


FIGURE 1.1 *The parliament of the self.* The twenty-four skills sit in four blocs of six; beneath the chamber speak the Ancient Reptilian Brain, the Limbic System, and the Spinal Cord, which cannot be levelled or used for checks.

The oldest template is Plato's tripartite soul: the calculating part (*logistikon*), the spirited part (*thumoeides*), and the appetitive part (*epithumetikon*) of *Republic* IV, figured in the *Phaedrus* (246a–254e) as a charioteer struggling to govern a noble and an ignoble horse. Intellect, Psyche, and Physique map onto this triad with suspicious ease, but the fourth attribute breaks the Platonic frame. Motorics recovers a faculty that Aristotle's *De Anima* had included and Plato had neglected: locomotion, the soul's power to move the body through space. The game also modernizes that faculty. Interfacing governs the self's commerce with machines, locks, and radiocomputers; Composure governs its presentation to the gaze of others; Savoir Faire governs its style. Motorics is the faculty psychology of a technical and spectacular age, in which the soul's interface with objects and appearances has become a power in its own right.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) gives the fourth attribute its philosophical warrant. Consciousness, he argued, is originally not a matter of "I think" but of "I can": a motor intentionality through which the body grasps a world it inhabits before it represents it. Motorics is the "I can" given six voices. Antonio Damasio's *Descartes' Error* (1994) supplies the corresponding warrant for Physique. Its somatic markers, bodily states that colour options before deliberation begins, are what Electrochemistry, Half Light, and Shivers report, and their testimony is not a contamination of reason but one of its conditions.

The medieval elaboration of faculty psychology supplies more exact correspondences. In the *Kitāb al-Nafs* of his *Shifāʾ*, Avicenna distinguished five internal senses: common sense, retentive imagination, compositive imagination, estimation (*wahm*), and memory. Estimation is the faculty by which the sheep perceives the wolf's enmity—a non-sensible "intention" (*maʿnā*) apprehended in the sensible. Half Light, which reads threat in every face and urges flight or attack before deliberation can intervene, is Avicennan *wahm* in its pure form; Empathy is the same faculty turned benign, apprehending the intentions of others as grief, shame, or longing rather than as menace. Encyclopedia corresponds to Avicennan memory with one catastrophic subtraction: it retains the intentions of the world—its histories, its trivia, its ideologies—while having lost every intention bearing on the self.

Thomas Aquinas carried the scheme into Latin scholasticism, naming the human form of estimation the *vis cogitativa*, the power that judges particulars (*Summa Theologiae* I, q. 78), and Thomas Reid's *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man* (1785) and *Essays on the Active Powers of Man* (1788) gave faculty psychology its last great systematic statement before Gall turned faculties into organs.

Kant's late treatise *Der Streit der Fakultäten* (1798) concerned the conflict between the faculties of a university—philosophy against theology, law, and medicine. *Disco Elysium* literalizes the pun the title never intended: it is a *conflict of the faculties* in the psychological sense, and the conflict is constitutive rather than accidental. The third *Critique* (1790) had located aesthetic judgment in the free play of imagination and understanding. The game parodies that harmony as a quarrel. Conceptualization, its productive imagination, speaks in the hauteur of an art critic who condemns the derivative and demands that Harry become an artist; Logic answers with the dry contempt of the understanding for whatever cannot be deduced. Their "free play" is a running feud.

The decisive genealogical step is Franz Joseph Gall's organology, systematized with Johann Spurzheim between 1810 and 1819 as phrenology. Gall divided the mind into some twenty-seven faculties, each localized in a cerebral organ whose development could be read from the contours of the skull. Faculty psychology thus bifurcated in the nineteenth century into two descendants. One became the dialogical psychology of the

novel, in which faculties speak; the other became craniometry and race science, in which faculties are measured. Samuel George Morton's *Crania Americana* (1839) and the anthropometry that followed—dismantled by Stephen Jay Gould in *The Mismeasure of Man* (1981)—converted the skull's contours into a hierarchy of peoples. *Disco Elysium* stages both descendants. Harry's faculties are voices; Measurehead, whose very name designates the craniometric act, reads faculties as heritable bumps and ranks races by them; in the game he inspects Kim's skull aloud, bone by bone (see Chapter 5). The game's first ethical decision is therefore formal: faculties are to be heard, not measured.

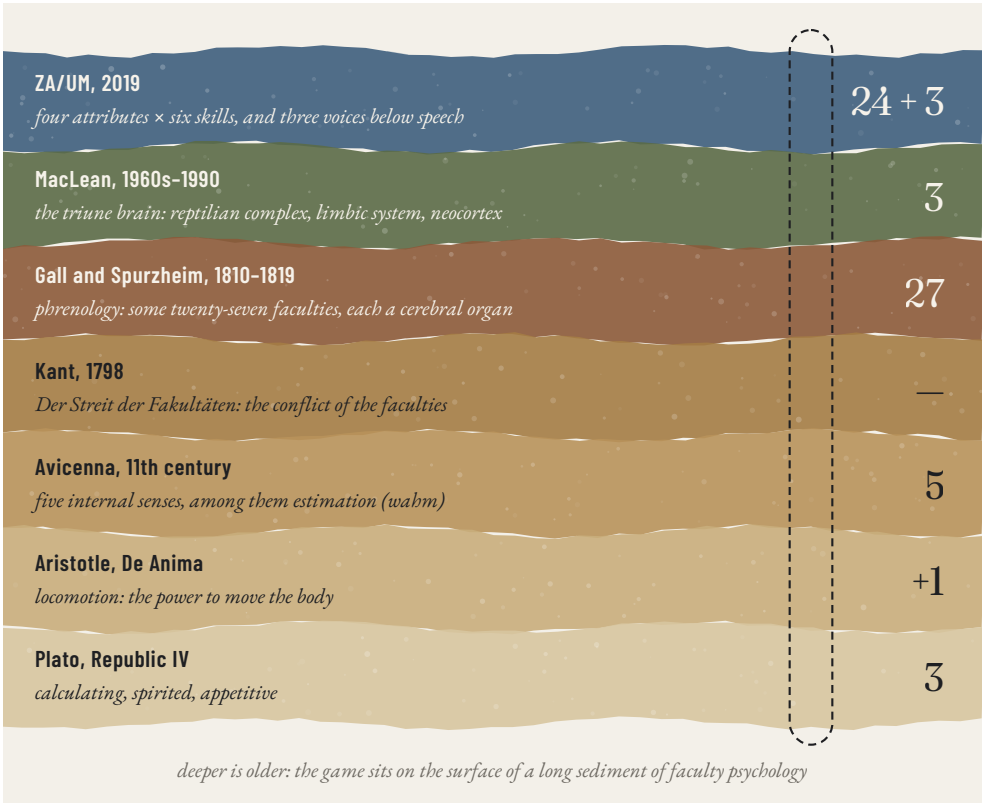


FIGURE 1.2 *Strata of the faculties.* The skill system rests on a long sediment of faculty psychology, from Plato's tripartite soul to Paul MacLean's triune brain; the numbers give how many faculties each scheme distinguishes.

1.2 *The Triune Brain and the Bicameral Voice*

The Ancient Reptilian Brain and the Limbic System derive from the neuroscientist Paul MacLean's model of the *triune brain*, developed from the 1960s and systematized in *The Triune Brain in Evolution* (1990): a reptilian complex governing instinct and territory, a

paleomammalian limbic system governing emotion, and a neomammalian neocortex governing reason. Carl Sagan's *The Dragons of Eden* (1977) carried the model into popular culture, and comparative neuroanatomy has since largely abandoned it; Cesario, Johnson, and Eisthen (2020) summarized the consensus in their title, which denies that the brain is an onion with a reptile at its core. The game's use of a discredited model is therefore not an error but a choice of genre. It treats the triune brain as myth—a cosmogony of the psyche in the manner of Plato's myth of the metals—and gives its strata the voices of chthonic oracles. The Reptilian Brain speaks with the seductive calm of the inorganic, counselling a return to the warm dark where nothing is required. The Limbic System speaks with the raw tenderness of a mammal in pain, its intimacy indistinguishable from injury. In The Final Cut the stratification is audible: Lenval Brown voices the twenty-four skills, while the Ancient Reptilian Brain and the Limbic System are performed by a different actor, Mikee W. Goodman.

The Disco Elysium Wiki classes a third voice, the Spinal Cord, with them. The three are special voices, performed by an actor other than the one who voices the twenty-four skills; they cannot be levelled or used for checks, and they speak mostly when Harry is unconscious, asleep, or incapacitated. The archaeology of this self descends below the brain altogether.

Julian Jaynes's *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind* (1976) proposed that before roughly the end of the second millennium BCE human beings experienced the commands of one cerebral hemisphere as voices of gods heard by the other. Jaynes's paradigm was the *Iliad*. When Athena seizes Achilles by the hair to stop him drawing his sword against Agamemnon (I.193–222), she is, on Jaynes's reading, the voice of the hemisphere that restrains. *Disco Elysium* re-stages the scene as a passive check: Authority urges Harry to assert himself by force, and Volition intervenes to hold him back. The inversion is instructive. In the bicameral mind the voices *command*; in *Disco Elysium* they *petition*. They argue, flatter, plead, sulk, and lose. The work presents a post-bicameral polyphony, in which the voices are neither gods nor fragments of a self but citizens.

1.3 *Polyphony, Heteroglossia, Menippea*

In *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics* (1929; revised 1963) Bakhtin defined the polyphonic novel as a plurality of independent, unmerged consciousnesses, each a fully valid subject rather than an object of the author's finalizing word. He also described the *microdialogue* of Dostoevsky's heroes, whose inner speech is internally split, every word uttered with a sideward glance at an anticipated rejoinder and a loophole left open for retraction. *Disco Elysium* externalizes microdialogue into an interface. Before Harry speaks, a

council of faculties has already spoken, and each voice is "full-valued" in Bakhtin's sense: Empathy may be right where Logic is wrong; Inland Empire's apparently absurd intuitions are vindicated with disquieting regularity; Electrochemistry's appetites are not simply refuted but answered.

The game advances beyond Dostoevsky by fusing polyphony with what Bakhtin, in "Discourse in the Novel" (1934–35), called *heteroglossia* (*raznorechie*): the stratification of a national language into the social languages of professions, classes, generations, and genres. Each skill speaks a sociolect. Physical Instrument speaks like a locker-room coach; Drama like a courtier who calls Harry 'sire' in nearly a hundred lines; Conceptualization like a critic; Electrochemistry like a barker outside a nightclub; Half Light like a tabloid of catastrophe; Esprit de Corps in the cinematic cutaway of police camaraderie; Shivers in a lyrical reportage that belongs to no character at all. The psyche is a parliament of sociolects, and the social world is already inside it before Harry has met a single resident of Martinaise. This is the first appearance of the city–soul isomorphism that Part Two develops: the city speaks within the man before the man walks into the city.

The interface was designed with a social medium in mind. Kurvitz has said that the team wanted a dialogue engine as addictive and snappy as Twitter, with text flowing upward in a narrow column like a feed (Kotaku, 2020). The parliament of the self is rendered in the visual grammar of a timeline, in which every faculty posts and the player scrolls. Bakhtin's heteroglossia has found its contemporary form: the social languages of the city arrive in Harry's head in the shape in which social languages now arrive everywhere.

Bakhtin traced the polyphonic novel to the *Menippean satire*, and his inventory of its features (Chapter 4 of the 1963 edition) reads like a design document for *Disco Elysium*. The menippea, he argued, is comic and free of historical legend. It invents extraordinary situations in order to test an idea. It combines the fantastic and the mystical with a crude "slum naturalism" of taverns, brothels, and roads. It poses ultimate questions. It conducts moral-psychological experimentation on abnormal states—insanity, split personality, unrestrained daydreaming, strange dreams, passions bordering on madness. It favours scandal scenes, eccentric behaviour, and inappropriate speech. It joins oxymoronic contrasts, includes elements of social utopia, inserts other genres, mixes styles, and responds to the topical controversies of its day. Every item is present in Martinaise: the hostel and the harbour; the cryptozoology and the Pale; the questions of history and death; the voices; the outbursts; the karaoke, pamphlets, and books; the ideological vision quests that read as journalism of the present. The genre's founding text even supplies the title's mythic coordinates. Lucian's *True Story* (second century CE) sends its narrator to the Isles of the Blessed, the satirical Elysium where the heroes of Homer and the philosophers loiter in comic immortality, and his *Dialogues of the Dead* stage

the conversations that the game's absurd death screens reprise. A detective who dies of cardiac arrest while trying to retrieve a necktie from a ceiling fan has entered Lucian's underworld, where the eschatological and the ridiculous are a single register.

1.4 *Heteronymy, the Magic Theatre, the Polity*

The literary tradition that renders the self as a multiplicity of complete persons culminates in Fernando Pessoa. Alberto Caeiro, Ricardo Reis, and Álvaro de Campos possess biographies, horoscopes, philosophies, and styles; the assistant bookkeeper Bernardo Soares, author of *The Book of Disquiet*, is a semi-heteronym close to Pessoa himself. In his letter of 13 January 1935 to Adolfo Casais Monteiro, Pessoa recounted the "triumphal day" of 8 March 1914, when Caeiro arrived and wrote through him, and he described his oeuvre as a *drama em gente*, a drama enacted not in acts but in persons. The skills of *Disco Elysium* are heteronyms with one structural difference. Pessoa's heteronyms *write*; Harry's *deliberate*. Pessoa dispersed authorship into persons; Kurvitz disperses agency.

The Final Cut gives the comparison a literal form. A single performer, the jazz musician Lenval Brown, new to acting, voices the narrator and all twenty-four skills, nearly half of the game's dialogue. Over some eight months of recording he kept his voice constant, slow, and meticulous, distinguishing the faculties by small nuances (Wikipedia). One voice divided into many is Pessoa's situation exactly.

The nearest precursor in the European canon is Hermann Hesse's *Der Steppenwolf* (1927), and the homonymy of its protagonist, Harry Haller, with Harry Du Bois is the most precise affinity the comparative record offers. Haller is a middle-aged intellectual undone by self-contempt and drink. The "Treatise on the Steppenwolf" inserted into his papers dismantles his self-diagnosis as a creature of two natures, man and wolf: the dualism is a crude simplification of a manifold composed of hundreds or thousands of selves. In the Magic Theatre, entered at the price of one's reason, the saxophonist Pablo demonstrates the art of life on a chessboard, assembling the figures into which Haller's personality has been dismantled into ever-new arrangements. A mirror shatters Haller into innumerable Harrys. Hermine teaches him to dance. The correspondences are structural. Character creation in *Disco Elysium*, which offers prefabricated arrangements under the names *Thinker*, *Sensitive*, and *Physical* or a bespoke distribution of points, is Pablo's chessboard. The mirror scene at the game's opening is Haller's shattering, taken up in Chapter 2. And the dance, deferred and longed for across the whole of Martinaise, is Hermine's lesson. The difference is as instructive as the likeness. Haller's education is aesthetic and mystical, culminating in the cold, ironic laughter of the Immortals. Du Bois's is ethical and political, culminating in the question of whether he can work, and live, with others.

Stevenson's Jekyll supplies the word that binds these traditions to the political argument of this thesis. Man, Jekyll guesses, will be known at last as a *polity* of incongruous and independent denizens. *Disco Elysium* is the realization of that polity, and the word must be taken literally: the self is a constitution. The French tradition adds the decisive historical index. In two letters of May 1871, to Georges Izambard on the 13th and to Paul Demeny on the 15th, Arthur Rimbaud wrote that *Je est un autre* and called for the poet to make himself a seer by a long, immense, and reasoned *dérèglement de tous les sens*. Those letters were written during the last weeks of the Paris Commune, between its proclamation in March and its annihilation in the *Semaine sanglante* at the end of May. The modern poetics of the plural self and the modern politics of the commune were born in the same city in the same weeks. Harry's binge is a derangement of the senses that is neither reasoned nor visionary, and Revachol's revolution is a commune that was crushed. The isomorphism this thesis attributes to *Disco Elysium* has its first literary witness in the Paris of 1871.

1.5 *Bundles, Aggregates, and the Amnesiac Person*

The philosophical correlate of heteronymy is the bundle theory of the self. In the *Treatise of Human Nature* (1739, I.iv.6) David Hume, searching within for a self, found only particular perceptions, and concluded that the mind is "nothing but a bundle or collection of different perceptions." He offered the image of a theatre in which perceptions successively appear, pass, glide away, and mingle, and then immediately withdrew it: there are only the perceptions, and we have not the most distant notion of the place where the scenes are represented. *Disco Elysium* builds Hume's theatre—it gives the stage a frame in the dialogue panel and the performers names—while honouring Hume's caveat. There is no Harry behind the voices. "Harry" is the provisional name for whatever the voices, and the player, have most recently made him.

The Buddhist doctrine of *anātman* (Pāli *anattā*) arrived at the same conclusion two millennia earlier and drew from it an ethics rather than a scepticism. The person is a designation for five aggregates (*skandha*): form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. In the *Milindapañha*, the monk Nāgasena answers King Milinda's challenge by asking whether the chariot is its pole, its axle, its wheels, or its frame, and concludes that "chariot" is a conventional name for an assembly of parts, as "Nāgasena" is. Harry is a chariot of twenty-four parts, and the game makes the convention visible by allowing the player to name him—Harry, or the aliases he invents, from Raphaël Ambrosius Costeau, which Conceptualization and the Horrific Necktie urge on him as a chance to begin life anew as a classier person, to Tequila Sunset, which Electrochemistry finds dangerously cool.

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) gave the bundle tradition its rigorous modern form. Personal identity, Parfit argued, is not what matters in survival; what matters is Relation R, psychological connectedness and continuity, which can hold in degrees. Amnesia is the paradigm case in which connectedness is severed while bodily and dispositional continuity persists, and Harry is a Parfitian thought experiment staged at length. The cognitive psychology of memory sharpens the case. Endel Tulving's distinction (1972) between *episodic* memory, which remembers one's own past experiences, and *semantic* memory, which remembers facts about the world, maps precisely onto Harry's condition: Encyclopedia retains vast semantic stores, procedural skills survive intact, and the episodic record is gone. The faculties are older than the self; they remember how to do what Harry cannot remember having done. Parfit described his conversion to reductionism as an escape from a glass tunnel whose walls disappeared. Harry's amnesia is an involuntary Parfitian liberation, with its attendant danger. If connectedness is what matters, the post-binge Harry is only weakly answerable for the man who drove his car into the sea, and the question of his responsibility for a past he cannot remember—taken up in Chapter 3—becomes the moral crux of the work.

Two computational models complete the bundle tradition and mark its limit. Marvin Minsky's *The Society of Mind* (1986) described intelligence as the product of innumerable simple agents, none of them intelligent. Daniel Dennett's *Consciousness Explained* (1991) replaced the Cartesian theatre with a model of multiple drafts, and his essay "The Self as a Center of Narrative Gravity" (1992) treated the self as a theorist's fiction, as useful and as unreal as a centre of gravity in physics. *Disco Elysium* agrees with both that there is no homunculus at the centre, and departs from both in one respect: its agents are not mechanisms but characters. They have styles, loyalties, and grudges; they can be wrong in interesting ways and right for bad reasons. The game replaces the society of mind with a society of persons, and the difference is the difference between a theory of cognition and a theory of the polity.

1.6 *Against the Cure*

The modern clinical imagination has tended to treat the divided self as a pathology whose cure is integration. William James, in *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (1902), devoted two lectures to "The Sick Soul" and one to "The Divided Self, and the Process of Its Unification," in which conversion appears as the unification of a self at war with itself. Freud's *New Introductory Lectures* (1933) closed their account of the psychical personality with the programme *Wo Es war, soll Ich werden*, "where id was, there ego shall be," and compared that work of culture to the draining of the Zuider Zee, an image to which Chapter 4 returns with some force. Even the therapeutic models nearest to the

game's picture of the mind, such as the Internal Family Systems approach Richard Schwartz developed in the 1990s, aim at a harmony of "parts" led by a central Self.

Disco Elysium refuses the cure. No ending fuses the skills into a single voice, and no achievement rewards their silence. A Harry who has slept, eaten, abstained, and been made to face himself does not hear fewer voices; he hears them better, and they speak to better effect. Improvement is figured not as the restoration of a sovereign but as the reform of a government. Lacan's rereading of Freud's maxim, which turns it from a programme of conquest into the injunction that the subject must come to be where the unconscious already was, comes closer to the game's position. The frontispiece of Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) depicts a sovereign whose body is composed of innumerable tiny subjects beneath a single crowned head. *Disco Elysium* depicts the obverse: a body of voices without a crowned head, in which the player is not the sovereign but something nearer to the Speaker of a parliament, the officer who calls members to the floor, cannot vote, and is nonetheless responsible for the order of the house.

The Cartesian subject of the *Second Meditation*, the thinking thing certain of itself prior to world and body, is thereby displaced by a plural *res cogitantes* whose certainty is never prior to the world, because the world is already speaking inside it. The theory of the subject that emerges may be called *constitutional polyphony*. Its ethical wager, on which the rest of this thesis builds, is that the remedy for a ruined self is not sovereignty but good government, and that the same is true of ruined cities.

CHAPTER 2



The Mirror, the Necktie, and the Cabinet

Psychoanalytic and Phenomenological Readings

If Chapter 1 described the constitution of the self, this chapter reads its founding scenes and its institutions: the birth of the subject from the death drive, its first encounter with its image, its first temptation by an object, the cabinet in which it stores ideas, the drugs and garments that modulate its faculties, and the twin meters that measure whether it can go on. Each is a site where the game condenses a body of theory into a mechanism, and each prepares the political reading of Part Two by showing that the self's persistence is never self-grounded.

2.1 *The Primal Scene of the Death Drive*

Disco Elysium begins before the world, in darkness, with voices that have not yet been assigned to a body. The Ancient Reptilian Brain speaks first. In a register of almost tender quietism it informs the nascent subject that there is nothing, that nothing is required of it any longer, and—in the most quoted joke of the opening—that this primordial void contains no ex-wives. The Limbic System answers with the wet intimacy of an injury. It pictures the world that awaits him as a giant ball on which evil apes are fighting, and when he calls this sad it tells him that he drowned in that sadness long ago (Winslow-Yost 2025). The player's first acts are responses to these voices, and only by answering them does the subject consent to wake.

The scene is a primal scene in an extended sense. Freud's *Urszene* was the child's witnessing of parental coitus, the fantasized origin of its own existence; here the subject witnesses its own emergence from the inorganic. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) Freud proposed that the compulsion to repeat betrays a drive more primordial than pleasure: a conservative tendency of the living organism to restore an earlier state, ultimately the inanimate condition from which life arose. He adopted from Barbara Low the term *Nirvana principle* for the tendency to reduce internal excitation to zero, and he acknowledged Schopenhauer as a predecessor. Book IV of *The World as Will and Representation* (1818) had made the denial of the will the summit of ethics. The Ancient Reptilian Brain is the death drive given a voice and a sense of humour, and its counsel is Schopenhauerian quietism stripped of ascetic heroism: not the saint's renunciation but the drunk's preference for unconsciousness.

The game's answer to that counsel is not argued but enacted. To play at all is to have chosen against the Reptile, and the first verdict of the work is therefore a verdict for Eros, delivered before the subject has a name. Kierkegaard's *Either/Or* (1843) made the choice of oneself the founding act of the ethical life, and Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927) described *Dasein* as thrown (*geworfen*) into a world it did not choose. Harry is thrown in the most literal sense: into a bedroom he has wrecked, a body he has poisoned, and a case he does not know he has. The opening of Camus's *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942) opens by declaring that there is only one truly serious philosophical problem, suicide, since to judge whether life is worth living is to answer the fundamental question of philosophy. *Disco Elysium* poses that question procedurally, in its first minute, and answers it the only way a game can—by continuing.

Precision requires naming what the Reptile proposes. Its counsel is not rest but extinction: that the subject decline to wake at all, which, addressed to a man who has just spent three days on a self-destructive binge, begun the night he was assigned the case and traced by his usual partner, Jean Vicquemare, to his fiancée's leaving him years before, is a counsel of death. The game does not keep the theme implicit: critics have noted that it gives Harry explicit suicidal ideation at several points, though it never states that the binge was itself an attempt on his life. The opening stages in comic form the temptation the rest of the game treats in earnest—despair as a voice within the self, given the floor and then outvoted—and the Morale meter discussed in section 2.6 is that voice's standing threat. Outside unconsciousness, the Reptile speaks only when Harry dances in the ravers' church, and a successful karaoke performance comes out in its voice: the voice of extinction is also the voice of the dance (see section 8.6). On the first night the same counsel returns in a nightmare as Harry's own corpse, which tells him that everything is hopeless and that he will fail (sections 6.4 and 8.5).

2.2 *The Mirror Stage in Reverse*

Among the first objects Harry encounters in his room is a mirror. In it he meets a face he does not recognize, ravaged by age, drink, and neglect, and around the image his faculties gather as commentators, each reading the ruin in its own idiom. Jacques Lacan's "The Mirror Stage as Formative of the Function of the I" (1949) describes the infant, still uncoordinated, jubilantly assuming its specular image as a unified form, an "Ideal-I" that anticipates a mastery the body does not yet possess. The identification is constitutive and alienating at once: the ego is founded on an image of wholeness that conceals the *corps morcelé*, the body in pieces, which returns in dreams of dismemberment and in the paintings of Bosch.

Harry's mirror stage runs in reverse. The image does not cover the body in pieces; it exhibits it, and the voices articulate the fragmentation the infant's jubilation would have suppressed. Where the Lacanian infant receives a false unity from the mirror, the amnesiac adult receives a true multiplicity. The Ideal-I is not given at the start of the game. It is something the player may or may not choose to construct, through the copotypes discussed in Chapter 6 and the grandiose personae—Superstar, Apocalypse, Art—that Harry tries on like garments.

The mirror also returns a mask. Harry's face is locked in a strained grin the game calls the Expression, and a successful check reveals its origin: an imitation of the signature smile of Guillaume le Million, a disco star of the decade when, for a fleeting moment after the revolution, the free market seemed the uncontested way of life. The Expression, the game concludes, is a relic (Winslow-Yost 2025). The Ideal-I that the mirror offers Harry is not his own but a dead celebrity's commodity smile, the face of a market euphoria that has passed. In the terms of Deleuze and Guattari, the face Harry wears was produced by a social machine before he put it on.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's seventh plateau, "Year Zero: Faciality" (*A Thousand Plateaus*, 1980), describes the face as a social machine, a "white wall/black hole" system that produces subjectivity by overcoding the body, and proposes that the task is to dismantle the face. Harry's face has been dismantled by drink before the game begins. His project is not to escape the face but to learn to wear the one he has; it is no accident that Composure, the faculty that manages the face before others, is also the faculty most concerned with clothing and with the refusal to weep in public.

Two literary awakenings frame the scene. Kafka's *The Metamorphosis* (1915) opens with Gregor Samsa waking from uneasy dreams transformed into vermin; Harry wakes transformed into a ruin, and like Gregor he must first master a body that no longer obeys. Philip K. Dick's *Flow My Tears, the Policeman Said* (1974) opens with Jason Tav-

erner, a celebrity, waking in a seedy hotel in a police state in which no record of his existence survives. The novel's other centre is Police General Felix Buckman, whose grief at the death of his sister undoes him: in the book's final movement he weeps and embraces a stranger at an all-night service station. Harry Du Bois is both of Dick's men at once—the self-proclaimed superstar no one recognizes, and the policeman who cannot stop weeping.

Two further frames complete the scene. Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) located the origin of ethics in the face of the other, whose exposure commands, before any argument, that I not kill. Harry's first face is his own, and the mirror withholds that command; it arrives only with the faces of others—Kim's, the hanged man's, the deserter's—from which the game does not let him look away. David Lynch's *Lost Highway* (1997), in which a man convicted of his wife's murder wakes in his cell as another man, gives the psychogenic fugue its cinematic form. Harry's amnesia is a fugue without the second identity, which the player must supply.

2.3 *Mephistopheles as Accessory*

The first talking object in *Disco Elysium* is a necktie, flung onto the blades of a ceiling fan during the binge and retrievable only at some risk to the heart. Through Inland Empire it speaks: a sardonic, hedonistic, conspiratorial voice that urges Harry toward the bottle and the dance floor and mocks his scruples. In Goethe's *Faust I* (1808) the black poodle that follows Faust home from his Easter walk swells and dissolves to reveal Mephistopheles, and Faust exclaims, *Das also war des Pudels Kern!*—so that was the poodle's core. The Horrific Necktie is the poodle's core in the age of the commodity: a fashion accessory whose kernel is a tempter.

The association with the commodity is exact. In the first chapter of *Capital* (1867), Marx described the table that, once it emerges as a commodity, "not only stands with its feet on the ground, but, in relation to all other commodities, it stands on its head, and evolves out of its wooden brain grotesque ideas, far more wonderful than 'table-turning' ever was." A few pages later he imagined the commodity's speech: "Could commodities themselves speak, they would say..." *Disco Elysium* lets them speak. The necktie's counsel is the counsel of the commodity form itself—expenditure, pleasure, display—and its mockery of Harry's conscience is the fetish's indifference to its owner. Inland Empire, which extends speech to the tie, to a corpse, to the city, and to the cryptid, is an animism that has learned from Marx: the voices of things are social relations in disguise.

The tempter's idiom is precise. In *The Final Cut* the necktie addresses Harry as *bratan*, Russian slang for brother, a word that carries to a post-Soviet ear the swagger of the 1990s street. The commodity's Mephistopheles speaks the dialect of the market that

replaced the Soviet world, which is to say the dialect of the transition discussed in Chapter 4.

James Joyce's "Circe" episode in *Ulysses* (1922), set in the brothels of Nighttown, is the high-modernist precedent for this animism. There a cake of lemon soap sings, and Bella Cohen's fan flirts with Bloom in the moment before his masochistic transformation. A tie hung on a ceiling fan is Joyce's fan taken literally. The other precedent is David Lynch, whose film *Inland Empire* (2006) the skill's name recalls, and whose *Twin Peaks* (1990–91) gave the detective genre its first institutionalized mystic in Special Agent Dale Cooper, who interrogates dreams, throws stones at bottles to select suspects, and listens to a woman who listens to a log. Inland Empire makes Cooper's method a faculty and assigns it a numerical value. Contemporary materialisms give the animism a philosophical warrant. Bruno Latour's actor-network theory (*Reassembling the Social*, 2005) treats objects as actants, and Jane Bennett's *Vibrant Matter* (2010) attributes to things a "thing-power" that resists the model of inert stuff. In the dissipative ontology developed in Part Four, matter is never inert, and the talking tie is its first, comic witness.

The comparison is closer than analogy. In *Disco Elysium* the ceiling fan itself is given lines. When Harry strains toward the tie on its blades and fears a heart attack, the same mockery, that none of this is a real heart attack and that he should probably just exercise more, is spoken in one variant by Pain Threshold and in another by the ceiling fan. Joyce gave a fan a voice in a brothel hallucination; Kurvitz gives one a voice in a hostel hangover.

2.4 *The Thought Cabinet: Wunderkammer, Memory Palace, Ministry*

The Thought Cabinet is the game's most original mechanism. In conversation Harry discovers ideas—*Hobocop*, *Volumetric Shit Compressor*, *Jamais Vu*, *Mazovian Socio-Economics*, *Advanced Race Theory*, *Indirect Modes of Taxation*, *Rigorous Self-Critique*, and dozens more. He may place them in a limited number of slots, where they must be researched over hours of game time before they are internalized, at which point they alter his faculties, frequently at a cost. A thought may sharpen one skill and blunt another; an ideology may grant eloquence while impairing perception. Ideas are objects, ideas take time, and ideas have prices.

The cabinet has a constitution. The game contains fifty-three thoughts, some mutually exclusive, and only twelve can be internalized at once; it begins with three open slots, and every further slot, like every act of forgetting, costs a skill point. Forgetting a thought frees its slot and discards it for good. In this economy Lethe has a price.

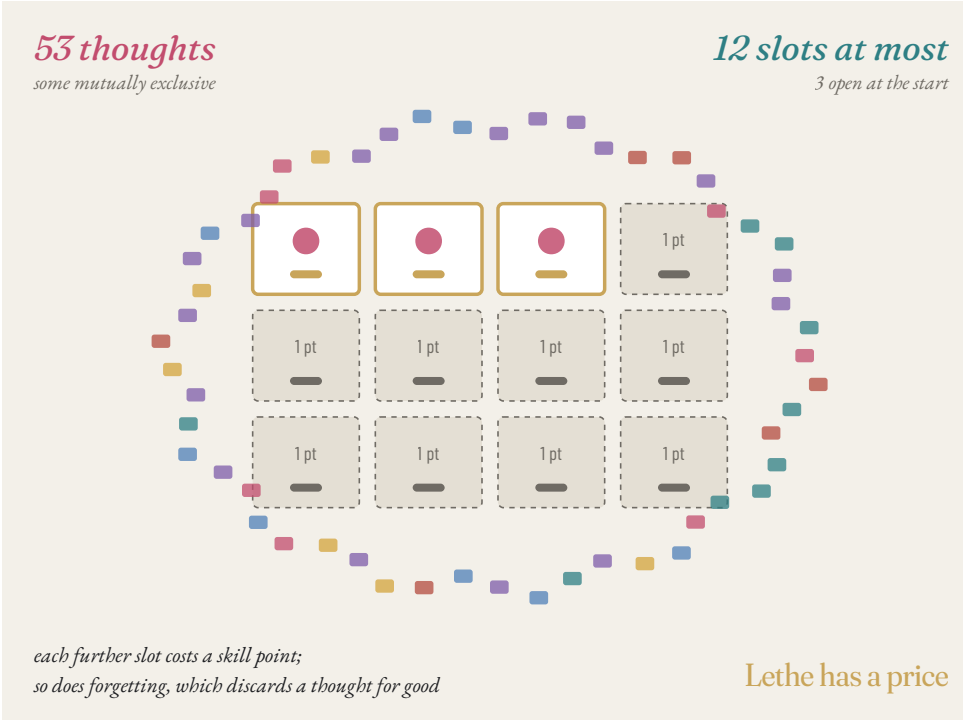


FIGURE 2.1 *The cabinet's constitution.* Fifty-three thoughts compete for at most twelve slots, three of them open at the start; every further slot, and every act of forgetting, costs a skill point.

The cabinet's name contains three histories. The first is the *Wunderkammer*, the cabinet of curiosities of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries—Ole Worm's collection catalogued in the *Museum Wormianum* of 1655 is the canonical instance—which arranged *naturalia*, *artificialia*, and *mirabilia* in a single cosmos of wonder. Harry's thoughts are curiosities of exactly this kind: natural (a theory of the spine), artificial (a theory of taxation), and marvellous (a theory of the cryptid). The second is the art of memory, which Frances Yates reconstructed in *The Art of Memory* (1966) from Cicero's story in *De Oratore* of Simonides, who identified the crushed guests of a collapsed banquet hall by remembering where each had sat. The tradition runs through Giordano Bruno's memory wheels to the Jesuit Matteo Ricci's palace of memory, studied by Jonathan Spence (1984). The Thought Cabinet is a memory palace built by a man without memory, a set of rooms in which he deposits not what he was but what he might become.

The third history is political. In *The English Constitution* (1867) Walter Bagehot described the cabinet as "a combining committee—a hyphen which joins, a buckle which fastens, the legislative part of the State to the executive part of the State." In Harry's

polity the skills are the legislature, endlessly debating, and his action is the executive; the Thought Cabinet is the buckle that fastens deliberation to conduct. The ideologies of Revachol enter it literally as ministers, and their incubation is a parliamentary process: a programme becomes policy only after a period of deliberation, and its implementation reshapes the balance of the house. Two further frames complete the picture. Robert Musil's *The Man Without Qualities* (1930–43) opposed to the "sense of reality" a "sense of possibility" (*Möglichkeitssinn*), and named Ulrich's practice of living hypotheses experimentally "essayism"; the Thought Cabinet is essayism mechanized. Graham Wallas's *The Art of Thought* (1926) divided creative thinking into preparation, incubation, illumination, and verification, and the game renders incubation as clock time—a reminder, in Marx's idiom, that thought too is produced, and that its production consumes the hours of a life.

2.5 *Pharmaka of the Faculties*

Harry's faculties are not fixed endowments. They are modulated by substances and garments. Alcohol temporarily strengthens Physique; speed strengthens Motorics; cigarettes strengthen Intellect; the fictional drug Pyrholidon strengthens Psyche. Each boost is paid for in Health, Morale, or dependency, and each garment—a jacket, a pair of boots, a hat, the Horrific Necktie—raises some skills and lowers others. The self is prosthetic all the way down.

Electrochemistry formalizes appetite as obligation. It issues journal tasks of its own: find smokes and smoke them, find booze and drink it, find speed and sniff it, find pyrholidon and slurp it. The hungry ghost is also a quest-giver, and the player's ledger of duties includes the duty to relapse.

The philosophical frame is the *pharmakon*. In the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), Socrates tells how the god Theuth offered writing to King Thamus as a remedy for memory, and how Thamus refused it: "this discovery of yours will create forgetfulness in the learners' souls, because they will not use their memories; they will trust to the external written characters and not remember of themselves" (Jowett's translation). Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) showed that the Greek *pharmakon* signifies both remedy and poison, and that it is shadowed by *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from the city to purify it—a figure to which the hanged man of Chapter 6 returns. Bernard Stiegler's *Technics and Time, 1: The Fault of Epimetheus* (1994) reread the myth in Plato's *Protagoras* in which Epimetheus distributes qualities to the animals and forgets to keep any for humankind, so that Prometheus must steal fire to supplement the oversight. The human being, for Stiegler, is constitutively a being of default (*défaut*), whose faculties

exist only through technical supplements that are always pharmacological, curative and toxic at once.

Harry is the Epimethean man in extremity: a being whose qualities have been forgotten and must be supplemented by drugs, clothes, thoughts, and—most importantly, as Chapter 3 shows—the notebook of another man. The game's treatment of addiction follows from this pharmacology. It does not moralize; Kim registers Harry's choices to drink or abstain, and the faculties themselves divide over them. Electrochemistry, the voice of appetite, is not a demon but a lobbyist within the parliament of the self, a constituency with real interests and a gift for persuasion. The physician Gabor Maté borrowed the Buddhist image of the *hungry ghost*—the *preta*, with its vast belly and needle-thin throat—to describe addiction as the response of a wounded organism to unbearable pain (*In the Realm of Hungry Ghosts*, 2008). Electrochemistry is the hungry ghost seated in Harry's parliament, and the game's compassion lies in giving it the floor without granting it the government.

2.6 *Morale, Despair, and the Sickness unto Death*

Harry possesses two meters of life. Health, governed by Endurance, measures the integrity of the body; Morale, governed by Volition, measures the integrity of the will. Either may fail. A wound can kill him; the game's generic game-over text narrates a slide into a mute darkness and announces death. Humiliation, grief, or a revelation he cannot bear does something stranger. When Morale is exhausted, the game stages a last exchange with Volition and closes on a newspaper report of a man who has given up rather than died; in one such ending he is said to have lost his mind and to be living under a bridge. The design insists that despair is as final as injury by making both meters equally visible and equally depletable, and it insists on their difference by refusing despair the dignity of a death.

Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) defines the self as a relation that relates itself to itself, and despair as a misrelation within that relation. Despair takes three forms: ignorance of having a self, not willing to be oneself, and defiantly willing to be oneself. Harry passes through all three in the course of Martinaise. Kierkegaard's most anguished paradox is that despair is a "sickness unto death" not because it kills but because it does not: the despairing self longs to die and cannot, condemned to the perpetual dying of a relation that will not dissolve. *Disco Elysium* literalizes the paradox without revising it. Its Morale ending is not a death. The self survives, under a bridge in one ending, as a relation that has ceased to relate itself to itself; the game ends and the man goes on, which is exactly Kierkegaard's sickness unto death, a dying that cannot

die. Despair can kill others, as Chapter 11 shows in the case of Ruby, but it does not grant its own sufferer the release of an ending.

Volition, the faculty that governs Morale, is Spinoza's *conatus*. "Everything, in so far as it is in itself, endeavours to persist in its own being," runs the sixth proposition of *Ethics* III (1677; Elwes's translation); the endeavour is not a property of the thing but its actual essence. Volition is the steadiest voice in the parliament, the one that reminds Harry, against the consensus of the house, that he is worth preserving. Kierkegaard's cure for despair was faith, in which the self rests transparently in the power that established it. *Disco Elysium* offers no such vertical transcendence. It offers a horizontal one: the self rests in another person, whose presence restores Morale more reliably than any substance, and in the encounter with improbable life that closes the game. Part One therefore ends where Part Two must begin. A self whose persistence depends on relation is already a political entity, and its ruin and repair cannot be understood apart from the ruin and repair of the city in which it lives.

CHAPTER 3

3

Lethe, Anamnesis, Eunoë

The Investigation as Recollection

Tzvetan Todorov's "Typology of Detective Fiction" (1966) observed that the classical whodunit contains two stories: the story of the crime, which is absent, and the story of the investigation, which is present and whose sole function is to reconstruct the first. *Disco Elysium* multiplies the absent story. Behind the investigation of the hanged man lies a second crime-story, Harry's own past, which he must reconstruct from the testimony of strangers; behind both lies a third, the history of Revachol's revolution and its defeat, which the case gradually exhumes. The game is a triple *anamnesis*, and this chapter argues that its structure is purgatorial: it moves from a forgetting that has not been earned, through recollection as labour, toward the possibility of a forgetting that would be a release.

3.1 *The Choice of Lives*

The myth that closes Plato's *Republic* (614b–621d) recounts the vision of Er, a soldier who returned from death to describe the afterlife. The souls awaiting rebirth are summoned before Lachesis, receive lots that determine the order of their choosing, and select from a field of patterns of life—tyrannies, obscurities, the lives of animals and of athletes. Having chosen, they cross the plain of Lethe and drink from the River of Unmindfulness (*Amelēs*); those whom wisdom does not restrain drink more than they need, and forget everything. The last soul to choose is that of Odysseus, who, cured of

ambition by the memory of his labours, searches for the neglected life of a private man without cares and declares that he would have chosen it even had his lot been first.

Character creation in *Disco Elysium* is the choice of lives. The player selects among patterns—the *Thinker*, the *Sensitive*, the *Physical*, or a bespoke distribution—and the soul so constituted awakens having drunk of Amelēs. Yet the game inverts the myth's temporal order. Er's souls choose a future life and then forget the past; the player chooses a past self—the faculties Harry must already have possessed—after he has forgotten it. The choice is retroactive. It does not determine who Harry will become so much as who he will turn out to have been, and the investigation that follows is the discovery of the consequences of a choice made, as it were, before memory. Odysseus's choice finds an echo too. Among the dispositions the player may cultivate is a humble, functional competence, without grandeur, that the game's most self-aware voices quietly honour; Chapter 6 reads it as the ethical dignity of the "boring" cop.

3.2 *Du Bois in the Dark Wood*

The *Commedia* opens with its pilgrim lost in the middle of life: *Nel mezzo del cammin di nostra vita / mi ritrovai per una selva oscura, / ché la diritta via era smarrita* (Inferno I.1–3). The protagonist of *Disco Elysium* is a man in middle age whose surname, Du Bois, means "of the wood." Whether or not the echo was intended, it organizes the work with remarkable precision. Harry wakes in the dark wood of himself, the straight way lost; he is given a guide; and his guide has limits.

Kim Kitsuragi is Harry's Virgil. Like Dante's guide he is the embodiment of a dignified, rational, secular virtue, the best that an order without grace can produce. He knows the terrain, enforces method, rebukes and protects, and, crucially, cannot follow his charge everywhere: as Virgil must leave Dante at the threshold of the earthly paradise, Kim's companionship is bounded by procedure, by his own precinct, and by a reserve he seldom abandons. The absent beloved is Dora Ingerlund, Harry's former fiancée, whom he habitually calls his ex-wife, and she occupies the position of Beatrice: never present, constantly invoked, and sublimated in Harry's delirium into the figure of Dolores Dei, one of the setting's *Innocences*, whose cult is modelled on the Marian devotion of the *Mater Dolorosa*. Harry's love is a Beatrician love that has failed to become a theology and curdled into a pathology.

Two psychoanalytic constellations sharpen the figure of the absent beloved. In C. G. Jung's psychology the *anima* is the image of the feminine that a man projects onto real women and divine figures alike, and the *persona* is the mask the ego presents to society (*Two Essays on Analytical Psychology*, 1928). Harry's Dora is anima-projection in pure form, migrating from the woman he lost to the saint he venerates and to Klaasje, and his

copotypes are personae. The name also recalls the most famous failed analysis in psychoanalysis. In "Fragment of an Analysis of a Case of Hysteria" (1905), Freud's patient "Dora" broke off her treatment after eleven weeks, and Freud conceded in a postscript that he had failed to master the transference; Lacan's "Intervention on Transference" (1951) read the case as Freud's failure to recognize what Dora was seeking. Harry's Dora is likewise the object his analysis cannot master, and his anamnesis succeeds only when it stops trying to possess her.

Martinaise is a purgatory more than an inferno, because its sufferers are still in motion and capable of change. Its sins can be distributed among Dante's terraces: Harry's gluttony and wrath, the union boss's avarice, the mercenaries' pride, the acedia that hangs over the district's idlers. The most exact correspondence is envy. On the second terrace of the *Purgatorio* (XIII.70–72), the envious have their eyelids sewn shut with iron wire, like wild hawks being tamed, because *invidia* derives from *in-videre*, to look upon with hostility. The murderer of *Disco Elysium* is an old man, once a political commissar of the Commune's army, who has watched Klaasje from a sniper's nest in a ruined sea fort, nursing a psychosexual obsession, before he fires. His crime is the crime of a gaze, and the investigation discloses what that gaze fed on: by his own admission, anger and jealousy: bitterness toward the capitalist order the mercenary represented, and sexual envy of Klaasje. Dante's word is the one the case confirms; envy is what the old man confesses.

At the summit of Purgatory flow two rivers. Lethe removes the memory of sin; Eunoë restores the memory of every good deed: *Da questa parte con virtù discende / che toglie altrui memoria del peccato; / da l'altra d'ogne ben fatto la rende* (Purgatorio XXVIII. 127–129). The order is essential. Dante drinks of Lethe only after he has climbed the mountain, confessed, and been purged; forgetting is the reward of penance, not its substitute. Harry has drunk of Lethe without climbing. His amnesia is an unearned forgetting, a counterfeit absolution, and the game's purgatorial labour consists in reversing the sequence: he must recover the memory of what he did before he can be released from it. This is the *Elysian dialectic* named in the Introduction: Lethe without purgation, then *anamnesis* as penance, then, perhaps, a Eunoë that returns to him the memory of the good he did and might do.

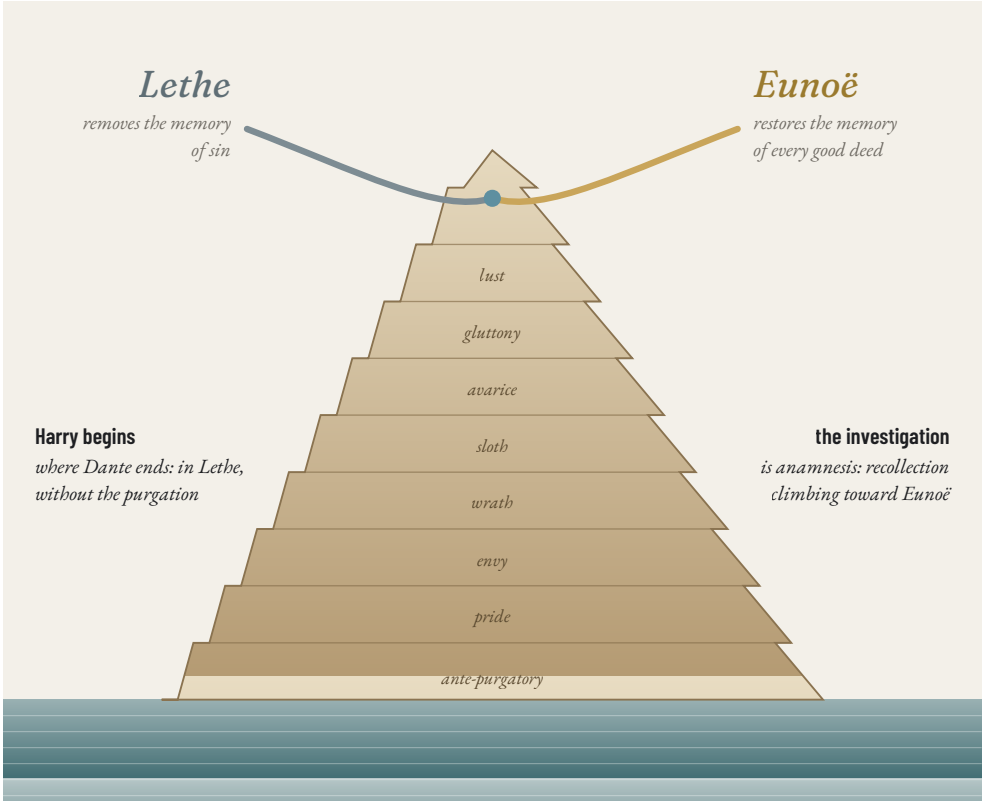


FIGURE 3.1 *Mount Purgatory after Dante.* Dante drinks of Lethe at the summit, after purgation; Harry begins in Lethe, and the investigation runs the sequence backward, as recollection climbing toward Eunoë.

Virgil's underworld adds a final complication. In *Aeneid* VI the souls destined for rebirth drink at the river of Lethe the care-free waters and long oblivion—*securos latices et longa oblivia potant* (6.715)—and Aeneas leaves the underworld through the ivory gate by which, as the poem has just explained, false dreams are sent up to the living (6.893–898). Commentators have debated for two millennia whether Virgil meant to cast doubt on the whole vision. *Disco Elysium* is saturated with such doubt. Its dreams of Dora may come through the gate of horn or the gate of ivory, and the game declines to say which; what Harry remembers of his past may be memory or confabulation. The work's epistemology of the past is Virgilian: recollection is necessary, and it is never guaranteed.

3.3 *The Detective Without a Brain-Attic*

In the second chapter of *A Study in Scarlet* (1887) Sherlock Holmes explains his ignorance of the Copernican system: "I consider that a man's brain originally is like a little empty attic, and you have to stock it with such furniture as you choose." The classical detective is an economist of memory who admits only what is useful. Harry's attic is the inverse of Holmes's. Encyclopedia has stocked it with an absurd profusion of lore—the histories of dead monarchs, the technical specifications of motor carriages, the obscure doctrines of a dozen sects—while the one item a detective most needs, his own identity, has been thrown out with the rubbish. He is a Holmes whose attic is full and whose house is empty.

Jorge Luis Borges's "Funes the Memorious" (1942) supplies the opposite limit case: Ireneo Funes, after a fall from a horse, remembers everything, and is incapable of thought, because to think is to forget differences, to generalize, to abstract. Harry's condition is Funes inverted and the inversion is enabling. Because he remembers nothing of himself, he must generalize from the testimony of others, construct hypotheses about his own character, and test them; his amnesia makes him, perforce, a thinker about himself. Gene Wolfe's *Book of the New Sun* (1980–83) offers a further mirror. Its narrator, Severian, a journeyman of the guild of torturers expelled for an act of mercy, claims to forget nothing, and his perfect memory makes him the most unreliable narrator in modern speculative fiction. Severian and Harry are both agents of state violence. The one who remembers everything cannot be trusted; the one who remembers nothing must learn to trust others.

W. G. Sebald's *Austerlitz* (2001) offers the closest literary model of anamnesis conducted as research. Its protagonist, brought to Wales from Prague as a small child on the Kindertransport in 1939 and raised under another name, reconstructs a past he did not know he had lost through archives, buildings, and the testimony of a surviving witness, and learns that his mother was deported by the German occupiers to Theresienstadt. Austerlitz and Harry share the structure of recollection as investigation: the self is recovered from documents and from the memory of others, never from introspection alone. The difference of scale is the measure of the game's restraint. Sebald's recollection opens onto the Holocaust; Harry's opens onto a private ruin that the city's history mirrors without dwarfing.

The Platonic doctrine of recollection completes the picture. In the *Meno* (81c–86b) Socrates leads an untutored slave boy, by questions alone, to discover the side of a square double the area of a given square, and concludes that learning is the recollection of what the soul already knew; the *Phaedo* (72e–77a) makes the same argument the ground of

the soul's pre-existence. In the *Theaetetus* (149a–151d) Socrates calls himself a midwife who delivers the thoughts of others. Harry is at once the questioner and the slave boy. As a detective he interrogates suspects; as an amnesiac he is delivered of his own past by the questions they put to him, by Kim's quiet probes, and by the skills that cross-examine him from within. Interrogation in *Disco Elysium* is maieutic in both directions.

The title, as the Introduction noted, says as much: *disco* is Latin for "I learn." A game whose name is a first-person verb of learning is a *Meno* in which the slave boy is also the investigator, and in which what is recollected is not geometry but a world.

3.4 *Kim's Notebook as* Hypomnēma

Kim Kitsuragi writes everything down. His notebook is the investigation's external memory, and the game's own journal, in which tasks and discoveries are logged, is its procedural double. Chapter 2 recalled Thamus's verdict on writing in the *Phaedrus*: a remedy for memory that is also its poison, because those who trust external marks will cease to remember of themselves. Harry is the limit case of that warning, a man with no internal memory at all, who must trust external marks entirely.

The text is exact about the instrument. Kim consults his "little notebook" throughout, turning its pages and tucking a number into a pocket inside its cover; at one point he checks it, says that he has everything, and asks whether Harry does. Harry's own instrument is the Damaged Ledger, a police ledger whose halogen watermarks unlock the journal's tallies of his copotype and political affiliation. The two notebooks are the partnership in miniature: one intact and shared, the other damaged and legible only under a special light.

Michel Foucault's essay "Self Writing" (1983) recovered the ancient practice of the *hypomnēmata*, notebooks in which readers collected quotations, examples, and reflections, not to reveal a hidden inner self but to constitute a self out of what had already been said. Kim's notebook is Harry's *hypomnēma*, kept by another hand. In "The Extended Mind" (1998), Andy Clark and David Chalmers argued that cognitive processes may extend beyond the skull into the environment, and their paradigm case was Otto, a man with Alzheimer's disease who finds his way to the Museum of Modern Art by consulting a notebook in which he has written what he can no longer remember. The notebook, they argued, plays the functional role of memory and should count as part of Otto's mind. Harry is Otto, and Kim's notebook is Otto's, with one decisive difference: it belongs to someone else.

The extended mind thereby becomes a shared mind. Edwin Hutchins's *Cognition in the Wild* (1995) described navigation aboard a naval vessel as a cognitive process distributed across crew, instruments, and charts, which no individual performs alone. The in-

vestigation in Martinaise is such a process, distributed between two officers, a notebook, the testimony of witnesses, and the dice. The political consequence is considerable. If memory can be held in common, then the amnesiac is not simply deficient but dependent, and his dependence is the seed of a commons. The first commons in *Disco Elysium* is a notebook.

3.5 *Idem, Ipse, and the Promise*

Chapter 1 left Harry in a Parfitian predicament: if what matters is psychological connectedness, his responsibility for the man who wrecked a hostel room, sank a car, and lost a badge and a gun is attenuated. The game refuses that comfort. The hostel's manager, Garte, presents him with a bill for sixty reál, three nights at twenty, and forty more for the window Harry 'annihilated' but cannot remember breaking; strangers recognize him and recall what he did; and in the final movement his colleagues from Precinct 41 arrive and speak of the man he was. Responsibility persists across the gap in memory, and the game must therefore show how a self can answer for a past it cannot recall.

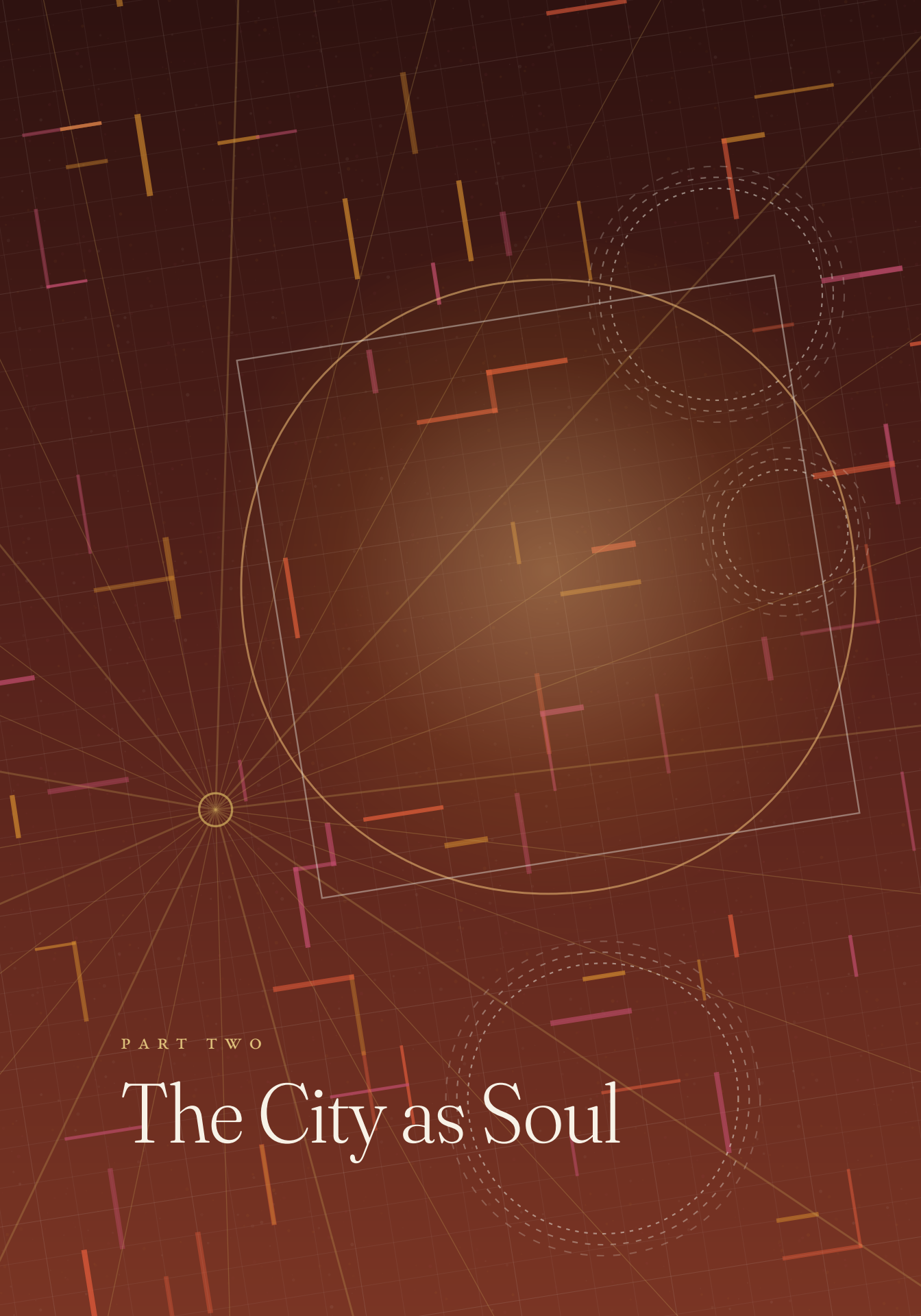
Paul Ricoeur's *Oneself as Another* (1990) distinguished two kinds of personal identity. *Idem*-identity is sameness, the permanence of character and memory through time. *Ipse*-identity is selfhood, whose paradigm is the keeping of a promise: whatever has changed in me, I maintain myself by keeping my word. Harry has lost *idem*. He can still achieve *ipse*. His selfhood is not recovered from the past but constituted toward the future, in commitments to Kim, to the case, and, should he choose, to sobriety.

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) identified two faculties that remedy the predicaments of action. Forgiveness remedies irreversibility, the fact that what has been done cannot be undone; promising remedies unpredictability, the fact that no one can know what they will do. Harry needs both, and the game distributes them. Kim, whose reliability is his defining trait, embodies the promise; Harry, whose past is a catalogue of harm, seeks forgiveness from his colleagues, from the memory of Dora, and from himself. Ricoeur's *Memory, History, Forgetting* (2000) closes with an epilogue on "difficult forgiveness," which cannot be commanded and must not become amnesty. Harry's amnesia is precisely an amnesty without forgiveness, and the work of the game is to convert the one into the other.

Nietzsche supplies the darker genealogy. The second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887) begins with the task of breeding an animal entitled to make promises, and explains that such an animal requires a memory that has been burned into it: *nur was nicht aufhört, weh zu thun, bleibt im Gedächtniss*—only what does not cease to hurt remains in the memory. Harry's memories return through pain. Pain Threshold is one of his faculties, and the recollections the game grants him are almost never pleasant; the

mnemotechnics of *Disco Elysium* are Nietzschean. Yet the game's final wager is not Nietzschean but Dantean. Through the long anamnesis of Martinaise, Harry recovers not only the memory of the harm he did but intimations of the good he was capable of—his gifts as a detective, the respect he once commanded, the love he was able to give. That is Eunoë. The purgatorial structure is complete when recollection has made him capable of promising, and promising has made forgetting no longer a flight but a release.

The order of the game's first encounters confirms Nietzsche in another respect. The second essay of the *Genealogy* derives the moral concept of guilt, *Schuld*, from the material concept of debt, *Schulden*, the relation of creditor to debtor. Harry's first social relation in Martinaise is exactly that. Before he has recovered his name, he owes the hostel a hundred reál; responsibility for the forgotten past arrives first as an invoice.



PART TWO

The City as Soul

II

Le vieux Paris n'est plus (la forme d'une ville
Change plus vite, hélas! que le cœur d'un mortel).

— Baudelaire, "Le Cygne" (1861)

Die Tradition aller toten Geschlechter lastet wie ein Alp auf dem Gehirne der Lebenden.

— Marx, *Der achtzehnte Brumaire des Louis Bonaparte* (1852)

CHAPTER 4



Revachol

The City–Soul Isomorphism

Part One established that Harry's psyche is a polity. Part Two establishes the converse: that Revachol is a psyche, a collective subject with a traumatic past, an occupied present, and a parliament of factions whose voices it cannot silence. The thesis of this chapter is that the city and the man are isomorphic—constructed from the same elements in the same relations—and that the game's investigation of a murder is an investigation of both at once.

4.1 *Plato's Analogy, Re-engineered*

In the second book of the *Republic* (368c–369a), Socrates proposes to seek justice first in the city, where it is written in larger letters, and then in the soul, where it is written small. The analogy governs the whole dialogue. Book IV finds the three classes of the city—rulers, auxiliaries, producers—mirrored in the three parts of the soul. Books VIII and IX narrate the decline of constitutions, from aristocracy through timocracy, oligarchy, and democracy to tyranny, and pair each regime with a type of soul. *Disco Elysium* re-engineers the analogy in three respects.

First, it substitutes history for typology. Revachol has passed through a monarchy whose seat it once was, a communist revolution that briefly established a commune, a foreign intervention that crushed it, and an occupation administered by an international coalition. Harry's psyche has passed through a corresponding sequence: a regime of

career and love, a revolution of the senses in the binge, and an occupation by voices he can no longer govern. Second, it substitutes multiplicity for tripartition. Plato's three classes become the setting's four ideologies, and each ideology names a psychic regime as well as a political one. Mazovian communism corresponds to a collectivized psyche in which every faculty claims an equal share of the floor; fascism to a dictatorship of a single faculty, typically Authority or Half Light; ultraliberalism to a market of faculties in which Electrochemistry's hedonic calculus sets prices; moralism to a technocratic management of the voices that damps every conflict in the name of stability. Third, it substitutes an open question for Plato's answer. The *Republic* resolves the analogy by placing reason in command. *Disco Elysium* rejects every candidate for command and leaves the constitution open.

Plato's portrait of the tyrannical soul gives the analogy its sharpest point. A man becomes tyrannical in the strict sense, Socrates says in Book IX (573c), when by nature or habit or both he becomes *methustikos te kai erōtikos kai melankholikos*—drunken, erotic, and melancholic. The triad is a clinical description of Harry Du Bois at the moment the game begins. His soul is governed by the tyrant *Erōs*, whose object is Dora; it is drunk; it is, in the precise Greek sense, black-biled. Plato's question was how a tyrannical soul might become just. The game's question is the same, and its answer is not the rule of reason but the reform of the assembly.

4.2 *Onomastics of Catastrophe*

The names of *Disco Elysium* form a dense constellation, and reading them is a hermeneutic act in its own right. *Revachol* differs by a single letter from Ravachol, the nom de guerre of François Claudius Koënigstein, the anarchist whose bombings in Paris in 1892 made him the emblem of "propaganda by the deed" and who was guillotined at Montbrison on 11 July of that year. The name's bearer was not simply a martyr. Ravachol bombed the Paris residences of a judge and a prosecutor in March 1892 in reprisal for the sentencing of anarchists, and he was guillotined for an earlier crime, the murder of an elderly hermit in a robbery in 1891; anarchists nonetheless sang of him as a martyr. The city is named, in effect, for revolutionary violence at the point where it becomes indistinguishable from crime—the point the deserter reaches on his island. *Insulinde*, the isola on which it stands, was the poetic name coined by Multatuli in *Max Havelaar* (1860) for the Dutch East Indies, an empire he described as winding about the equator like a girdle of emerald, and whose exploitation his novel indicted. The setting's map thus bears the colonial unconscious in its very nomenclature.

Kras Mazov, the theorist and leader of the Antecentennial Revolution in Graad, carries the initials of Karl Marx and a surname that recalls the Karamazovs; critics have also

seen in him something of Lenin and, in the report that he shot himself when the counterrevolution triumphed, of Salvador Allende, whose death during the 1973 military coup in Chile was ruled a suicide (Winslow-Yost 2025). *Dolores Dei*—literally the sorrows of God—transposes the *Mater Dolorosa* of the thirteenth-century sequence *Stabat Mater dolorosa* into a secular cult of world-historical persons. *Du Bois* recalls, beyond its Dantean wood, W. E. B. Du Bois, whose *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903) described double consciousness as "this sense of always looking at one's self through the eyes of others" and as two warring ideals in one body.

The game relocates that gaze without appropriating its history. Harry's chief means of seeing himself is through the eyes of Kim Kitsuragi, a Seolite officer who is subjected to racist abuse in Martinaise: by a lorry driver whom the game names simply the Racist Lorry Driver; by Gary, the Cryptofascist, who greets him with a racial epithet before correcting himself to 'officer'; by Measurehead, who reads his skull aloud as evidence of racial type; and, if the player so chooses, by Harry himself, who can join in the driver's racism and is then asked by Kim whether he meant it in earnest or was only trying to win the man's confidence. Kim's measured judgment becomes the mirror in which Harry learns what he is, and the game thus makes the player answerable for the gaze Du Bois described: Harry can be the eyes of contempt before he becomes the man who sees himself through the eyes of the one he has held in contempt.

Kim names the condition himself. Born and raised in Revachol, he calls himself a regular, garden-variety Revacholiere, yet he remarks that to most of his countrymen he will always be the object of a racial slur. The Racist Lorry Driver's first words, a mocking welcome to Revachol, are addressed to Kim, a man born in the city; the same driver accuses a foreign shopkeeper, Siileng, of smuggling drugs on no ground but that Siileng is foreign.

The relocation has a cost that criticism has named. Critics, Takeo Rivera among them according to one recent survey of the debate, have argued that the game makes Kim a conduit for Harry's redemption: hypercompetent and patient, he absorbs the lorry driver's abuse and goes on conducting the investigation, his interiority subordinated to the protagonist's recovery. The objection is Du Bois's own, turned on the game. Double consciousness names the burden of a subject compelled to see himself through the eyes of others; a work that makes such a subject the mirror of another man's self-knowledge risks reproducing the burden it depicts. This thesis takes the objection as a limit of the game's humanism rather than a refutation of it, and Chapter 11 returns to it.

Even the ranks of the militia are a palimpsest. Harry's title, lieutenant double-yefreitor, which he can recite as his place in the world, joins the French *lieutenant* to the Russian *efreitor*, itself borrowed from the German *Gefreiter*, and records in its morphology the several empires that have passed over the city.

The most remarkable constellation is Dutch. Klaasje, the fugitive at the centre of the case, bears a Dutch diminutive and the epithet Miss Oranje Disco Dancer; the isola is Multatuli's Insulinde; and the hanged man is called Lely. Cornelis Lely (1854–1929) was the Dutch civil engineer and minister whose plan for enclosing and draining the Zuiderzee became the great hydraulic project of the twentieth-century Netherlands; the city of Lelystad bears his name. Chapter 1 recalled that Freud closed the thirty-first of his *New Introductory Lectures* (1933) by comparing the ego's conquest of the id to *die Trockenlegung der Zuydersee*, the draining of the Zuider Zee. The corpse at the centre of *Disco Elysium* thus bears the name of the engineer of the very project Freud chose as the image of the integrated ego. Whatever its origin, the constellation is exact: the case begins with the death of the ego's engineer, hanged in a yard, and the sea he would have held back is, in this world, the Pale. The constellation extends to politics. The Dutch *poldermodel*, the consensus bargaining between unions, employers, and government inaugurated by the Wassenaar Agreement of 1982, is the very type of the managed centrism the game satirizes as moralism. The dikes of consensus, like the dikes of the ego, hold back a sea that is rising.

The Dutch cluster is deliberate at the scale of the world map. Elysium's analogue of the Netherlands is Oranje, a heavily militarized state; France and Belgium are fused as Sur-la-Clef; and the setting conspicuously offers no analogue of the United States or England (Winslow-Yost 2025). The absence recentres Elysium's geopolitics on continental Europe and its colonial peripheries, which is where the onomastics of Revachol have already placed it.

4.3 *The Commune and Its Afterlives*

The history of Revachol is modelled with unmistakable closeness on the Paris Commune of 1871. The Commune was proclaimed on 28 March, after the insurrection of 18 March, and destroyed by the troops of the Versailles government under Adolphe Thiers in the *Semaine sanglante* of 21–28 May, during which many thousands of Communards were killed; survivors such as Louise Michel were deported to New Caledonia. Marx's address to the International, *The Civil War in France* (1871), called the Commune "the political form at last discovered under which to work out the economical emancipation of labour." Prosper-Olivier Lissagaray, a participant, wrote its history (1876). In Revachol, the revolutionary commune was likewise crushed by an external force—the Coalition, whose governing body is the Moralintern—and its scars remain legible in the city's architecture and in the bodies of its survivors.

The setting's chronology is exact. The game takes place in the year '51 of the current century. Forty-nine years earlier a wave of communist revolutions overthrew the Suzer-

ainty of Revachol, until then Elysium's pre-eminent power; six years later the Commune was toppled by the Coalition, and Revachol became a Special Administrative Region, which the Disco Elysium Wiki also calls the International Zone of Control (Wikipedia; Disco Elysium Wiki).

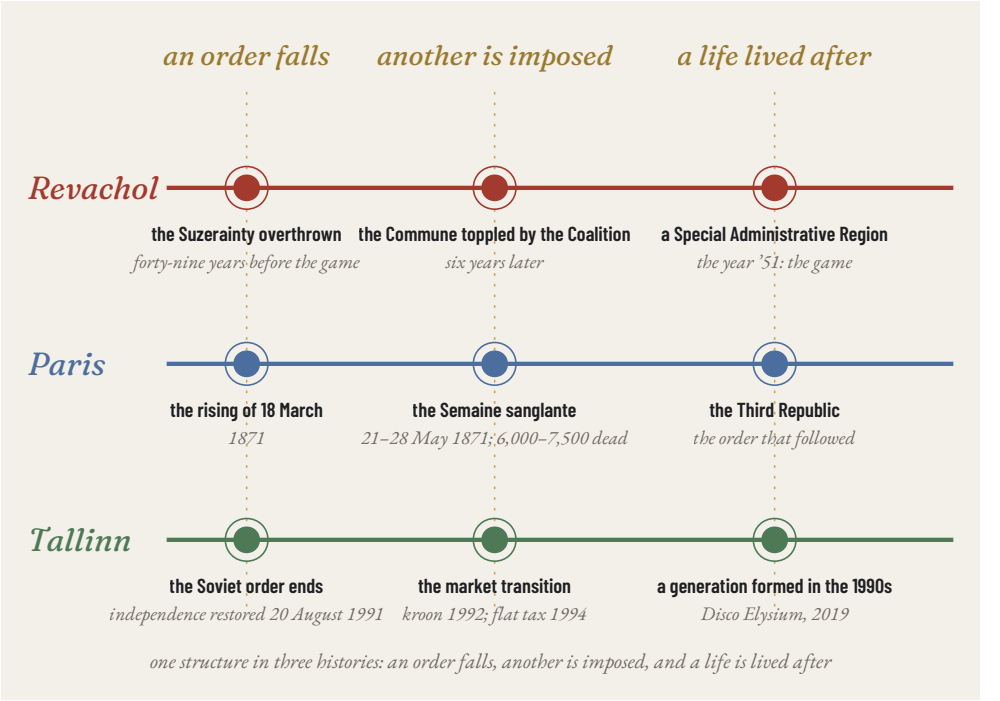


FIGURE 4.1 *One structure in three histories, aligned by phase: Revachol's chronology, the Paris Commune of 1871, and the Estonian transition after 1991.* Casualty figures follow Tombs's revision.

The analogy requires the precision of the dead. The Versailles army under Marshal Patrice de MacMahon, acting for Thiers's government, killed Communards and suspected Communards in the street fighting and in summary executions; older estimates ran from ten to more than twenty thousand dead, while Robert Tombs's revision (2012) argued for roughly six to seven and a half thousand. The Commune, for its part, shot hostages in its final days, among them Georges Darboy, Archbishop of Paris, on 24 May. The game's history keeps both registers: a revolution crushed by an external coalition, and a revolutionary violence that outlives the revolution in the deserter's shot.

The game refuses to settle who killed whom, and the refusal is an argument. On a rotting boardwalk in Martinaise a wall is still pocked with bullet holes, and Visual Calculus can reconstruct the scene: the ghosts of men lined against the wall and soldiers facing them. The reconstruction does not reveal which side shot which, communists ex-

ecuting loyalists early in the revolution or the victors executing communists at its end. It records only that no Moralist died there, because, in the game's phrase, they were always the last ones against the wall (Winslow-Yost 2025). Revolutionary and counter-revolutionary violence are rendered in a single image, and the only party exempted from the wall is the one that inherited the city.

Kristin Ross's *Communal Luxury* (2015) recovered from the manifesto of the Commune's Federation of Artists the phrase that gives her book its title: the demand that beauty and pleasure, not merely subsistence, be distributed to all. This idea is essential to the reading of disco in Chapter 8, because it shows that the commune was never only an economic programme; it was also an aesthetic one, a claim to the right to luxury for those excluded from it. Arendt's *On Revolution* (1963) called the councils that sprang up in every modern revolution, and were crushed by every revolutionary party, "the lost treasure" of the revolutionary tradition. Benjamin's theses "On the Concept of History" (1940) warned that even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins, and pictured the angel of history facing the wreckage of the past while a storm blowing from Paradise drives him backward into the future. The aged deserter on his island is the angel turned assassin: a man who has faced the wreckage of the revolution for four decades and who, unable to redeem it, has fired into the present.

4.4 *The Threshold Chronotope and Non-Synchronism*

In "Forms of Time and of the Chronotope in the Novel" (1937–38) Bakhtin defined the chronotope as the intrinsic connectedness of temporal and spatial relationships artistically expressed in literature. Among his types is the *threshold*, the chronotope of crisis and break, characteristic of Dostoevsky, in which time is not duration but an instant of decision. Martinaise is a threshold in every dimension: a peninsula at the edge of the city, a harbour at the edge of the sea, a district at the edge of solvency, and a world at the edge of the Pale. Its signature architecture is a building named for the businesses that have failed in it, and its signature time is the instant before something gives way.

Antonio Gramsci, in the notebooks he kept in a Fascist prison between 1929 and 1935, gave the threshold its political name. A crisis, he observed, consists precisely in the fact that the old order is dying while the new cannot yet be born, and in that interval morbid symptoms of the most varied kinds appear. Martinaise is an interregnum in Gramsci's exact sense—the Commune dead, the occupation unable to found a living order—and its residents, from the deserter to Measurehead, are its morbid symptoms. Harry, a policeman who has lost his mandate, is the interregnum embodied.

Ernst Bloch's *Heritage of Our Times* (1935) introduced the concept of non-synchronism (*Ungleichzeitigkeit*): people who live in the same chronological present may inhabit

different historical times, and the contradictions between those times, unresolved, are a reservoir from which fascism draws. Martinaise is a museum of non-synchronous lives. The old royalist René Arnoux, once a captain of the Royal Carabineers who fought for the Suzerain in the revolution and, before it, in a seven-year campaign to force the Ikeira tribes under the Revacholian banner, lives in the time of the monarchy and its colonial wars; the deserter lives in the time of the Commune; Measurehead lives in a mythic time of races; Joyce Messier, the negotiator for Wild Pines, lives in the global time of capital; the young people who wish to turn a derelict church into a techno club live in a future that cannot arrive; the child Cuno lives in the time of a childhood without future. Harry, who remembers nothing, lives in no time at all, and that zero-point is what allows him to hear them all. The detective in *Disco Elysium* is a synchronizer of non-synchronous times, and the solution of the case is the moment at which the time of the Commune and the time of capital collide in a single shot.

Georg Lukács supplies the literary form of this synchronizing function. *The Theory of the Novel* (1916; in book form 1920) described the novel as the epic of a world abandoned by God, whose hero is a problematic individual seeking a meaning no longer immanent in life, and named the condition "transcendental homelessness." *The Historical Novel* (1937) praised Walter Scott for choosing mediocre, middle-of-the-road heroes, men of no decided party through whom the contending forces of a historical crisis could pass and become visible. Harry is at once Lukács's homeless hero and Scott's mediocre one: an amnesiac without a party through whom royalist, communist, capitalist, and moralist Revachol pass and become legible. Hans Castorp, the unremarkable young man of *The Magic Mountain* recalled in Chapter 9, belongs to the same type.

4.5 *The Post-Soviet Palimpsest*

The work was made by a generation formed in the Estonia of the 1990s. The country, occupied by the Soviet Union in 1940, by Germany from 1941 to 1944, and again by the Soviet Union until the restoration of independence on 20 August 1991, underwent one of the most radical market transitions in the former Eastern bloc: a new currency in 1992, pegged to the Deutsche Mark through a currency board, a flat income tax in 1994, rapid privatization, and the social dislocations—unemployment, alcoholism, a sharp fall in male life expectancy across the post-Soviet space—that accompanied the transition everywhere. Alexei Yurchak's *Everything Was Forever, Until It Was No More* (2005) described the last Soviet generation's experience of a system that seemed eternal until the moment it vanished, and coined the term *hypernormalization* for the performative reproduction of official forms whose meanings no one believed. Svetlana Alexievich's oral history *Secondhand Time* (2013) recorded the voices of those who outlived the Soviet

world and found themselves strangers in its successor. The deserter of *Disco Elysium* speaks in the cadences of Alexievich's witnesses.

The game supplies its own index of the transition. Rhetoric observes that the West Revacholian industrial base was dismantled after the war, leaving extinguished coke furnaces across a landscape despoiled by industry: the deindustrialized terrain of the post-Soviet periphery, transposed into Elysium.

The protagonist himself has a Soviet source. By the developers' account Harry was directly inspired by Kaur Kender's father, a detective in the Soviet police, and the scene in which Harry vomits at the stench of the corpse reproduces an incident from that career (Wikipedia). The amnesiac cop of a post-revolutionary city is modelled on a policeman of the Soviet order.

Yet the game inverts the national memory from which it emerged. In Estonian experience, communism was the occupier and liberal Europe the horizon of liberation. In Revachol, communism is the crushed native revolution and liberal internationalism the occupier. The inversion is not an apologia for the Soviet occupation, whose crimes in Estonia include the mass deportations to Siberia carried out by the Soviet security organs in June 1941 and March 1949, which removed some ten thousand and some twenty thousand people respectively; nor does it efface the German occupation, under which the Jews who had remained in Estonia were murdered in 1941 by units of Einsatzgruppe A and their Estonian collaborators. It is estrangement in the sense of Shklovsky's *ostranenie* and Brecht's *Verfremdung*. By reversing the valence of the national myth, the game renders visible what all occupations share and what all defeated futures have in common. Svetlana Boym's *The Future of Nostalgia* (2001) distinguished *restorative* nostalgia, which seeks to rebuild the lost home and underwrites nationalism, from *reflective* nostalgia, which dwells in longing itself, ironic and unfinished, and she proposed an "off-modern" path that is neither modernist nor anti-modernist. *Disco Elysium* is the off-modern game par excellence: its world looks like the 1970s of a history that did not happen, and its melancholy is reflective rather than restorative.

Estrangement also carries a charge. The Coalition's administration of Revachol—an international order that defeated a revolution in the name of stability and governs its ruins as a special zone—maps onto the post-1991 settlement that the Baltic states experienced as liberation: accession conditionality, rapid privatization, the reconstruction of a society as a market. The inversion implies a critique that national memory does not easily accommodate: that the order which ended one occupation also administered the transition as a discipline, and that a liberation can be lived, by those it impoverished, as another form of rule.

The Estonian landscape had already furnished one of the twentieth century's great images of the post-utopian zone. Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979), adapted from the

Strugatskys' *Roadside Picnic*, was filmed largely in the industrial wastelands around Tallinn. Its Zone—flooded, overgrown, strewn with the debris of an unexplained catastrophe—is the visual ancestor of Martinaise, a district where the ruins of a revolution rust beside the harbour and the sea carries the grey of the Pale.

CHAPTER 5



The Four Visions

Political Ontology and the Satire of Ideology

The Final Cut formalized four ideological itineraries—communist, fascist, ultraliberal, and moralist—each opened by Harry's attraction to an idea, extended through comic episodes, and capped by a visionary sequence. The conventional reading treats them as even-handed satire. This chapter argues that the satire's true target is not the content of any doctrine but the form of attachment each one solicits, and that each vision encodes a distinct relation to historical time. The thermodynamic interpretation of those relations is completed in Chapter 11.

5.1 *Ideology after Cynical Reason*

Marx's formula for the unconscious practice of commodity exchange—*Sie wissen das nicht, aber sie tun es*, they do not know it, but they do it (*Capital* I, chapter 1)—defined ideology as false consciousness. Peter Sloterdijk's *Critique of Cynical Reason* (1983) diagnosed its late-modern mutation: an "enlightened false consciousness" that sees through its own illusions and continues to act upon them. Slavoj Žižek's *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (1989) reformulated Marx accordingly: they know very well what they are doing, and they are doing it nonetheless, because ideology resides not in belief but in practice and in the fantasy that structures reality. Louis Althusser had already defined ideology as the representation of individuals' imaginary relationship to their real conditions of existence.

Martinaise is populated by every species of ideological subject these theories distinguish. There are naive believers: the earnest young Mazovians, and Measurehead with his anthropometric certainties. There are cynics: the union boss Evrart Claire, who speaks the language of solidarity while running the district's economy, and Joyce Messier, whose lucid account of the world's political economy is offered without illusion and without dissent. There are nostalgics: the royalist René and the deserter. Harry belongs to none of these species. Having forgotten his convictions along with his name, he adopts ideology as one adopts a costume, and the Thought Cabinet renders the adoption mechanically: an ideology occupies a slot, takes time to internalize, and confers bonuses and penalties. Ideology becomes a build. The satire's deepest target is this identitarian form of politics, in which conviction is a mode of self-fashioning practised in a vacuum of memory.

The build has a price list, and the Thought Cabinet pays each politics in its own currency. *Mazovian Socio-Economics* lowers Visual Calculus while it is researched and then rewards every left-wing answer with experience. *Rigorous Self-Critique* costs Authority and then makes failed red checks of Intellect and Psyche restore Morale. *Indirect Modes of Taxation* costs Empathy and then pays a reál for every ultraliberal answer. *Kingdom of Conscience* calms Half Light and makes moralist answers heal Morale. *Advanced Race Theory* costs Drama. The left pays in learning and turns defeat into endurance; the market pays in cash at the expense of empathy; the centre pays in sedation; race theory costs the self its theatre. The game's political economy of the psyche is, in this precise sense, a satire of what each ideology offers its adherents.

thought	it costs, or alters	it pays
Mazovian Socio-Economics communist	Visual Calculus −2	*+4 experience for each left-wing answer*
Rigorous Self-Critique communist	Authority −1	*failed Intellect and Psyche red checks restore Morale*
Indirect Modes of Taxation ultraliberal	Empathy −2	*+1 réal for each ultraliberal answer*
Kingdom of Conscience moralist	calms Half Light	*moralist answers heal Morale*
Advanced Race Theory fascist	costs Drama	*costs the self its theatre*

the left pays in learning, the market in cash, the centre in sedation

FIGURE 5.1 *The Thought Cabinet's price list.* Each political thought costs or alters a faculty and then pays in its own currency.

5.2 *Mazovian Socio-Economics and Left Melancholy*

The communist itinerary is the most affectionate of the four and the most painful. Harry's enthusiasm for Kras Mazov is grandiose and ineffectual; his conversations with the young Mazovians, Steban the Student Communist among them, dissolve into sectarian theorizing; the thought *Rigorous Self-Critique* mocks the Stalinist and Maoist ritual of criticism and self-criticism while conceding its psychological truth. The communist of the present is a reader, a talker, and a mourner. The communist of the past is the deserter: Iosef Lilianovich Dros, a former commissar of the revolutionary army who survived its collapse by deserting his post and has lived for decades in a ruined fort, watching.

Walter Benjamin's review "Left-Wing Melancholy" (1931) attacked the poetry of Erich Kästner for converting revolutionary reflexes into objects of consumption, a melancholy that had made itself comfortable in defeat. Wendy Brown's "Resisting Left Melancholy" (1999) extended the diagnosis to a left more attached to its lost ideals than

to the possibility of transformation—a melancholia in Freud's strict sense, in which the lost object is incorporated into the ego and the ego berates itself in the object's name. Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993), written against Francis Fukuyama's triumphalism, named *hauntology* the logic of a past that does not pass and of futures that continue to haunt the present in which they failed to arrive. Mark Fisher's *Ghosts of My Life* (2014) gave that logic its cultural phenomenology.

Disco Elysium stages left melancholy in two bodies. Harry's melancholia is private: he has incorporated Dora and berates himself in her name. The deserter's is political: he has incorporated the Commune and berates the world in its name. The two are homologous, and their confrontation on the island is a confrontation of a man with the end-state of his own disorder. Albert Camus's *The Rebel* (1951) traced the passage from rebellion, which affirms a limit, to revolution, which abolishes it and ends in murder; Dostoevsky's *Demons* (1872) gave the passage its emblem in Shigalyov, whose system begins from unlimited freedom and arrives at unlimited despotism. The deserter is Shigalyov in old age: a man for whom the revolution has become a private sentence of death passed upon whatever reminds him of its defeat—youth, beauty, a mercenary having sex with the woman the old man had watched from his sniper's nest.

Demons contains a second figure the argument requires. Kirillov, the engineer who has resolved to kill himself to prove that his will is absolutely free and that man can become god, places his suicide at the disposal of Pyotr Verkhovensky's conspirators, who use it to cover their murder of Shatov by having him sign a false confession before he dies. Kirillov's metaphysical suicide and Shigalyov's system are the two exits the novel offers from ideological despair: the destruction of the self and the destruction of others. Harry begins between them, addressed by a voice that counsels the first, and ends facing a man who chose the second.

The game does not, however, mock the communist hope. Its tenderness for the dockworkers, its anger at Wild Pines, and its grief for the Commune are unironic. Its communism is closer to the young Marx of the *Economic and Philosophical Manuscripts* (1844)—the critique of alienation and the vision of human beings recognizing themselves in their activity and in one another—than to the eschatological Marxism of the party. This is the sense in which the team's onstage thanks to Marx and Engels, together with Kurvitz's tribute to the humanism of Arvi Siig, can be taken at its word: a dialectical humanism that refuses both eschatology and cynicism and that has not yet found its form.

5.3 *Revacholian Nationhood, Race Theory, and the Armored Body*

The fascist itinerary runs through the thoughts *Revacholian Nationhood* and *Advanced Race Theory*, through the royalist nostalgia of René, and through Measurehead, whose speeches on the hierarchy of peoples combine pseudo-science, sexual braggadocio, and the cult of the body. Umberto Eco's "Ur-Fascism" (1995) listed fourteen features of an eternal fascism—among them the cult of tradition, the rejection of modernism, the cult of action for its own sake, the fear of difference, the appeal to a frustrated middle class, the obsession with a plot, machismo, and an impoverished vocabulary. Roger Griffin's *The Nature of Fascism* (1991) defined its core as *palingenetic ultranationalism*, the myth of a national rebirth from decadence. Both descriptions fit Revachol's fascists with comic precision; the game's nationalism dreams of the monarchy's restoration in a city whose monarchy was swept away by the revolution and whose revolution was swept away by the Coalition.

The Thought Cabinet renders these ideologies as mechanics. *Advanced Race Theory*, acquired by subscribing to Measurehead's theory and accepting the task of pondering what the game calls the race enigma, lowers Drama and raises the cap on Rhetoric: it costs the self its theatre and feeds its argument. *Revacholian Nationhood* makes alcohol's boost to Physique stronger, so that nationalism and drink are coupled in the code itself.

Klaus Theweleit's *Male Fantasies* (1977–78), a study of the novels and memoirs of the German *Freikorps*, argued that the fascist soldier constituted himself as a body-armour against a flood—of women, of communism, of bodily fluids, of everything that threatened his boundaries with dissolution. Harry is the inverse of Theweleit's soldier male: a body that has already dissolved, whose flood is inside him, whose fluids are on the floor of his room. The fascist itinerary is therefore a fantasy of armour available to a man with none. The mercenaries of Krenel, sheathed in actual armour, embody the fantasy without its comedy. Susan Sontag's "Fascinating Fascism" (1975) identified fascism's aesthetic as the cult of beauty, strength, and submission; Measurehead's physique is that aesthetic made flesh and made ridiculous.

Theweleit's soldier males were not only authors. Freikorps units, deployed by the Social Democratic government in 1919, crushed the Spartacist rising in Berlin and the Bavarian Soviet Republic in Munich, and officers of the Garde-Kavallerie-Schützen-Division murdered Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht on 15 January 1919. The Krenel mercenaries whom Wild Pines hires to break the strike stand in this lineage: armed men under contract whose function is to defeat a labour action, and whose code of honour turns, in the Tribunal, into a court of execution.

Chapter 1 traced the descent of race science from Gall's organology. The point may now be stated politically. Fascism in *Disco Elysium* is a theory of the faculties: it localizes them in skulls, ranks them by race, and installs one of them—Authority, or Half Light's fear—as dictator over the rest. It is, in the vocabulary of Svetlana Boym, restorative nostalgia in its purest form. The game's refutation is formal before it is argumentative. A mind in which every faculty retains a voice cannot be ruled by one, and a self that has been heard cannot be measured.

Michel Foucault's lectures "Society Must Be Defended" (1975–76) explain why a race theorist belongs in a game about the police. Modern racism, Foucault argued, is the mechanism by which a state devoted to fostering life introduces a break between those who must live and those who may be let die; it is the condition on which a biopolitical power exercises the right to kill. Measurehead's anthropometry is that break in pseudoscientific form, and the game places racism's nearest target inside the partnership at its centre: Kim. Measurehead inspects him aloud, pronouncing on his paedomorphic features, his protruding occiput, and his indented zygomatic bone, and concedes that his farsightedness does not make him a complete invalid, since he still has the use of his mind. The craniometric gaze of Chapter 1 is turned, in the game's own text, on the partner at its centre, and Kim does not flinch.

5.4 *Ultraliberalism and the Doomed Commercial Area*

The ultraliberal itinerary converts Harry into a petty capitalist: he schemes for money, reveres the abstractions of finance, and internalizes the thought *Indirect Modes of Taxation*. Its comedy is the comedy of a man with nothing playing at accumulation. Its seriousness lies elsewhere, in the person of Joyce Messier, the negotiator for Wild Pines, who explains to Harry, with a candour that is itself a form of power, how the world is governed and what the Pale portends for it. Joyce is a secularized Grand Inquisitor. Like the Inquisitor of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), she knows exactly what the order she serves is and argues that human beings are better served by it than by freedom; unlike him, she does not even claim to love them.

The doctrine Harry parodies has a lineage. Friedrich Hayek's *The Road to Serfdom* (1944) argued that economic planning leads to tyranny, and the Mont Pèlerin Society, which Hayek convened in 1947, became the intellectual centre of the movement later called neoliberalism; Ayn Rand's *Atlas Shrugged* (1957) made its moral premise—the entrepreneur as creator, the regulator and the collective as parasites—into myth. Harry's ultraliberal quest is Rand's myth performed by a man who owes a hostel for the damage to his room. David Harvey's account of neoliberalism as accumulation by dispossession

(*The New Imperialism*, 2003; *A Brief History of Neoliberalism*, 2005) names what the strike resists.

The ultraliberal order has an architecture. In Martinaise stands the Doomed Commercial Area, a building named for the businesses that have failed on its property, so reliably that their failure has acquired the character of a curse. Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) defined the eerie as a failure of absence or of presence, a question about agency: what kind of agent is acting here? He named capital as the eerie entity par excellence, conjured out of nothing yet exerting more influence than any allegedly substantial thing. The Doomed Commercial Area is the eerie made architectural: the invisible hand as a haunting.

The game stages the very question of agency that defines Fisher's eerie. Martinaise disagrees about why the businesses fail: Plaisance blames evil or supernatural spirits, while Garte and the Novelty Dicemaker blame bad business practices. The Whirling-in-Rags itself appears on the building's intercom, the two houses having been built together under the East Delta Commerce Centre project, so that by some accounts the hostel in which the game begins belongs to the doomed property. And the Dicemaker, who says she has spent fourteen years selling novelty dice to role-playing enthusiasts, is a puzzle in her own right: Shivers can ask why her business has not failed. Where commerce fails, play persists.

The historical frame is the neoliberal project as Quinn Slobodian reconstructed it in *Globalists* (2018) and *Crack-Up Capitalism* (2023): the encasement of markets against democratic pressure and the proliferation of zones exempted from ordinary law. Revachol, administered by the Coalition as a special administrative region, is such a zone. Naomi Klein's *The Shock Doctrine* (2007) described the use of catastrophe to impose market reforms; the post-revolutionary occupation is Revachol's shock. Karl Polanyi's *The Great Transformation* (1944) supplies the dialectic. The attempt to disembed the economy from society provokes a protective countermovement, which may take emancipatory or authoritarian forms. The dockworkers' strike is Polanyi's countermovement; that it is led by a boss who is himself an operator of the local economy is Polanyi's ambiguity made flesh.

Critics have read Revachol as a composite of Paris, postwar Berlin, 1970s New York, and the Tangier International Zone, the city governed by a consortium of foreign powers from the 1920s to 1956 (Winslow-Yost 2025); the last analogue names exactly the kind of zone Slobodian describes. The countermovement is compromised in practice as well as in structure. Ruby, the organizer of the Hardie Boys, had smuggled drugs for a crime syndicate before coordinating trafficking for the Union, and the investigation can confront her with it. The union that leads the countermovement is entangled in the shadow economy the occupation tolerates.

5.5 *Moralism, the Extreme Centre, and the Ode to Joy*

The fourth ideology is the one that rules. Moralism is the creed of the Moralintern, the international body that governs the Coalition and administers Revachol, and it is the ideology of the centre: technocratic, humanitarian, managerial, and averse to conflict. Harry's moralist itinerary makes him a champion of moderation; its governing thought, *Kingdom of Conscience*, is discussed below. A thought whose name sounds centrist, *Wompty-Dompty Dom Centre*, in fact satirizes the art world, which it calls an unholy symbiosis of esthetics and tax optimization. Francis Fukuyama's "The End of History?" (1989) and *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992), following Alexandre Kojève's reading of Hegel, proposed that liberal democracy is the final form of human government. Chantal Mouffe's *On the Political* (2005) criticized the post-political consensus that denies the antagonistic dimension of politics; Tariq Ali's *The Extreme Centre* (2015) named the convergence of mainstream parties around a single programme; Jacques Rancière's *Disagreement* (1995) described consensus democracy as the end of politics by the police. The Moralintern is all of these. It is also Kant's *Perpetual Peace* (1795)—a federation of states pledged to end war—ossified into an administration that has abolished war by abolishing politics.

The setting's doctrine of Innocences—persons in whom an age is held to be incarnate, among them Dolores Dei and Ambrosius Saint-Miro, an avatar of pessimism and nihilism—is Hegel's theory of world-historical individuals made into a cult. In the *Lectures on the Philosophy of History* (delivered 1822–31), Hegel described figures such as Alexander, Caesar, and Napoleon as agents of the World Spirit who realize its purposes without knowing them and are cast aside once those purposes are served. On 13 October 1806, the eve of the battle of Jena, he wrote to Niethammer that he had seen the Emperor, *diese Weltseele*, this world-soul, riding out through the city. A world that venerates its world-souls has turned the cunning of reason into a calendar of saints, and the satire of moralism lies close by: an order that believes history has ended can only commemorate the spirit, never meet it.

The moralist order has an anthem. Friedrich Schiller's "An die Freude" (1785) hails joy as the daughter of Elysium—*Freude, schöner Götterfunken, / Tochter aus Elysium*—and proclaims that all men become brothers. Beethoven set the poem in the finale of his Ninth Symphony (1824); the Council of Europe adopted the melody as its anthem in 1972, and the European Communities in 1985. On Christmas Day 1989, weeks after the fall of the Berlin Wall, Leonard Bernstein conducted the symphony in Berlin and changed *Freude* to *Freiheit*. The end of history was celebrated as Elysium. A game called *Disco Elysium*, set in a world governed by a moralist international after the defeat of a re-

volution, cannot escape this resonance. Its title names the Elysium of the centre and profanes it. In "In Praise of Profanation" (2005), Giorgio Agamben defined profanation as the return to common use of what had been separated into the sphere of the sacred, and named play as its paradigmatic organ. *Disco Elysium* is a profanation in exactly this sense: it takes the Enlightenment's Elysium, institutionalized as the anthem of a governing order, and returns it to the dance floor.

The game's own portrait of the Moralintern bears out the reading. The Moralist International is a centuries-old organization devoted to gradual progress and a stable world governed by democratic values; its subsidiaries include EPIS, an analogue of NATO or the European Union, and the Coalition that occupies Revachol, whose permitted democracy one character calls market driven. The Thought Cabinet entry *Kingdom of Conscience*, unlocked by choosing four or more options that express neutrality, apoliticism, or a preference for incremental progress, names the Moralintern's ideals Dolorian humanism, after Dolores Dei, and concludes that centrism is not change, not even incremental change, but control, over oneself and the world. It then instructs the thinker to look up at the Coalition airships hanging in the sky, to ask whether there is something sinister in moralism, and to answer no: God is in his heaven, everything is normal on Earth, a deflated echo of Browning's *Pippa Passes*. Its mechanics enact its doctrine. It calms Half Light, the faculty of fear, and makes moralist dialogue heal Morale. Centrism enters Harry's parliament as a sedative. Yet the portrait is not only scathing. The Moralists' colour is blue, after the forget-me-not; their unofficial motto is that for a moment there was hope; and Kim Kitsuragi admits that he was once a believer (Winslow-Yost 2025). An order whose emblem is a flower of remembrance and whose motto is a hope in the past tense is the end of history knowing itself as elegy. Its forget-me-not is the centre's answer to Lethe, and it is an answer made of nostalgia.

5.6 *The Fifth Position*

The game satirizes all four visions, but it is not neutral in tone. Its sympathies lie with the dispossessed—the strikers, the fishing village, the child Cuno—and its contempt with cruelty in every ideological dress. Critics have nonetheless read it in incompatible ways: as communist art, as an anti-communist satire of left sectarianism, as liberal humanism, and as a critique of liberalism. The work sustains these readings because its position is not a fifth doctrine.

That breadth of reading should not be mistaken for symmetry. The satire is asymmetric in kind. Fascism appears as cruelty dressed as science; ultraliberalism as vacuity in the service of power; moralism as the complacent rule to which the others are answers. Communism alone appears as tragedy: a hope that failed, disfigured by its own disaster

in the deserter, mocked in its sectarian heirs, and still honoured in the dignity of the strikers and the memory of the Commune. Read alongside the team's onstage thanks to Marx and Engels, and Helen Hindpere's attribution of the game's strong leftist roots to the creative direction of Kurvitz and Rostov, the work's political centre of gravity is a melancholic, anti-dogmatic Marxist humanism that satirizes left sectarianism as sharply as it satirizes its rivals, but not on the same terms. Readings of the game as anti-communist satire draw on its mockery of the Mazovian students and its portrait of the deserter; this thesis holds that they mistake an internal critique for a repudiation.

The game gives the fifth position a site. At the centre of a Martinaise roundabout stands an equestrian monument to King Filippe III, whom the setting remembers as the Squanderer. It was blown apart by the Communards, damaged by the Coalition's airships when they landed, and restored by young liberal artists; the Commune had destroyed a hundred and forty-one other Filippian monuments (Disco Elysium Wiki). The four political vision quests culminate at this statue, whose appearance changes with Harry's ideology and copotype. In one of its states Kim describes it lit up like a stage, an apricot sceptre in the king's hand and glitter balls about him, a king of disco waiting for a funky beat that will never come. The monument to the squanderer becomes the dance floor's idol: sovereign expenditure, the profanation of royal glory, and the disco's unrealized beat in a single image.

Each of the four visions entails a relation to historical time. Communism, in the deserter's form, is eschatological: it lives toward a future end that has receded into the past. Fascism is mythic: it lives toward a past that never existed. Ultraliberalism inhabits the perpetual present of exchange, in which nothing accumulates but capital. Moralism inhabits a frozen present of management, in which history has ended and only administration remains. Against these, the game sets a fifth temporality, which is rhythmic: the time of return, pulse, and repetition with variation, the time of the dance. Rancière defined politics as the appearance of the part of those who have no part, the disruption of a social order that assigns everyone a place. The strike is such an appearance, and so, Chapter 8 argues, is the disco. The fifth position is not an ideology but a practice, and its theory is the subject of Part Four.

CHAPTER 6

6

Police, Militia, Tribunal

Law, Violence, and the Agency of the Cop

Harry Du Bois is a policeman, and the game's analysis of the self and the city converges on the institution he serves. This chapter reads the Revachol Citizens Militia through the major theories of police power and argues that the game presents the police as a spectral institution—a militia whose foundation, revolutionary or occupational, the setting itself leaves undecided—whose agent can recover his function only by performing it otherwise.

6.1 *The Interpellated Cop*

In "Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses" (1970) Louis Althusser illustrated interpellation with a scene on the street: a police officer calls out, "Hey, you there!", and the individual who turns around, believing that the hail was addressed to him, becomes a subject in the act of turning. The policeman is the paradigmatic agent of interpellation. *Disco Elysium* inverts the scene. Its policeman has forgotten that he is one, and it is he who is hailed—first by the voices of his own body in the dark, then by Kim, who addresses him as "detective," then by witnesses who recognize him and by the faculties that remind him of procedures he cannot recall. The cop must be interpellated as a cop.

The game is explicit about the power the role lends him even in oblivion. It notes, in what one critic calls a sly leftist joke, that people will answer the amnesiac's outlandish questions because everyone is a little afraid of a cop (Winslow-Yost 2025). Interpellation

runs in both directions: Martinaise is hailed by a man who has forgotten that he is the one doing the hailing.

Harry has lost the insignia of his office: his badge, and his service weapon, which, it emerges, he pawned during the binge. Among the confessions the player can offer is that he needed money and so pawned his sidearm, and the union boss, Evrart Claire, whose men are looking for the weapon, remarks drily that they have factored in that Harry pawned it. The recovery of the state's instrument of violence runs through the patronage of the union boss. The body politic of the police has been converted into drinking money, the symbolic instrument of the state into a commodity. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval doctrine that the king possesses a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic. Every officer of the state participates in a minor version of the doctrine. The badge and the gun are the officer's body politic, the material supports of what Žižek, after Lacan, calls *symbolic investiture*: the mandate that makes a man's words carry the authority of an institution. Harry's ruined body natural is all that remains, and the search for his insignia is a search for investiture. The game makes the search optional and its success uncertain, and in doing so it poses the question on which the rest of this chapter turns: what is a policeman without the symbolic efficiency of the police?

Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915), later embedded in *The Trial* (1925), tells of a man from the country who waits his whole life before a door to the Law guarded by a doorkeeper, and learns at his death that the door was meant only for him. Harry stands before the Law in a stranger position. He is one of its doorkeepers and has forgotten it; the door is his, and he must decide whether to walk through it as its officer or past it as a man.

6.2 *The Spectral Police*

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguished law-making violence, which founds a legal order, from law-preserving violence, which maintains it, and identified the police as the institution in which the distinction collapses. Police violence preserves the law and makes it, through decrees issued wherever the law is silent; Benjamin called this a spectral mixture, and described the police's power as formless, nowhere tangible and everywhere present, a ghostly presence in the life of civilized states. Derrida's "Force of Law" (1990) took Benjamin's analysis as the occasion for an inquiry into the mystical foundation of authority, the violence without ground that founds every legal order.

The Revachol Citizens Militia is Benjamin's spectral police in literal form. Its very foundation is undecidable. It is the de facto police of Revachol, a voluntary citizens' bri-

gade turned semi-professional force, and policing is one of the few governmental responsibilities the Coalition concedes to the city; yet whether the citizens or the Coalition founded it is, in the setting's own record, a point of contention. It was formed under the close scrutiny of the Moralintern and the Coalition to restore order after the revolution, but part of its structure predates the Coalition and was conceived by two revolutionary lovers, Julia Dobreva and Jean Abadanaiz, and its officers still repeat an old revolutionary saying (Disco Elysium Wiki; Wikipedia). The law-making violence of the revolution and the law-preserving violence of the occupation are mixed in the institution's foundation, which is exactly Derrida's point about the mystical foundation of authority: no one can say who founded it. Beside it, the Hardie Boys act as the district's de facto peacekeepers, so that Martinaise is policed twice, by a militia of uncertain foundation and by vigilantes. The militia is under-resourced, improvised, and pervasive, handling everything from homicides to the complaints of shopkeepers, and in this it resembles the older sense of "police" that Michel Foucault reconstructed in *Security, Territory, Population* (lectures of 1977–78): the *Polizeiwissenschaft* of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, catalogued in Nicolas Delamare's *Traité de la police* (1705–38), which concerned not crime alone but the whole regulation of welfare, health, commerce, and public order. Harry is a ghost officer in a ghost institution.

Benjamin's essay also names the other pole of the game's politics. Drawing on Georges Sorel's *Reflections on Violence* (1908), he distinguished the political general strike, which seeks to seize the state, from the proletarian general strike, which seeks to abolish it, and characterized the latter as a pure means, a nonviolent suspension of the order of ends. The dockworkers' strike in Martinaise is not Sorel's myth, but it occupies the place of that myth in the game's structure: a collective refusal that suspends the circulation of commodities and that the police, spectral or not, are expected to break.

6.3 *Copotypes and Bad Faith*

The game tracks Harry's conduct as a policeman through a set of *copotypes*: four main ones, Superstar Cop, Apocalypse Cop, Sorry Cop, and Boring Cop, tallied in the journal alongside his political affiliation; a fifth, Honour Cop, unlocked by honour points; and others, among them Art Cop, that the journal does not track. That the game keeps the style of policing and the political allegiance in a single ledger is itself an argument: both are identities performed for an audience. Each names a style of inhabiting the role. In *Being and Nothingness* (1943) Jean-Paul Sartre described a café waiter whose movements are a little too precise and a little too eager, who is *playing at being* a waiter, and diagnosed in his performance the bad faith of a consciousness trying to coincide with a role as a thing coincides with its essence. Erving Goffman's *The Presentation of Self in*

Everyday Life (1956) described social life as performance and identified the "role distance" by which performers signal that they are more than their roles. Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) showed how identities are constituted by the stylized repetition of acts. The copotypes are a repertoire in all three senses.

Each copotype has a lineage. Superstar Cop is the policeman of Guy Debord's *Society of the Spectacle* (1967), for whom being seen has replaced being. Art Cop takes Oscar Wilde at his word in "The Decay of Lying" (1889) that life imitates art far more than art imitates life. Apocalypse Cop is an eschatologist, and the joke at his expense is that he is right: the world is ending, and the Pale is its evidence. Sorry Cop is Camus's Jean-Baptiste Clamence in *The Fall* (1956), the judge-penitent of a bar in Amsterdam, who accuses himself in order to earn the right to judge others. Honour Cop is Raymond Chandler's detective in "The Simple Art of Murder" (1944), a man of honour who walks the mean streets without being mean.

Nikolai Gogol's "Diary of a Madman" (1835), whose minor clerk Poprishchin comes to believe that he is the King of Spain, is the ancestor of the grandiose copotypes: a functionary whose self-inflation is at once comic and a cry against a hierarchy that has given him nothing.

Boring Cop deserves particular attention, because the game reserves for it a quiet dignity. In "Politik als Beruf" (1919) Max Weber defined politics as *ein starkes langsames Bohren von harten Brettern mit Leidenschaft und Augenmaß zugleich*—a strong and slow boring of hard boards, with passion and a sense of proportion at once. The English pun is the work's and Weber's together. The boring cop is the cop who bores: who does the slow, unglamorous work of procedure with what Weber called the ethic of responsibility. Against the copotypes of spectacle, aestheticism, apocalypse, and penance, Boring Cop is the Odyssean choice of the Myth of Er transposed into the police: the life of a man who does his work. Kim Kitsuragi is its exemplar.

6.4 *The Hanged Man and the Tribunal*

The body at the centre of the case is Colonel Ellis 'Lely' Kortenaer, the commander of the Krenel mercenaries hired by Wild Pines to break the strike. It hangs from a tree in the yard behind the Whirling-in-Rags, rotting through the days of the investigation. The dockworkers' vigilante crew led by Titus Hardie claims to have lynched him for attempting to rape Klaasje. The claim is false. Lely was shot in the mouth from the island by the deserter, Iosef Lilianovich Dros, during consensual sex with Klaasje. Klaasje, a former corporate spy who feared the authorities and could not tell where the bullet had come from, turned to Ruby, a union sympathizer, who staged the hanging with the Hardie Boys; the attempted-rape story was offered as its motive. Each woman later

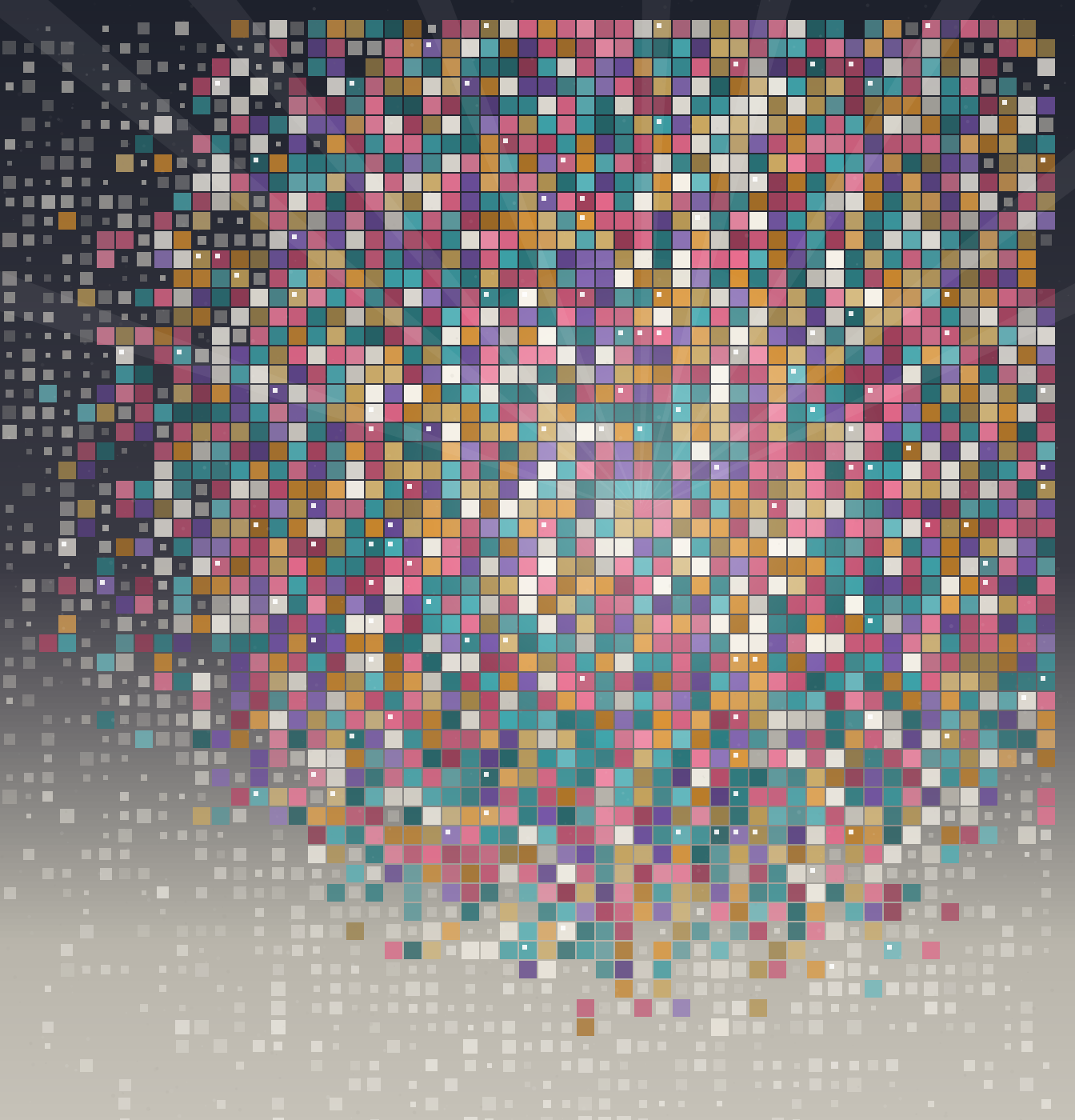
names the other as the author of the plan. Klaasje's account casts Ruby as the instigator, the name the case gives her, while Ruby, when found, insists that the cover-up was Klaasje's idea. The structure of the lie has a terrible history. In *Southern Horrors: Lynch Law in All Its Phases* (1892), Ida B. Wells documented how the lynching of Black men in the American South was routinely justified by false accusations of sexual assault, and how the accusation functioned as the theatre that made murder appear as justice. The game's victim and circumstances are entirely different, but its staged lynching reproduces the narrative form Wells exposed, and the investigation consists in dismantling that theatre.

Wells named the perpetrators and the motive. Her campaign began in Memphis, where in March 1892 a white mob took Thomas Moss, Calvin McDowell, and Will Stewart, the Black owners of the People's Grocery, whose business had drawn customers from a white-owned rival, from the jail in which they were held and shot them dead. When Wells wrote that the charge of rape was a pretext, a mob destroyed the offices of her newspaper, *Free Speech*, and she could not return to the city. *Southern Horrors* showed that lynchings were carried out by white mobs, frequently with the complicity of local officials and police, and that the accusation of rape concealed economic and political motives. The limit of the parallel must be stated as precisely as the parallel itself: Lely was the commander of a mercenary unit, not a member of a persecuted people, and the body hanged in the yard was already dead. What the game reproduces is the form Wells exposed—a sexual accusation deployed to convert violence arising from an economic conflict, here a strike, into communal justice.

The hanged man has a mythic genealogy as well. In the *Hávamál* of the *Poetic Edda*, Odin recounts that he hung for nine nights on the windy tree, wounded with a spear, "offered I was / To Othin, myself to myself" (Henry Adams Bellows's translation, 1923), and gained the runes by his sacrifice. Lely's corpse becomes, like Odin's, a source of knowledge: through forensic examination, and through Inland Empire's eerie conversation with the dead, the hanged body yields the case. Harry, whose binge was a sacrifice of himself to himself, is the hanged man's double, and the game says so in its own imagery. In the first night's nightmare Harry discovers himself as the hanged man beneath a disco ball, and his own dead body tells him that everything is hopeless and that he will fail to solve the case or put his life back together (Wikipedia); in the game's dialogue the corpse, listed as the Bloated Corpse of a Drunk, adds that he has only ever been talking to himself, even in his dreams, and that the act is wearing thin. The Hanged Man of the tarot, suspended upside down in contemplative surrender, is the card of reversal, and the case reverses everything it touches. Chapter 2 introduced the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled to purify a city. Lely is Martinaise's *pharmakos*: an outsider whose death is made to bear a collective meaning it did not have.

The hanged man also gives Harry back his name. When Harry, in one of the game's visions, styles himself Tequila Sunset, the hanged man answers that he is no Tequila Sunset, he is probably just Harry. As the shades of the *Odyssey*'s eleventh book tell Odysseus what he must know, the corpse tells the detective who he is; and since, in the nightmare, the hanged body is Harry's own, he learns his name from his own death, a being-toward-death in the most literal sense.

The climax of the case is not its solution but the Tribunal. The surviving Krenel mercenaries return to the yard to take retribution on the Hardie Boys, who have publicly claimed the lynching, in a standoff the game calls the Tribunal. It collapses into a gunfight between the mercenaries and the dockworkers whose course depends on Harry's faculties and the dice: none, some, or all of the Hardie Boys and the mercenaries may die, Kim may be wounded and hospitalized, in which case the child Cuno offers to take his place as Harry's partner; Harry himself is shot and lies unconscious for days. Aeschylus's *Eumenides* had shown the Furies' vendetta transformed into the first court of law. Revachol has no Areopagus. Its justice is either the vendetta of armed men in a yard or the administration of an occupier, and the working title *No Truce With The Furies* names that absence exactly. Dashiell Hammett's *Red Harvest* (1929) had imagined a mining town, Personville, which its inhabitants called Poisonville, delivered to gangsters after its owner hired strikebreakers in a labour dispute, and a detective, the Continental Op, who feels himself going "blood-simple" as he plays the factions against one another. The second season of *The Wire* (2003) relocated the same matter to the Baltimore docks and a dying stevedores' union. *Disco Elysium* inherits both, but it denies its detective the Op's descent into violence as a method. In a world without a court, the only justice available to Harry is the truth of the investigation and the fidelity of the partnership, and the game will argue that these are not nothing.



PART THREE

The Pale and the Dance

III

Die Entropie der Welt strebt einem Maximum zu.

— Rudolf Clausius (1865)

pars pedibus plaudunt choreas et carmina dicunt.

— Virgil, *Aeneid* VI.644

CHAPTER 7

7

The Pale

Entropy, Hauntology, and the Negative Sublime

The Pale is the setting's most original invention: a grey continuum between the isolas in which matter, physical law, memory, and time come apart; a medium that can be crossed only by specialized means, whose prolonged exposure corrodes the mind, and of which, in Joyce Messier's words, one of the few measurable effects is that it is expanding at an unknown rate. This chapter argues that the Pale is entropy rendered as geography and as history, and that it literalizes the "end of history" not as the triumph of a final form of government but as thermodynamic equilibrium.

The game's own protagonist states the homology this thesis defends. In one exchange Harry declares that everything is related to the Pale: his condition, the case, everything; it is all entroponetic. Kim, for his part, remarks drily that he cannot stop a grown man from learning about the fundamental geographic and entroponetic features of their world. The isomorphism of self, case, and world is not the critic's imposition. Harry proposes it himself, in the game's own technical vocabulary.

7.1 *Thermodynamics of History*

In 1865 Rudolf Clausius condensed the mechanical theory of heat into two sentences: the energy of the world is constant; the entropy of the world tends toward a maximum. William Thomson, later Lord Kelvin, had already published "On a Universal Tendency

in Nature to the Dissipation of Mechanical Energy" (1852), from which the image of the universe's heat death—the *Wärmetod*, a final state of uniform temperature in which no work is possible—soon followed. Ludwig Boltzmann gave entropy its statistical form, and the equation that relates it to the number of microscopic arrangements compatible with a macroscopic state is engraved on his tomb in Vienna. Entropy is the measure of indifference: the degree to which the world has lost the differences that make things happen.

Henry Adams was the first historian to take the second law as a theory of history. In the twenty-fifth chapter of *The Education of Henry Adams* (privately printed 1907; published 1918), "The Dynamo and the Virgin," he described standing before the dynamos of the Paris Exposition of 1900 and feeling them as a moral force, as early Christians had felt the Cross, and set against them the Virgin of Chartres, the greatest force the Western world had known. "The Rule of Phase Applied to History" (1909) and *A Letter to American Teachers of History* (1910) went further, arguing that the degradation of energy governs social as well as physical systems and that history is running down. Adams's polarity reappears in Revachol with uncanny exactness. Dolores Dei, the Marian Innocence, is the Virgin; Wild Pines, the shipping conglomerate whose logistics organize the world, is the Dynamo; and the Pale is the entropic horizon toward which, on Adams's theory, both forces are spent.

The philosophical tradition of the end of history runs from Hegel through Alexandre Kojève's Paris seminars of the 1930s to Fukuyama. It conceived the end as completion: the final reconciliation of freedom and recognition in a universal homogeneous state. *Disco Elysium* rewrites completion as exhaustion. A universal homogeneous state is, in thermodynamic terms, a state of maximum entropy, in which no gradient remains to drive a process and no difference to be contested. The end of history is heat death. Nietzsche had already given its inhabitants their name in the prologue to *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* (1883): *Wir haben das Glück erfunden—sagen die letzten Menschen und blinzeln*—"we have invented happiness," say the last men, and they blink. The citizens of the Moralintern are last men who blink at the Pale.

7.2 *Capitalist Realism Literalized*

Mark Fisher's *Capitalist Realism* (2009) defined its subject as the widespread sense that capitalism is the only viable political and economic system and that it is now impossible even to imagine a coherent alternative to it. Fisher's book begins from a dictum attributed to Fredric Jameson and Slavoj Žižek: that it has become easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism. *Disco Elysium* literalizes the dictum. The end of the world is, in its setting, a documented phenomenon, the object of a science—entro-

ponetics, a word the game uses dozens of times—and of calm discussion with a corporate negotiator; the end of capitalism is unimaginable to nearly everyone in Martinaise, and the one man who has never stopped imagining it has turned his imagination into murder.

Franco "Bifo" Berardi's *After the Future* (2011) named the condition of the decades after 1977 the "slow cancellation of the future," a phrase Fisher made the refrain of his hauntology. The Pale is that cancellation given extension and colour. It devours the past, since what enters it is lost to memory, and it swallows the future, since it advances on every coast. Revachol's architecture is hauntological in Fisher's sense: bullet scars from the revolution, monuments to a monarchy that no longer exists, commercial premises that cannot sustain a business, a church awaiting a congregation that will never come. The city is a ruin of two futures, the royalist and the communist, and the Pale is the material form of the future's disappearance.

The name is itself instructive. Historically, a *pale* was a fenced boundary that defined a zone of jurisdiction: the English Pale around medieval Dublin, from which the idiom "beyond the pale" derives; the Pale of Calais; the Pale of Settlement, to which the Russian Empire confined most of its Jewish subjects from 1791 to 1917. In each case the pale divided an inside from an outside. The Pale of Elysium inverts the term. It is not the fence of civilization but the void between civilizations, and it implies that every inhabited place is a precarious island beyond the pale.

The setting's own texts support this reading directly. In the novel that preceded the game, the Pale is said to be made of the past, "the world's memory of the world," and the story ends in an entroponetic catastrophe in which its boundaries expand. Those who venture too far into it disappear, and in the setting's lore even their images may fade from photographs while the people who knew them begin to forget. In the game, Steban, the Student Communist, reports that many infra-materialists, the setting's Marxist theorists, regard the Pale as a manifestation of nostalgia and historical inertia, and that revolution may generate a counter-force that keeps it from expanding (Winslow-Yost 2025). The Insulindian Phasmid itself, in the game's final encounter, calls the Pale a nervous shadow cast into the world by human beings, eating away at reality, and says that its advent coincides with the arrival of the human mind. Ruby, the case's chief suspect, says simply that the Pale is the end of the world. The thermodynamic reading is therefore drawn from the setting's own speculations rather than imposed on them: an expanding medium of the past that only collective transformation can hold back is entropy, and its counter-force is what Part Four calls the dissipative commons.

7.3 *Whiteness, Snow, Mist, Nothing*

The Pale has a literary ancestry of white and grey voids. In the forty-second chapter of *Moby-Dick* (1851), "The Whiteness of the Whale," Ishmael explains the terror of whiteness: it is the visible absence of colour and the concrete of all colours at once, and he calls it "a colorless, all-color of atheism from which we shrink." The Pale is Melville's whiteness rendered as grey, the colour of indifference rather than of terror, and it does not provoke a hunt. In the chapter "Schnee" of Thomas Mann's *The Magic Mountain* (1924), Hans Castorp loses himself in a blizzard above the sanatorium and, in a white-out that abolishes direction and form, dreams of a sunlit people living in grace beside a temple in which two hags dismember a child. He wakes with a single italicized conviction: *Der Mensch soll um der Güte und Liebe willen dem Tode keine Herrschaft einräumen über seine Gedanken*—for the sake of goodness and love, man shall grant death no dominion over his thoughts. Castorp forgets the insight by dinner. Harry, emerging from his own white-out, has the opportunity to remember it.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), filmed by Tarkovsky in 1972, imagines a planetary ocean that materializes the memories of the scientists orbiting it, returning to the psychologist Kris Kelvin a simulacrum of his dead wife. The Pale is Solaris inverted: Lem's ocean makes memory flesh, while the Pale makes flesh forget. Kazuo Ishiguro's *The Buried Giant* (2015) imagines a post-Arthurian Britain under a mist of forgetting, exhaled by the she-dragon Querig, which has kept peace between Britons and Saxons by erasing their memory of mutual atrocity; to slay the dragon is to restore memory and with it the war. The Moralintern's peace in Revachol has the same structure. It is founded on forgetting the Commune, and the investigation, by restoring memory, threatens the peace. Michael Ende's *The Neverending Story* (1979) pictured the Nothing that devours Fantastica as human beings lose the capacity to wish, and its wolf Gmork explains that creatures who fall into it pass into the human world as lies and delusions; the 1984 film compressed the point into his remark that people without hope are easy to control. The Pale is the Nothing without Gmork's cynicism to explain it.

7.4 *Zones, Tracts, Areas*

The speculative fiction of the late twentieth century produced a genre of anomalous zones. The Strugatskys' *Roadside Picnic* (1972) imagined the Zones left behind by an alien visitation indifferent to humanity, scavenged by "stalkers" for artifacts whose functions no one understands; the novel ends with Redrick Schuhart before a golden sphere said to grant wishes, crying out a wish for happiness for everyone, freely given, with no

one left out. Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) turned the Zone into a pilgrimage through ruin. M. John Harrison's *Light* (2002) imagined the Kefahuchi Tract, a region of space where physical law breaks down and around which human culture accretes in fascinated decay; Harrison, who has also written mordantly against worldbuilding as a surveyor's compulsion to map what should remain unknown, thereby supplies the counterweight to Kurvitz's maximalism. Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation* (2014) imagined Area X, a coastal wilderness that absorbs and transforms those who enter it. Thomas Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) made occupied Germany in 1945 "the Zone," a space without sovereign in which its hero, Tyrone Slothrop, is gradually scattered until he ceases to be a person.

The Pale belongs to this genre and departs from it. Every Zone, Tract, and Area generates: artifacts, stories, desires, pilgrimages, transformations. The Pale generates nothing. It is the negative Zone, a region from which no artifact returns and no wish is granted. Its relation to Kurvitz's worldbuilding is dialectical. A setting mapped with encyclopedic density is bounded on every side by the one region that cannot be mapped at all, and Harrison's objection to worldbuilding is answered from within the world: the most exhaustively built of fictional worlds contains, as its outer limit, the unbuildable.

Kurvitz's own theory of worldbuilding is the opposite of Harrison's suspicion. He has called it messianic and "a vital psychological service to your fellow man," names Elysium rather than any book or game as his life's work, and describes it as a collection of ideas in the form of another world and a tool for analysing ours (Winslow-Yost 2025). The Pale is where that ambition meets its limit: the one region of a world built to blot out our reality that cannot itself be built.

7.5 *The Apophatic Sublime*

In the *Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful* (1757), Edmund Burke observed that "All general privations are great, because they are all terrible; Vacuity, Darkness, Solitude and Silence." Kant's *Critique of Judgment* (1790) distinguished the mathematical sublime of magnitude from the dynamical sublime of might, nature as a power that has no dominion over us because reason exceeds it. Jean-François Lyotard's "The Sublime and the Avant-Garde" (1984) relocated the sublime in the bare occurrence of the event, the question *arrive-t-il?*, is it happening? The Pale is sublime in all three senses: a privation, a might, and an occurrence that cannot be presented. It is also apophatic. The *Mystical Theology* of Pseudo-Dionysius (c. 500) taught that God is approached by negation, through a darkness beyond light; Meister Eckhart spoke of the divine *Nichts*. Entroponetics is a negative theology without God: a discipline that can say only what the Pale is not.

Fredric Jameson's *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (1991) described a postmodern or "hysterical" sublime, the euphoric disorientation produced by a world system too vast to be represented, and proposed *cognitive mapping* as the political task of an art that would restore to individuals a sense of their place in that totality. The Pale is the unmappable totality given its proper image. It is not capitalism, and the game never allegorizes it so crudely; it is the condition that capitalism, as the game's world presents it, has accelerated and cannot halt: the exhaustion of difference. The question of Part Three is therefore whether anything can sustain difference against it. The game's answer is in its title.

The game contains a literal machine for that task. Ruby's pale latitude compressor, built from frequency calculations she found in radio-enthusiast magazines, forces a grid of signals onto the Pale; by her account it imposes dimensions on something that does not have them and crunches the distance across it. Its field causes extreme pain to anyone caught in it, the people who man the repeater stations out in the Pale lose their minds within a few years, and she tested the field on herself first, as the ethical thing to do. Cognitive mapping of the unmappable appears in Martinaise as an instrument of torture, built by a fugitive hiding beneath an abandoned research building.

CHAPTER 8



Disco

Dionysus, Dépense, and the Daughter of Elysium

If the Pale is the image of history's exhaustion, disco is the image of what resists it. This chapter argues that the title of *Disco Elysium* is neither ornament nor irony but the most compressed statement of its philosophy: Elysium is, in its classical sources, a place of play and dance, and disco is, in its historical sources, the last collective utopia of the twentieth century. The chapter culminates in the claim that the disco cop is the figure in which police becomes politics.

8.1 *Elysium from Homer to Schiller*

The Elysian plain first appears in the fourth book of the *Odyssey* (IV.561–569), where Proteus tells Menelaus that he will not die in Argos but will be sent to the ends of the earth, where fair-haired Rhadamanthys dwells and life is easiest for men, without snow or storm or rain, refreshed by the West Wind. Hesiod's *Works and Days* (167–173) places the heroes of the fourth race on the Isles of the Blessed beside deep-swirling Ocean; Pindar's *Second Olympian* (476 BCE) admits to the tower of Kronos those who have kept their souls from wrong through three lives on each side of death. Elysium is an afterlife for the few, at the margin of the world.

Virgil gave Elysium its decisive form, and the passage bears directly on the game's title. When Aeneas enters the groves of the blessed in the sixth book of the *Aeneid*, the poet describes a place with a light of its own: *largior hic campos aether et lumine vestit /*

purpureo, solemque suum, sua sidera norunt (6.640–641)—here a more generous air clothes the fields in purple light, and they know their own sun and their own stars. The souls are at play: *pars in gramineis exercent membra palaestris, / contendunt ludo et fulva luctantur harena; / pars pedibus plaudunt choreas et carmina dicunt* (6.642–644)—some exercise on grassy grounds, contend in play, and wrestle on the yellow sand; some beat out dances with their feet and chant songs. Orpheus, the Thracian priest in his long robe, accompanies them on seven strings (6.645–646). Virgil's Elysium is a field of *ludus* and *chorea* under purple light, with its own sun and stars, and a musician at its centre. *Disco Elysium* is a game named for a dance floor of the dead, and the name is Virgilian in its exactness.

The musician of Virgil's Elysium brings with him a myth the game follows to its harder end. Orpheus descended to the underworld for Eurydice, moved its rulers with his song, and lost her at the threshold because he could not keep from looking back (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X). Harry is an Orpheus who has already lost: a man whose music, disco, is the power he claims, and whose ruin is a backward glance at Dora that he cannot stop repeating. The game does not restore Eurydice. It asks whether the singer can turn his face forward.

Schiller's ode, discussed in Chapter 5 as the anthem of the centre, gives the classical Elysium its modern, Enlightenment sense: joy is Elysium's daughter, and under her wings all men become brothers. The trajectory from Virgil to Schiller is the trajectory from an aristocratic afterlife to a universalist utopia. The game takes the trajectory one step further. In Revachol everyone lives after their own death: the deserter after the revolution, René after the monarchy, Harry after himself, the city after its future. Elysium is not a reward for heroes but the condition of a post-historical world, and the question is whether its dead can still dance.

The title holds both meanings at once. Kurvitz's gloss, discussed in the Introduction, reads *disco* as Latin; the game's world reads it as music. The dance floor of the dead is also a schoolroom, and the afterlife of history is something to be learned.

8.2 *Apollo and Dionysus in a Motor Carriage*

Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) derived Attic tragedy from the union of two artistic drives. The Apollonian is the drive of dream, form, measure, and individuation; the Dionysian is the drive of intoxication and music, which shatters what Schopenhauer had called the *principium individuationis* and dissolves the individual into the primordial unity of life. Tragedy arises when the Dionysian chorus, the ground of the drama, projects the Apollonian image of the hero, so that Dionysus speaks the language of Apollo.

Kim Kitsuragi and Harry Du Bois are Apollo and Dionysus sharing a motor carriage. Kim is measure, form, procedure, the notebook, the steady gaze and the reserve that never breaks; Harry is intoxication, music, dissolution, and the grief that breaks through every form. Their partnership is the fraternal union that Nietzsche identified as tragedy's essence, and the skills are its chorus: the Dionysian multitude from which, at each turn of dialogue, the Apollonian image of "Harry" is projected and to which it returns. Nietzsche's Zarathustra supplies the game's creed: *man muss noch Chaos in sich haben, um einen tanzenden Stern gebären zu können*—one must still have chaos in oneself to give birth to a dancing star—and *ich würde nur an einen Gott glauben, der zu tanzen verstünde*—I would believe only in a god who knew how to dance. Harry has chaos in abundance. The question is whether it can be made to dance.

8.3 *Disco as Historical Utopia*

Disco emerged in the early 1970s in New York, in the downtown lofts and clubs of Black, Latino, and gay communities. David Mancuso's Loft, opened in 1970, admitted guests by invitation to an egalitarian dance floor; the Paradise Garage, where Larry Levan played from 1977 to 1987, made the DJ a priest of collective ecstasy. Tim Lawrence's *Love Saves the Day* (2003) and Alice Echols's *Hot Stuff* (2010) reconstructed this history. In "In Defence of Disco," published in the socialist journal *Gay Left* in the summer of 1979, Richard Dyer argued against the left's contempt for disco that its eroticism, diffused through the whole body rather than concentrated in rock's phallic thrust, its romanticism, and its frank materialism could be progressive. Disco was a form of what Kristin Ross, describing the Commune, called communal luxury: pleasure and beauty claimed by those excluded from them.

On 12 July 1979, at Comiskey Park in Chicago, a radio promotion called Disco Demolition Night ended in the destruction of disco records and a riot on the field, and the backlash it crystallized carried unmistakable racial and homophobic overtones. The same year, Margaret Thatcher took office in Britain in May, and in October the Federal Reserve under Paul Volcker began the monetary shock that historians treat as the threshold of the neoliberal era. Disco's death and the neoliberal turn are coeval. Studio 54, which opened in 1977 with a door policy that turned admission into a spectacle of exclusion, had already shown how disco's utopia could be converted into its opposite. Harry's identification with disco is therefore not a mere joke about bad taste. It is fidelity to the last collective utopia of the long 1970s, the moment before the turn.

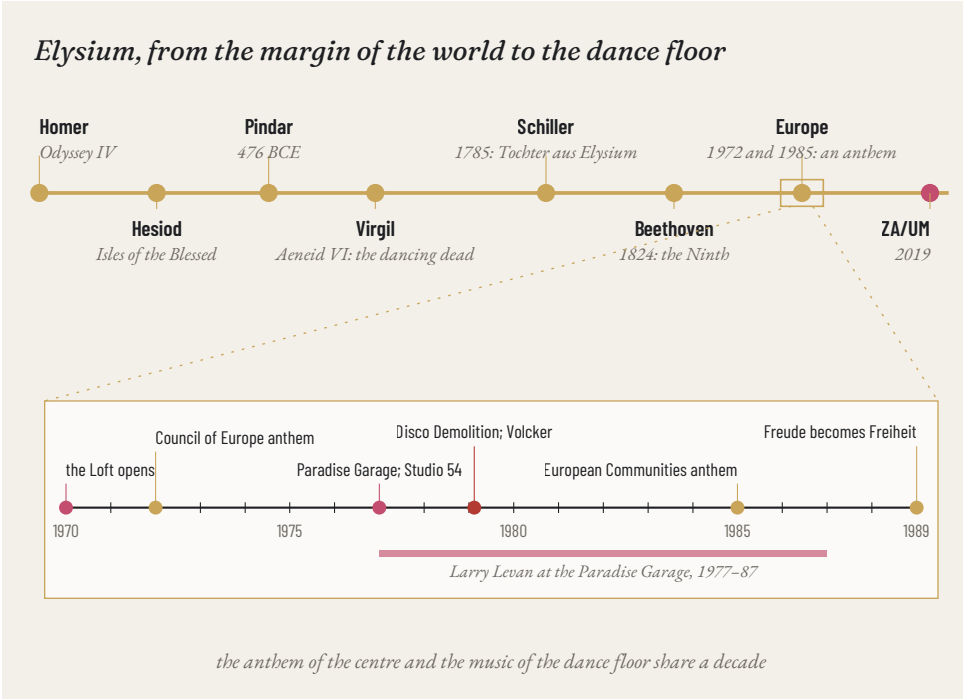


FIGURE 8.1 *Elysium from the margin of the world to the dance floor, with the disco decade enlarged.* The anthem of the centre and the music of the dance floor share the 1970s.

The music that accompanies the game is not disco: its score by British Sea Power is melancholy indie rock. Disco in *Disco Elysium* is an absent music, a horizon rather than a sound. The word itself, from the French *discothèque*, a record library, names an archive, and the game's disco is an archive of lost records in the hauntological sense. Fisher's writing on The Caretaker, the project of Leyland Kirby, is the closest analogue: *Everywhere at the End of Time* (2016–2019) renders the six stages of dementia through recordings of 1930s ballroom music progressively degraded into noise, and the project's name derives from the ghostly ballroom of Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980). Disco Elysium is a ballroom at the end of time.

The score keeps its own counsel on this point. Several of its pieces rework earlier songs by the band, two of them from an album titled *Let the Dancers Inherit the Party* (2017), one of which became the music called "The Insulindian Miracle" (Wikipedia). The game's miracle is scored from a record that promises the party to its dancers.

The game's own history of disco complicates this account and sharpens it. In Elysium, disco is the music of a particular euphoria. Guillaume le Million, whose grin Harry wears (section 2.2), rose to fame in the market's brief moment of seeming triumph and

died before the next decade ended, in circumstances the game offers as a metaphor for Revachol in those years (Winslow-Yost 2025). His very name echoes that of a king of the Suzerainty, Guillaume 'Le Lion': in the passage from lion to million the setting compresses the passage from monarchy to market. Disco in the game is therefore both the commons of the dance floor and the soundtrack of a market's brief triumph, and Harry's frozen grin is a relic of the latter. The dialectic this chapter attributes to disco is internal to the game. The same music names a commodity euphoria and a collective joy, and the work's question is which of the two Harry's dancing will serve. The ravers' plan for the Dolorian church, discussed in section 8.6, is the game's answer from below.

8.4 *Dépense and the Libidinal Economy*

Georges Bataille's "The Notion of Expenditure" (1933) and *The Accursed Share* (1949) distinguished the restricted economy of production and accumulation from the general economy of energy, in which every system receives more energy than it needs to subsist and must spend the surplus, either gloriously, in festival, sacrifice, art, and eroticism, or catastrophically, in war. Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) had described the potlatch, in which wealth is destroyed to establish rank. Sovereignty, for Bataille, is the moment that serves nothing.

Harry's binge was a catastrophic potlatch of the self: a destruction of wealth, health, memory, and dignity in an expenditure that served nothing and nearly killed him. Electrochemistry is the voice of the accursed share, the energy that demands to be spent. The game does not ask Harry to stop spending, which would be the restricted economy's answer and Wild Pines's. It asks whether the same energy can be spent gloriously rather than catastrophically, collectively rather than alone, rhythmically rather than in a single convulsion. That is the difference between the binge and the dance. Jean-François Lyotard's *Libidinal Economy* (1974) and Deleuze and Guattari's *Anti-Oedipus* (1972) recast desire as production rather than lack; the latter proposed that a schizophrenic out for a walk is a better model than a neurotic on the analyst's couch. Harry's long walk through Martinaise, open to every voice and every encounter, is the schizo-stroll of *Anti-Oedipus* conducted by a policeman.

8.5 *Dervish, Totentanz, Gyre: The Whirling-in-Rags*

The name of the hostel where the game begins condenses its philosophy, and its elements can now be unfolded. *Rags*: Marx's *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* (1852) described the *Lumpenproletariat*—literally the proletariat in rags—as the disintegrated mass of vagabonds, discharged soldiers, swindlers, and ragpickers that the

French call *la bohème*, and distrusted it as the reserve army of reaction. Baudelaire's "Le Vin des chiffonniers" in *Les Fleurs du mal* (1857) offered a different image of the same figure:

> *On voit un chiffonnier qui vient, hochant la tête,*
> *Butant, et se cognant aux murs comme un poète,*
> *Et, sans prendre souci des mouchards, ses sujets,*
> *Épanche tout son cœur en glorieux projets.*

The drunken ragpicker staggers against the walls like a poet and, heedless of the police informers whom he treats as his subjects, pours out his heart in glorious projects, swearing oaths and dictating sublime laws. Benjamin made the ragpicker the emblem of the critical historian who gathers the refuse of the past. Harry is Baudelaire's ragpicker in uniform: a drunk who legislates sublimely and whose subjects are, absurdly, the police.

Michel Foucault's *History of Madness* (1961) opens with the *Narrenschiff*, the ship of fools that Sebastian Brant's satire (1494) and Bosch's painting made emblematic, which carried the mad from city to city before the great confinement of the seventeenth century shut them away. The Whirling-in-Rags is a ship of fools at its moorings, and Harry's freedom to wander rather than be confined is the condition of the investigation.

Whirling: the Mevlevi order founded in the wake of Jalal al-Din Rumi turned the *samāʿ*, the ceremony of listening, into a turning dance in which the dervish seeks *fanāʾ*, the annihilation of the self, and *baqāʾ*, its subsistence in God. Rumi's *Masnavi* opens with the lament of a reed flute cut from its reed-bed, which sings of separation. Harry's grief for Dora is the reed's lament, and his binge a false *fanāʾ*—an annihilation without subsistence. The dance would be the true one.

The late medieval *danse macabre* belongs to the same constellation, and it has a Tallinn address. Bernt Notke's Lübeck *Totentanz* (1463) was destroyed by bombing in 1942; a fragment of his *Danse Macabre* survives in the church of St Nicholas (Niguliste) in Tallinn, the city in which the ZA/UM collective first formed. In it, skeletal figures lead pope, emperor, empress, cardinal, and king in a round, levelling the estates of the world in a single dance. *Disco Elysium* is a *Totentanz* for the post-historical age, in which every ideology and every class—royalist, communist, capitalist, moralist, cop, and dockworker—dances toward the Pale. Dante's second circle adds the erotic register: *La bufera infernal, che mai non resta* (Inferno V.31), the infernal hurricane that never rests, whirls the souls of the lustful, among them Francesca, who explains that *Amor, ch'a nullo amato amar perdona* (V.103)—love absolves no one beloved from loving. Harry and his memory of Dora are caught in Francesca's whirlwind.

The game supplies its own emblem of this conjunction. In the first night's nightmare, discussed in section 6.4, Harry finds himself as the hanged man beneath a disco ball whose spots are fading, and the corpse that speaks to him is his own. The dance of death and the dance floor are fused in a single image.

Yeats's "The Second Coming" (1920) gives the whirling its historical form:

> *Turning and turning in the widening gyre*
> *The falcon cannot hear the falconer;*
> *Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold;*
> *Mere anarchy is loosed upon the world.*

The centre that cannot hold is at once the centre of the moralist order and the centre of Harry's psyche, and Yeats's *A Vision* (1925) elaborated a theory of history as interpenetrating gyres. Finally, Norbert Wiener's *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950) described living beings as whirlpools in a river of ever-flowing water, patterns that perpetuate themselves rather than stuff that abides. The Whirling-in-Rags is thus a single emblem with six faces: the cybernetic self, the proletariat in rags, the drunken legislator, the dervish, the dance of death, and the gyre of history. All of them answer the same question: how does a pattern persist when its substance is in flight?

The name, it should be said, has a documented source: it is taken from a lyric in the British Sea Power song "Hail Holy Queen" (2013) (Wikipedia). The six faces unfolded above are constellations in the sense set out in the Introduction, readings of what the name has come to hold, not claims about where it came from.

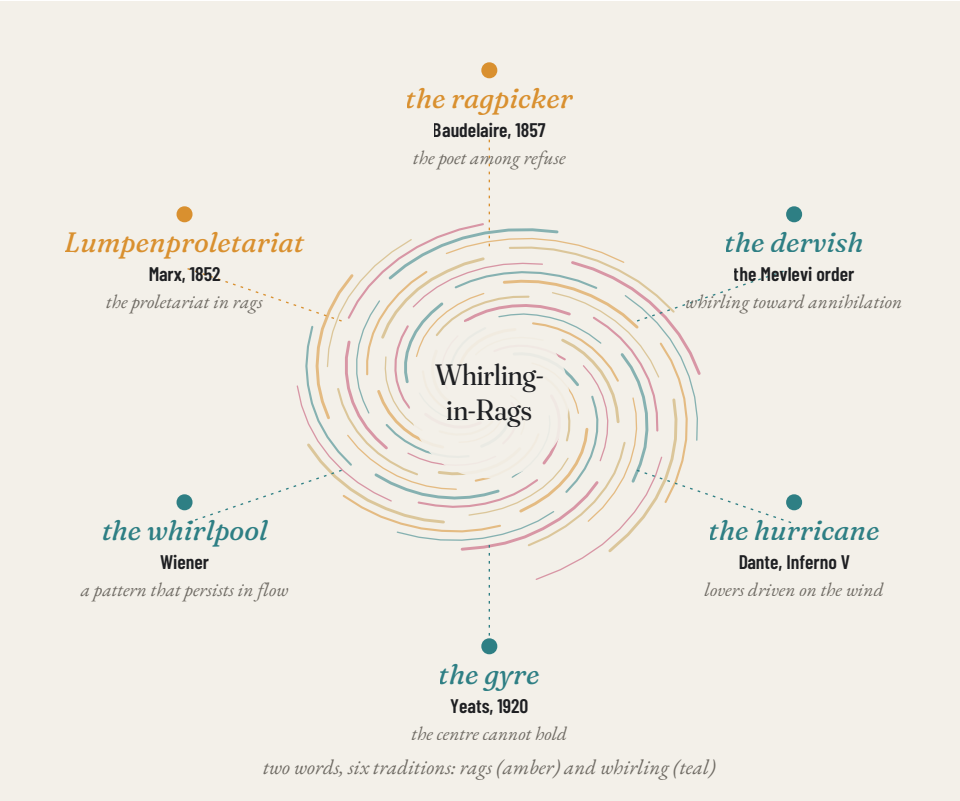


FIGURE 8.2 *Six faces of a name, grouped by its two words.* The name comes from a British Sea Power lyric; the six faces are constellations, not sources.

8.6 *Choreopolice and Choreopolitics*

Jacques Rancière's *Disagreement* (1995) and "Ten Theses on Politics" (2001) distinguished *the police*, understood as the order that distributes bodies, places, and functions and defines what is visible and sayable, from *politics*, the disruption of that order by those who have no part in it. The police's characteristic injunction, Rancière wrote, is to keep moving: move along, there is nothing to see here. André Lepecki's "Choreopolice and Choreopolitics" (*TDR*, 2013) drew the consequence for dance. The police is a choreographer that regulates circulation and forbids lingering; the dancer's task is to reinvent movement, to stop where one is supposed to pass, and to compose with others a different occupation of space.

Harry is a policeman who will not move along. He lingers beside a corpse that the district wishes forgotten, beside strikers whom the order wishes dispersed, beside ob-

jects, ruins, and a cryptid that the order considers beneath notice. Shivers, the faculty that opens him to the city's life, is choreopolitical attention given a numerical value; the game's clock, which advances only through action and speech, turns lingering into a mechanic. The Dolorian Church of Humanity, by Kim's account the only one of the coast's seven stave churches, the Seven Sisters, not burnt or dismantled during the revolution, is the game's counter-site of the police. Four young ravers, led by Andre, want to turn it into a club for what they call anodic dance music; a programmer, Soona, has come to study an anomaly inside it, around which the church may have been built to contain it. Harry can broker a settlement in which the scientist and the dancers share the building. A dance floor organized around an anomaly, under a roof that survived the revolution, is the dissipative commons in miniature: a place where circulation stops and a collective body forms at the edge of the inexplicable. The disco cop is therefore not a comic oxymoron but the figure of a transformation. In him the agent of the police order becomes, at moments and against his training, a dancer, and police becomes politics. This is the first and most compact formulation of the dissipative commons that Part Four theorizes.

The game lets Harry dance there, and it refuses to make the moment sublime. Kim later teases him that his moves on the church floor were just jump aerobics; elsewhere the Spinal Cord judges one of Harry's episodes to be definitely not a normal dance-floor experience. The old revolutionary on the island, for his part, calls the church God's shithouse and says it should have been dismantled for firewood, as it would have been in Graad. The dissipative commons is comic, clumsy, and contested from more than one flank: the revenant of the revolution would burn it, and its dancer cannot dance. That it persists anyway is the point.

The church is a counter-site of the police in the most literal sense. It was abandoned, Kim explains, after a police raid that he has heard shot the place to pieces, and he adds that Harry's own station was involved, though he cannot be sure. The ravers' club rises in a building that the revolution spared and the police wrecked, and Harry even suspects entroponetic crosstalk there. And the voice that speaks when Harry dances there is the Ancient Reptilian Brain, which otherwise addresses him only when he is unconscious, asleep, or incapacitated. When a cop whose station may have raided this church dances on its floor in the voice of his own death drive, choreopolice becomes choreopolitics on the very site of its violence, and the danse macabre stops being a metaphor imposed on the game: it is how the game distributes its voices.

CHAPTER 9



9

Genealogies

The Detective, the Holy Fool, the Fisher King

This chapter situates *Disco Elysium* within the generic and mythic traditions it inherits and transforms: the detective story from its rationalist origins to its metaphysical dissolution; the Dostoevskian novel of consciousness; the figures of the knight-errant, the pure fool, and the wounded king; the lineage of the role-playing game; and the speculative and modernist fiction that offers its closest comparanda. Its thesis is that the work completes each tradition by inverting it at the decisive point.

9.1 *From Dupin to the Continental Op*

Edgar Allan Poe invented the detective as a ratiocinative machine. C. Auguste Dupin of "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" (1841) reasons from overlooked particulars to an improbable solution. "The Purloined Letter" (1844) adds a second method: Dupin recalls a schoolboy who won at the game of even and odd by imitating his opponent's face—"I fashion the expression of my face, as accurately as possible, in accordance with the expression of his"—and waiting to see what thoughts arise. Ratiocination is Logic and Visual Calculus; the schoolboy's method is Empathy, Drama, and Suggestion. Arthur Conan Doyle's Holmes perfected the first method; G. K. Chesterton's Father Brown the second. In "The Secret of Father Brown" (1927), the priest explains that he solves crimes by imagining himself into the murderer until he is the murderer in all but act.

Georges Simenon's Commissaire Maigret, from 1931, solved crimes by absorbing the atmosphere of a milieu and by seeking to understand rather than to judge. Inland Empire is Father Brown's method; Shivers is Maigret's sponge.

The American hard-boiled tradition added politics. Raymond Chandler's "The Simple Art of Murder" (1944) cast the detective as an unflinching man of honour walking mean streets without himself being mean, and Dashiell Hammett's *Red Harvest*, discussed in Chapter 6, set the detective in a town delivered to violence by a labour dispute. Fredric Jameson's "On Raymond Chandler" (1970) explained the political function of the form: in a society whose classes no longer meet, the detective is the device that traverses them, connecting the mansion to the boarding house and assembling the social totality from fragments. Harry's investigation is a traversal of this kind, from the hostel to the union, from the corporate negotiator to the fishing village, from the derelict church to the deserter's fort. It is the prototype of what Jameson later called cognitive mapping, conducted by a mind that has itself become a map of fragments.

Kurvitz has given the same reason for choosing the form. Murder mysteries suit the exploration of an invented world, he has said, because they have to talk about its material reality (Winslow-Yost 2025). In *Disco Elysium* the detective plot is the instrument of the setting's historical materialism.

9.2 *The Metaphysical Detective*

Michael Holquist's "Whodunit and Other Questions" (1971) named the *metaphysical detective story*, in which the conventions of detection are turned against themselves to pose questions about knowledge, identity, and meaning; Patricia Merivale and Susan Elizabeth Sweeney's *Detecting Texts* (1999) traced the form from Poe to postmodernism. Its classics are Borges's "Death and the Compass" (1942), in which the detective Lönnrot, reading a series of murders as a cabbalistic design, walks into the trap his reading has made; Paul Auster's *City of Glass* (1985), in which a writer impersonating a detective becomes the shadow of the man he follows and dissolves into the pages of a red notebook; Umberto Eco's *The Name of the Rose* (1980), whose semiotician-detective fails to prevent the burning of a library and the loss of Aristotle's book on comedy; and Thomas Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966), whose heroine cannot determine whether the conspiracy she pursues exists. Borges's "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941), with its labyrinthine novel in which every possible outcome occurs, is the mythic prototype of the branching dialogue tree.

Disco Elysium adopts the metaphysical detective story's method and refuses its result. Its detective investigates himself, loses himself, and risks dissolution in signs. Unlike Auster's Quinn, whose notebook records his disappearance, Harry is held by a note-

book belonging to another man. And unlike every metaphysical detective, he solves the case. The solution is banal in Arendt's sense: an old man's envy and a single rifle shot. The game is thus post-metaphysical detection, metaphysical in method and realist in result, and the realism is a moral position. History's catastrophes are not the work of cosmic conspiracies but of particular persons with particular grievances. The cosmic is then restored, not as conspiracy but as grace, in the creature that appears in the reeds.

9.3 *The Dostoevskian Field*

The whole cast of *Disco Elysium* inhabits a Dostoevskian field. *Crime and Punishment* (1866) gave the detective story its psychological depth in Porfiry Petrovich, who hunts Raskolnikov by understanding him. *The Double* (1846) split its clerk, Golyadkin, into a man and his usurping replica. The underground man of *Notes from Underground* (1864) declares, in Constance Garnett's translation, "I swear, gentlemen, that to be too conscious is an illness—a real thorough-going illness," and Harry's faculties are hyperconsciousness made audible. The most exact precedent is in *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880). In the ninth chapter of Book XI, Ivan Karamazov, on the brink of brain fever, is visited by a devil in the shape of a shabby gentleman who mocks him with his own ideas, and Ivan cries out, in Garnett's version, "You are the incarnation of myself, but only of one side of me ... of my thoughts and feelings, but only the nastiest and stupidest of them." The skills are Ivan's devil multiplied by twenty-four, with one difference that is the whole of the game's humanism: they incarnate the best of Harry's thoughts as often as the worst.

The positive pole of the field is Prince Myshkin of *The Idiot* (1869), the holy fool whose compassion and epileptic illumination make him both ridiculous and holy. *Demons*, discussed in Chapter 5, supplies the negative pole of ideological possession. Harry moves between them: a man possessed by ideas, who may become a holy fool.

9.4 *Quixote, Parsifal, and the Waste Land*

Don Quixote (1605, 1615) went mad from reading romances of chivalry and rode out to live them. In *The Order of Things* (1966) Michel Foucault made him the hero of an obsolete episteme, a man who reads the world as a web of resemblances when resemblance has ceased to be the order of knowledge, and the type of the madman as the man of primitive resemblances. Inland Empire reads Martinaise by resemblance—a tie is a tempter, a corpse a witness, a city a lover—and Harry's superstar and apocalypse personae are romances he has read himself into. Kim is his Sancho, but an inverted one: the squire is the sane and dignified partner, and it is the knight who must learn from him.

The Grail romance supplies the work's deepest mythic structure. In Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival* (c. 1200–1210), the young knight visits the castle of the Fisher King Anfortas, whose wound keeps his land waste, and fails to ask the question that would heal him; only at his second visit does he ask, *œheim, waz wirret dir?*—uncle, what ails you? Wagner's *Parsifal* (1882) named its hero *durch Mitleid wissend, der reine Tor*: made wise through compassion, the pure fool. Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920) connected the wounded king and the waste land to fertility ritual, and T. S. Eliot built *The Waste Land* (1922) upon her: "Unreal City" (line 60); "I sat upon the shore / Fishing, with the arid plain behind me / Shall I at least set my lands in order?" (424–426); "These fragments I have shored against my ruins" (430).

Harry is both the Fisher King and Parsifal. He is the wounded king whose wound corresponds to the waste of his land—the city–soul isomorphism given mythic form centuries before Plato's analogy was re-engineered—and he is the pure fool who must learn to ask the question. The primary verb of *Disco Elysium* is the question; its dialogue menus are lists of interrogatives; and the question that heals is the question of compassion, which Empathy asks. A game in which the central action is asking another person what ails them is a Grail romance in structure. Erasmus's *Praise of Folly* (1511), the fools of Shakespeare, and the Russian *yurodivy*, the fool for Christ who tells the truth to power, complete the lineage. A minor figure of Martinaise is named, with merciless precision, Idiot Doom Spiral; Harry is the idiot who may break the spiral.

9.5 *Ludic Lineages*

The game's most frequently adduced ludic ancestor is *Planescape: Torment* (Black Isle Studios, 1999), whose Nameless One is an amnesiac immortal who wakes on a mortuary slab and discovers, through the testimony of others, the deeds of his previous incarnations—among them the Practical, the Good, and the Paranoid. Its city, Sigil, is divided among philosophical factions, one of which, the Harmonium, serves as the police. The game's central question—what can change the nature of a man?—is *Disco Elysium*'s question too, and the difference in the answers is instructive. *Torment* answers with belief and regret, interior transformations of a solitary self. *Disco Elysium* answers with relation: a man is changed by the persons and the voices with whom he must share his life.

The comparison is a matter of record, not only of analogy. The designers have praised *Planescape: Torment* effusively (Winslow-Yost 2025), and ZA/UM published its own list of influences in January 2020. Besides *Planescape: Torment*, it named the television series *The Wire*, for the working-class setting, together with *True Detective* and *The Shield*; the game *Kentucky Route Zero*; Émile Zola's *Germinal*, Dashiell Hammett's *The Glass Key*, China Miéville's *The City & The City* (an influence Kurvitz has denied in in-

terview), and the Strugatsky brothers; and the painters Rembrandt, Ilya Repin, Jenny Saville, Alex Kanevsky, and Wassily Kandinsky. Kurvitz has also described the game as belonging to the *Fallout* school of role-playing (Wikipedia). Several comparisons drawn in this thesis, *Germinal*'s miners' strike above all, are therefore documented sources as well as affinities. Chris Avellone, a writer on *Planescape: Torment*, has since joined Red Info, the successor studio of Kurvitz and Rostov.

Fallout (1997) established the dialogue skill check as a core mechanic of the computer role-playing game. *Vampire: The Masquerade – Bloodlines* (Troika Games, 2004) gave its Malkavian clan an alternate, insane dialogue track in which madness reveals truths and the protagonist converses with a stop sign, a direct ancestor of Inland Empire. *Pathologic* (Ice-Pick Lodge, 2005; reimagined 2019) set three healers in a dying town on the steppe, framed as theatre and governed by scarcity; it is the post-Soviet game closest to *Disco Elysium* in spirit. *Kentucky Route Zero* (Cardboard Computer, 2013–2020) narrated debt, labour, and ghosts in a magical-realist America of foreclosed futures, and is the work's hauntological sibling. In tabletop design, Vincent Baker's *Apocalypse World* (2010) also resolved actions with two six-sided dice and made failure a generator of story, an affinity rather than an influence. Among the games most often compared with *Disco Elysium* since its release are *Pentiment* (Obsidian, 2022), *Citizen Sleeper* (Jump Over the Age, 2022), and *Norco* (Geography of Robots, 2022).

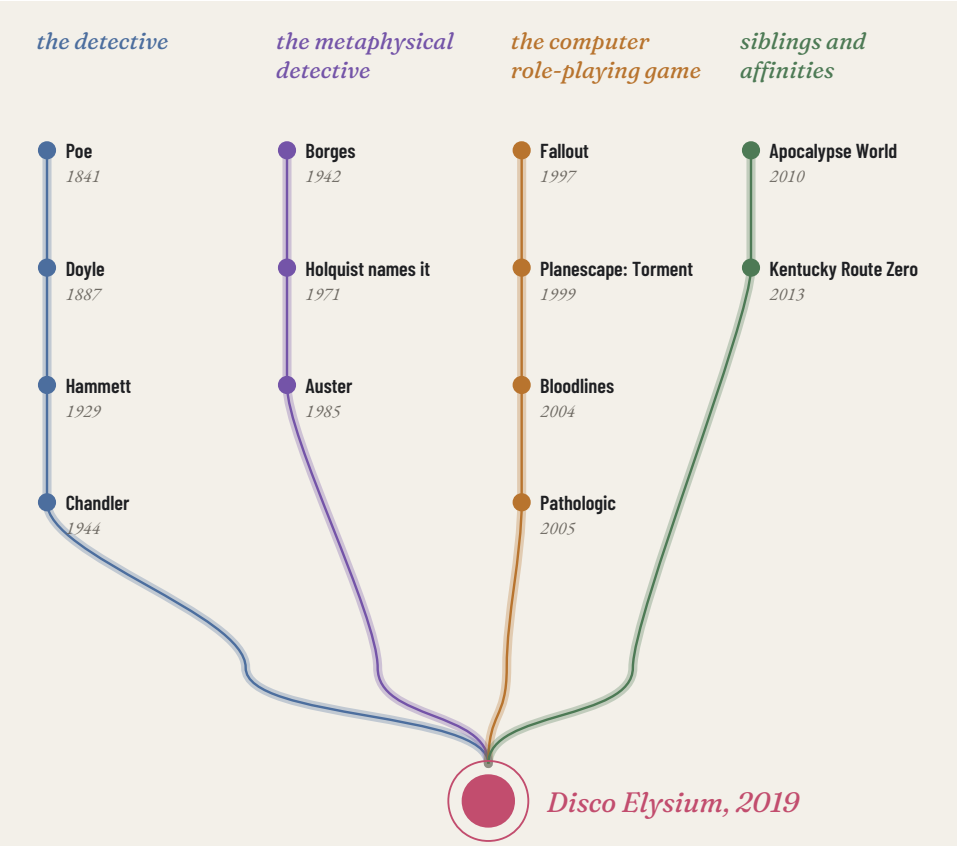


FIGURE 9.1 *Genealogies converging: four of the lineages traced in this chapter, drawn as tributaries, with the dates given in the text..*

9.6 *Speculative and Modernist Comparanda*

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* (1974) set an anarchist moon, Anarres, against a capitalist planet, Urras, and called itself "an ambiguous utopia"; its ambiguity is the ancestor of the game's refusal to idealize the Commune. Her "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) imagined a city whose happiness depends on the misery of a single child in a cellar. Revachol is the cellar of the Moralintern's Omelas, and Cuno is the child who throws stones. The game lets the investigator learn why: Cuno has no mother, lives with an abusive, drug-addicted father, and uses amphetamines himself. Le Guin's citizens learn of the child in the cellar and either stay or walk away. Harry can do neither; he is a policeman, and the child is on his beat. China Miéville's *The City & The*

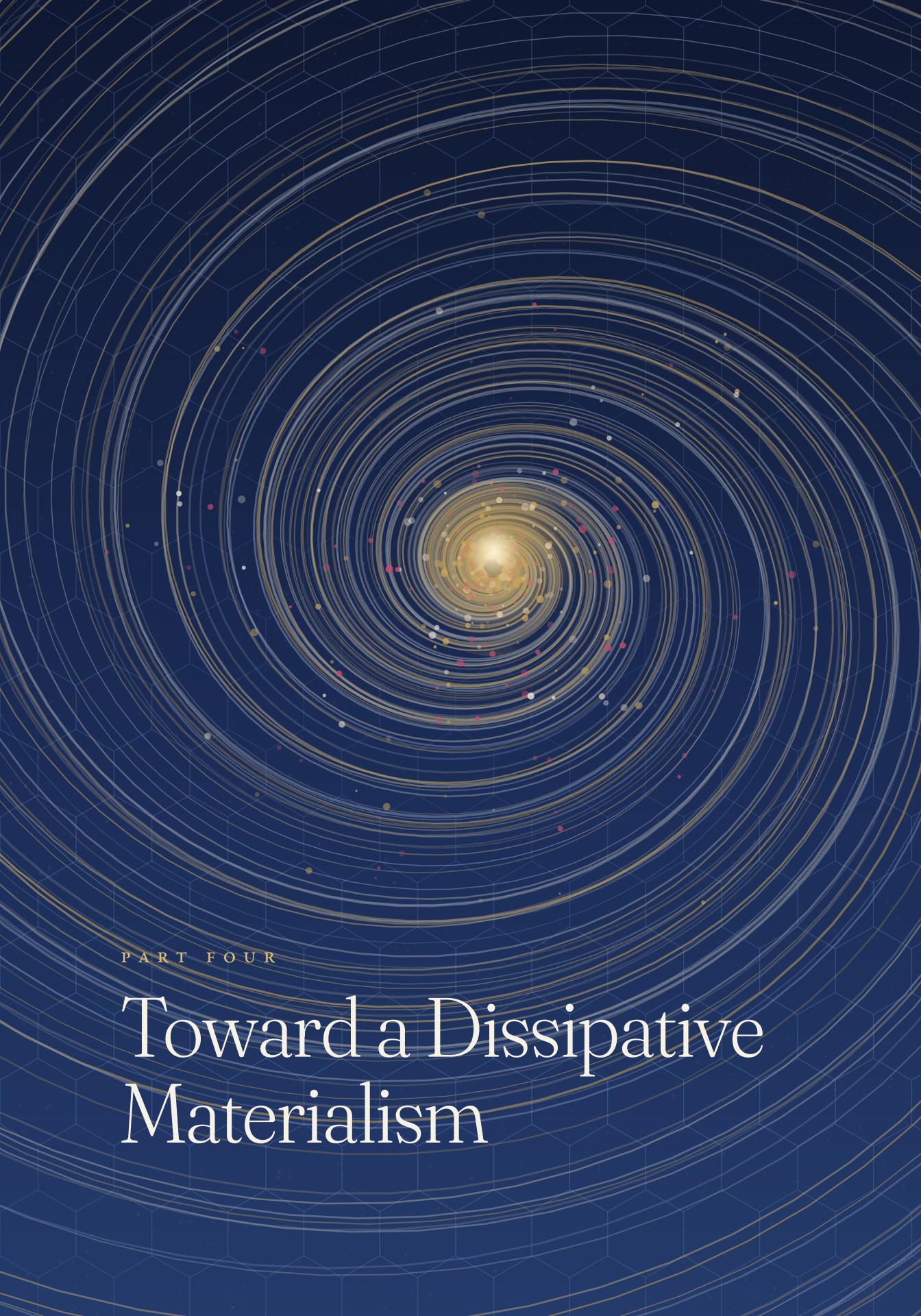
City (2009) set a police procedural in two cities occupying the same space, whose citizens must "unsee" each other. His *Iron Council* (2004) ends with a revolutionary train, a moving commune, frozen in time so that it is forever arriving and can never be destroyed—an image of the Commune's afterlife that the game approaches in its own idiom. His editorial "Marxism and Fantasy" (2002) argued for the political seriousness of the fantastic. Philip K. Dick's *A Scanner Darkly* (1977) made its undercover narcotics agent surveil himself as his brain's hemispheres separate under the influence of a drug: the cop as divided self. *Ubik* (1969) imagined a world in which objects regress through time as entropy advances.

László Krasznahorkai, awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature in 2025, is the work's closest contemporary in European fiction. *Satantango* (1985) depicts a collapsed collective farm awaiting a false prophet amid rain, drink, and dance; *The Melancholy of Resistance* (1989) brings a stuffed whale to a disintegrating town. Béla Tarr's films of both books render the post-socialist ruin as a choreography of slowness. Robert Musil's *The Man Without Qualities* satirized Kakania's "Parallel Campaign," a committee searching for a unifying idea, as the game satirizes its ideologies, and made the murderer Moosbrugger a mirror in which society contemplates itself. Mann's *The Magic Mountain* staged the duel of Settembrini, the liberal humanist, and Naphta, the Jesuit communist of terror, for the soul of a mediocre young man, and introduced Mynheer Peeperkorn, a Dutch colonial planter from Java—Multatuli's Insulinde again—whose inarticulate Dionysian vitality overwhelms them both. The Estonian canon offers A. H. Tammsaare's *Truth and Justice* (1926–33), the national epic of labour and futility; Jaan Kross's *The Czar's Madman* (1978), in which a nobleman who tells the emperor the truth is declared insane; and Andrus Kivirähk's *The Man Who Spoke Snakish* (2007), whose narrator is the last speaker of a language and a world. *Disco Elysium* speaks with all of them, in a language of its own.

Mann's ideological contest ends in death by the contestants' own hands, and the comparison requires that precision. Peeperkorn, feeling his vital powers fail, takes his own life with poison. Naphta challenges Settembrini to a duel; when Settembrini fires into the air, Naphta shoots himself. Mann's ideologue of terror and his Dionysian both turn their violence inward, as, in the setting's own history, Kras Mazov is reported to have done when the counterrevolution triumphed. The deserter of *Disco Elysium* turns it outward; the Ancient Reptilian Brain counsels the inward turn in the game's first minute; and Harry, both Dionysian and ideologically possessed, survives both temptations, which is the precondition of every argument in Part Four.

Mikhail Bulgakov's *The Master and Margarita* (written 1928–40; published 1966–67) brought the devil to Stalin's Moscow as a satirist of its pieties and restored a burned manuscript with the declaration that manuscripts do not burn. The world of Elysium,

which outlived the commercial failure of the novel that first contained it, has the same obstinacy.



PART FOUR

Toward a Dissipative Materialism

IV

Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst
Das Rettende auch.

— Hölderlin, “Patmos” (1803)

CHAPTER 10

10

The Phasmid Principle

Wonder, Attention, and the Ethics of Improbable Life

After the deserter has been confronted, on the islet from which he fired, Harry encounters the Insulindian Phasmid: a giant stick insect that Lena, the cryptozoologist's wife, who waits at the Whirling-in-Rags, says she saw among the reeds when she was five and a half, and that her husband Morell has come to Martinaise to find, while the rest of the world dismissed it. The creature addresses him in a register distinct from that of both the skills and the human interlocutors, and the scene is the game's nearest approach to a miracle, though section 10.1 shows that it is not an innocent one. This chapter argues that the encounter grounds the work's ethics, and formulates that ethics as the *Phasmid principle*: attention to improbable life is the virtue proper to entropic times.

10.1 *Mimicry and Legendary Psychasthenia*

In "Mimicry and Legendary Psychasthenia," published in the Surrealist review *Minotaure* in 1935, Roger Caillois argued that insect mimicry cannot be explained by its utility. Mimetic insects are eaten as often as others, and some leaf insects, mistaking one another for foliage, browse upon their own kind. Mimicry is a luxury, and its true meaning is psychological: a temptation by space, in which the organism loses the distinction between itself and its surroundings and assimilates itself to the environment. Caillois compared this to the experience of schizophrenics who feel devoured by space, who

know where they are but do not feel themselves to be at that place, and called the condition *legendary psychasthenia*. His emblems were the stick and leaf insects, the masters of disappearance.

The Insulindian Phasmid is Caillois's emblem raised to myth. It is the creature that has perfected disappearance into its surroundings, so completely that its existence has been doubted for generations. The climax of *Disco Elysium* is its appearance: the revelation of the camouflaged. Theology knows this structure as the self-disclosure of the hidden God—"Verily thou art a God that hidest thyself," in the King James rendering of Isaiah 45:15—and Pascal made the *deus absconditus* the centre of his apologetics. The encounter is also a lesson addressed specifically to Harry. Shivers has dissolved him into the city throughout the game; he is, in Caillois's sense, a psychasthenic, devoured by Martinaise. The Phasmid shows him that assimilation to one's surroundings need not be annihilation. In the vocabulary of Chapter 8, it is *baqā'* after *fanā'*, subsistence within dissolution. The creature has disappeared into the world and persists.

The encounter is a lesson in cosmology as well as an apparition. In its conversation with Harry, the Phasmid describes the Pale as a nervous shadow cast into the world by human beings, eating away at reality, a great unnatural territory whose advent coincides with the arrival of the human mind. The creature that has perfected disappearance into its surroundings diagnoses the Pale as the shadow of consciousness itself, which is Zapffe's diagnosis spoken in the voice of wonder. The Phasmid principle acquires its full stakes here. If the mind casts the Pale, the mind must also be the site of the counterforce, and the virtue the encounter calls for, attention to improbable life, is consciousness turned from its own shadow toward what still lives at the edge of it.

The game binds this principle to persistence itself. In one exchange Volition, the faculty of the conatus, insists that there was a giant insect, that others have to understand it, and that Harry will find proof; he is not to give up. The will to persist and fidelity to the improbable encounter speak with one voice.

The encounter also complicates the principle it grounds, and the complication must be stated plainly. The game implies that the Phasmid indirectly set the case in motion: the psychoactive chemicals it exudes affected the deserter's mind for years, stoking his fanaticism and resentment. In the psychic conversation the creature tells Harry that it fears the notion of his unstable mind but is awed by his ability to go on existing, and before it leaves it comforts him, in words section 11.5 takes up (Wikipedia). The improbable life that grounds wonder is not innocent of the crime, and the attention it calls for is not reverence but a clear-eyed regard for life whose effects exceed its intentions. The wonder, moreover, runs both ways: the creature marvels at Harry's persistence as he marvels at its existence.

10.2 *Anticipatory Illumination*

Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* (1954–59) founded an ontology of the Not-Yet: the Not-Yet-Conscious in the subject, the Not-Yet-Become in the world, and the anticipatory illumination (*Vor-Schein*) with which art discloses in the present a possibility that the present cannot contain. Bloch began from what he called the darkness of the lived moment, the opacity of the immediate present to itself, and distinguished concrete utopia, grounded in the real tendencies of the world, from abstract wishful thinking; hope disciplined by knowledge he called *docta spes*. *Disco Elysium* begins in a darkness of the lived moment more literal than Bloch imagined, and it ends in a *Vor-Schein*. The Phasmid is the anticipatory illumination of a world in which improbable life persists at the margin, unannounced and unmanaged, after history has been confronted and the case closed.

Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot* (1953) made the arrival that never happens the emblem of modern expectation. *Disco Elysium* is the play in which Godot comes. The Strugatskys' golden sphere promises to grant wishes; the Phasmid grants nothing. It simply is, and its being is the content of the hope it gives. Bloch insisted that hope is not confidence and can be disappointed. The Phasmid principle preserves that austerity: the existence of one improbable creature guarantees nothing about the fate of the world, but it refutes the claim that the world has already ended.

10.3 *Unselfing*

Iris Murdoch's essay "The Sovereignty of Good over Other Concepts" (1967), collected in *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970), describes looking out of a window in an anxious and resentful state of mind, seeing a hovering kestrel, and finding that the brooding self has vanished; Murdoch calls this *unselfing* and makes it the model of moral change, which consists in a just and loving attention to a reality other than oneself. Simone Weil, in "Reflections on the Right Use of School Studies with a View to the Love of God" (1942) and the fragments collected in *Gravity and Grace* (1947), made attention the substance of prayer and the rarest form of generosity. Harry's encounter with the Phasmid is an unselfing. For a moment the parliament of voices falls silent before something none of them predicted.

Murdoch's own fiction supplies the decisive contrast. In *The Sea, the Sea* (1978), the retired theatre director Charles Arrowby, writing his memoirs in a house by the sea, sees a sea monster rise from the waves, and the novel gradually reveals it as an emblem of his own possessive egoism. Murdoch's monster is the ego's projection; Kurvitz's cryptid is

reality's excess. The one confirms the self in its delusions, the other releases it from them.

The Phasmid also answers the voice that opened the game. The Norwegian philosopher Peter Wessel Zapffe's essay "The Last Messiah" (1933) argued that human consciousness is an overdeveloped faculty, comparable to the antlers that some have held burdened the Irish elk, and that human beings survive the panic it produces only by four mechanisms: isolation, anchoring, distraction, and sublimation. Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* (2010) carried Zapffe's pessimism into contemporary letters, and the first season of *True Detective* (2014) carried it into popular culture. The Ancient Reptilian Brain speaks Zapffe's philosophy. *Disco Elysium* does not refute it by argument. It answers with wonder, which is neither isolation, anchoring, distraction, nor sublimation, but a fifth relation to the world that Zapffe's inventory omits.

10.4 *Natality*

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) made natality, the fact that human beings are born and can therefore begin something new, the ontological root of action. She wrote that the miracle that saves the world from its normal, natural ruin is the fact of natality, and found its most succinct expression in the glad tidings of the Gospels: a child has been born unto us. Harry's awakening is a second birth, and the game's opening is a nativity in the dark. The Phasmid is natality in nature: proof that the world still produces beginnings. The Pale is its antithesis, the anti-natal principle, and the antinatalism that David Benatar defended in *Better Never to Have Been* (2006) is the Reptile's philosophy given academic form.

The *Phasmid principle* can now be stated. In a world whose condition is the exhaustion of difference, the virtue on which every other depends is attention to improbable life: to beings, persons, and possibilities whose existence the order of things renders unlikely and whose disappearance it would not notice. The principle unites Weil's attention, Murdoch's unselfing, Bloch's hope, and Arendt's natality, and it has a political consequence. The improbable lives that most require attention in Martinaise are not cryptids but strikers, children, old men, and a fugitive dancer, and the cryptid teaches Harry how to see them. Such attention is not reverence: as the Phasmid's part in the deserter's crime shows, it must also hold improbable life to account for what it sets in motion. Hölderlin's line in "Patmos" gives the principle its form: where danger grows, the saving power grows too. The Phasmid lives at the edge of the world because that is where saving powers grow.

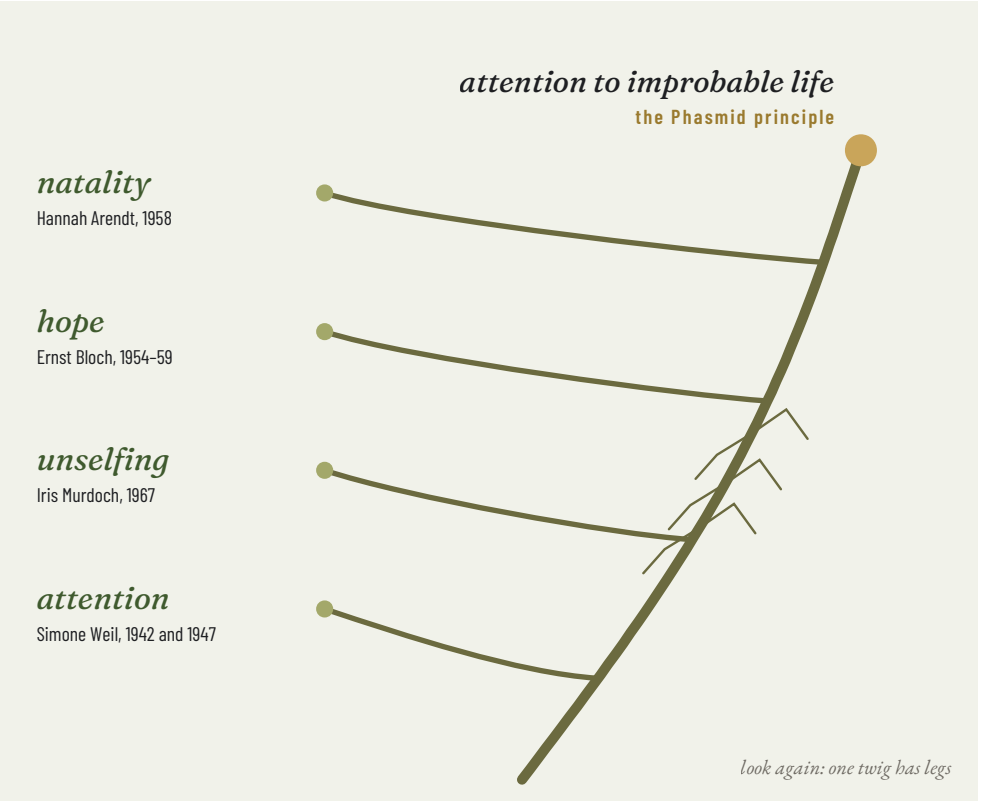


FIGURE 10.1 *The Phasmid principle as a twig.* Four sources join in attention to improbable life; after Caillois, mimicry hides an insect among the branches.

CHAPTER 11



11

Dissipative Polyphony

A Theory

The preceding chapters have read the work. This chapter states the theory implicit in it, first by establishing its physical and metaphysical premises, then in four theses, and finally through three analyses—of fidelity, of friendship, and of mourning—that show how the theory answers the questions the game leaves open.

11.1 *Whirlpools, Swerves, and Dice*

Heraclitus observed that upon those who step into the same rivers, different and again different waters flow (fragment B12 in the Diels–Kranz numbering), and that one cannot step twice into the same river (B91). The river persists as a pattern while its substance passes away. Norbert Wiener's image of living beings as whirlpools, patterns that perpetuate themselves in a flow, translated the insight into cybernetics. Erwin Schrödinger's lectures *What Is Life?* (1944) gave it thermodynamic form: an organism maintains its improbable order by continually drawing order from its environment and exporting disorder to it, feeding, in his phrase, on negative entropy. Ilya Prigogine, awarded the Nobel Prize in Chemistry in 1977, generalized the point in his theory of *dissipative structures*, popularized with Isabelle Stengers in *La Nouvelle Alliance* (1979; English *Order out of Chaos*, 1984). Convection cells in a heated fluid and the oscillating chemical clocks of the Belousov–Zhabotinsky reaction are ordered structures that arise and persist only

far from equilibrium, sustained by a continuous flux of energy that they dissipate; when the flux ceases, they vanish. New order, Prigogine showed, arises through the amplification of fluctuations in such systems.

The vortical subject of *Disco Elysium* is a dissipative structure of voices. Health and Morale measure the flux that sustains it; the binge was a near-collapse into equilibrium; the game's first scene is a fluctuation amplified into a self. The metaphysics that accompanies this physics is supplied by Lucretius. In the second book of *De Rerum Natura* (II.216–293), atoms falling through the void swerve at quite uncertain times and places —*incerto tempore … incertisque locis*—and without this swerve, the *clinamen*, no atom would collide with another, no world would form, and no living being would possess free will. Louis Althusser's late text "The Underground Current of the Materialism of the Encounter" (written in 1982, published in 1994) built on Epicurus and Lucretius an *aleatory materialism*: the world as the accomplished fact of encounters that happened to take hold, without origin and without end.

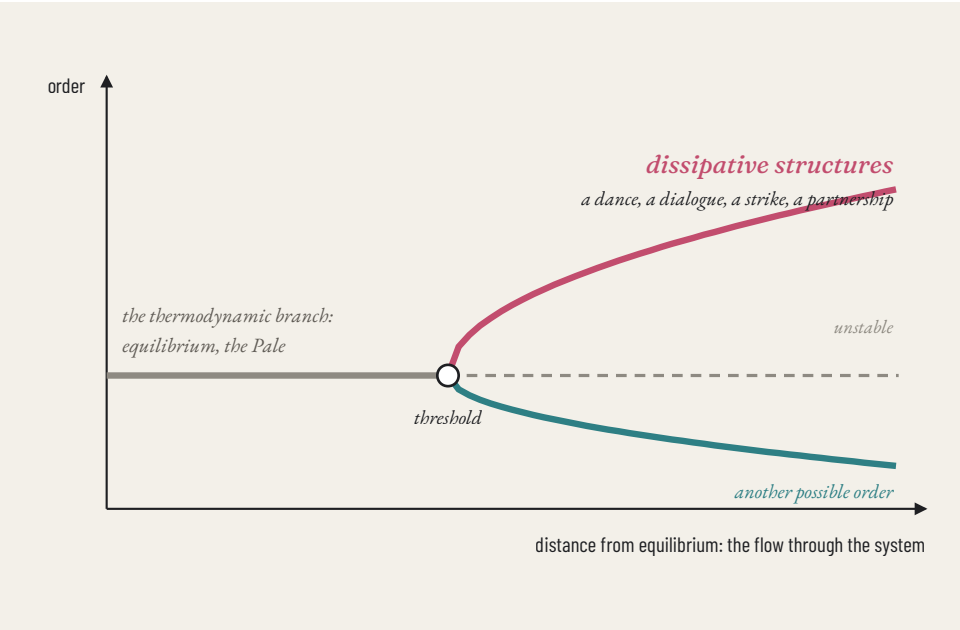


FIGURE II.1 *A bifurcation far from equilibrium, after Prigogine.* Below a threshold of flow a system stays on the thermodynamic branch; beyond it, new and stable orders can appear. The Pale lies on the first branch, the dance on the second.

The dice of *Disco Elysium* are the *clinamen*. Every check introduces a swerve that no skill can eliminate, since a double six always succeeds and a double one always fails, and the narrative of any playthrough is the accomplished fact of the encounters that took

hold. Harry's partnership with Kim is such an encounter; it might have failed. The Phasmid is such an encounter; it might not have come. The game's metaphysics is aleatory and anti-teleological, and it stands opposed at every point to the deserter's eschatology, for which history had a destination and its failure to arrive was a crime that demanded punishment.

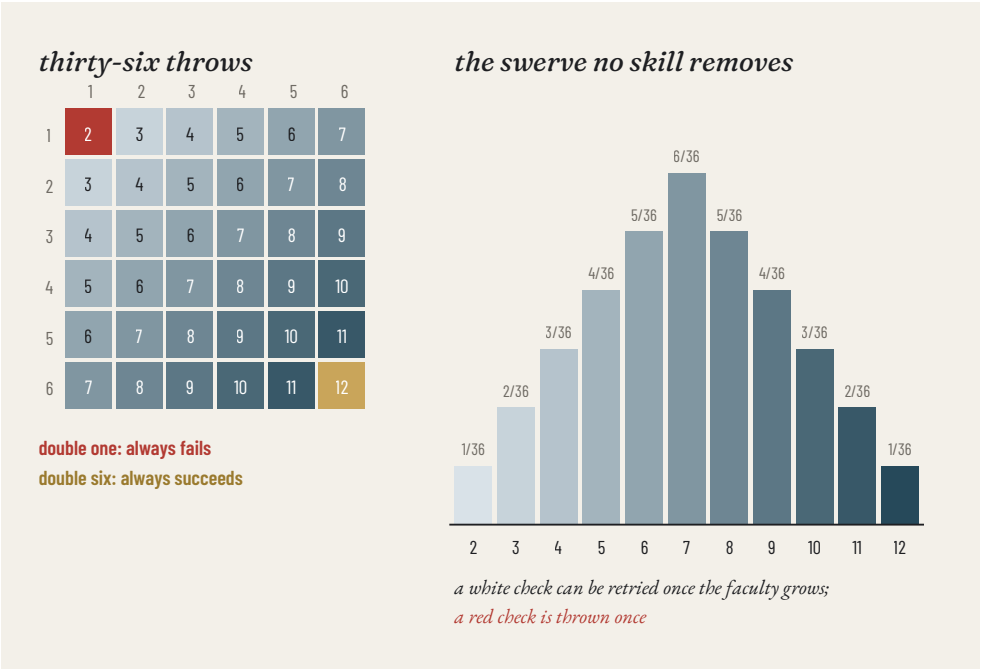


FIGURE 11.2 *The clinamen in two dice: thirty-six throws and the distribution of their sums.* A double one always fails and a double six always succeeds, whatever the skill.

The game contains a thought about exactly this. Questioning the Novelty Dicemaker, through a Shivers check, about why her business has not failed yields *The Precarious World*. While Harry researches it, every red check fails; once it is internalized, it alters the thresholds for critical success and failure, the one rule of the dice that otherwise never changes. To think precarity is to enlarge the clinamen: the aleatory is a thought one can have, and having it changes the odds of the world.

11.2 *Four Theses*

Thesis I (ontological). The subject is a dissipative polyphony: a pattern of semi-autonomous voices sustained far from equilibrium by flows of energy, will, attention, memory, and speech. Its unity is choreographic rather than substantial—the coherence of a

dance, not of a stone. It follows that integration into a single voice would be a form of equilibrium, the death of the pattern, and that health consists not in unification but in the better coordination of multiplicity: the constitutional polyphony of Chapter 1.

Thesis II (historical). The end of history is entropic equilibrium: the exhaustion of the gradients—of class, of hope, of difference—that power political work. Capitalist realism is the subjective experience of approaching equilibrium, and the Pale is its objective correlative.

Thesis III (political). The four ideologies of Revachol are four thermodynamic strategies, each of which hastens or freezes equilibrium. Eschatological communism, in the deserter's form, is *discharge*: it stakes everything on a single release of accumulated tension toward a final state, and when that release fails it contracts into a bullet. Palingenetic fascism is *crystallization*: it preserves a local order by closing the system against difference, and closed systems, by the second law, can only run down. Ultraliberalism is *accumulation*: it concentrates free energy as capital and exports disorder to peripheries. Revachol, in the terms of Immanuel Wallerstein's *The Modern World-System* (1974), is the Moralintern's entropy sink. Moralism is *homeostasis*: a thermostat state that damps every fluctuation and thereby forbids the amplified fluctuations from which, on Prigogine's account, new order arises; it approaches equilibrium asymptotically while calling the approach stability.

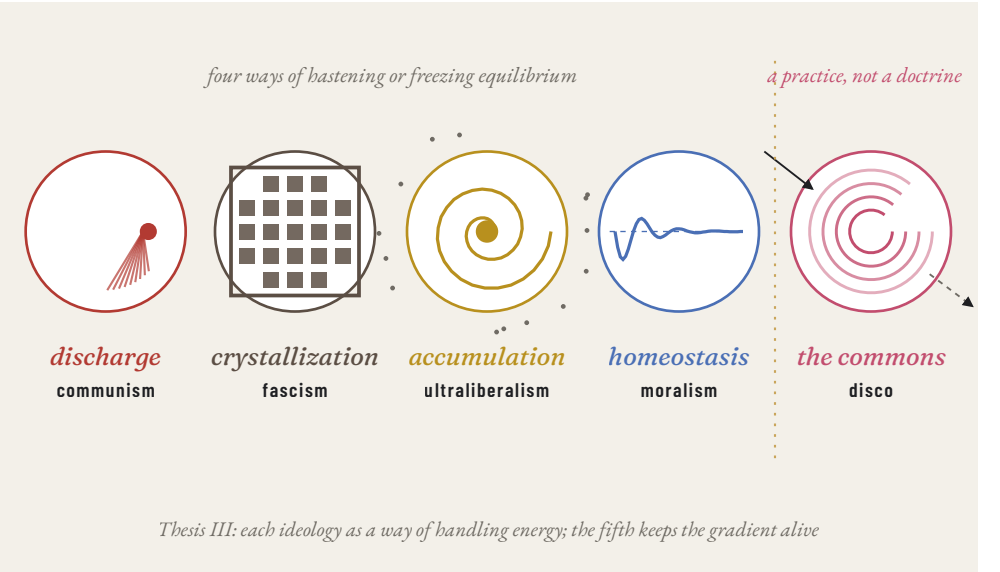


FIGURE 11.3 *Thesis III in five glyphs: four ideologies as four ways of handling energy, and the dissipative commons as the practice that keeps a gradient alive..*

Against these four the game proposes no fifth doctrine but a practice: the *dissipative commons*. These are temporary, rhythmic, collective structures—a dance, a dialogue, a strike, a partnership—that sustain difference far from equilibrium by spending energy in shared form. Disco is their emblem; the Commune's communal luxury is their political memory; Rancière's politics is their mode of appearance; Lepecki's choreopolitics is their bodily form; Bataille's glorious expenditure is their economy. They do not abolish entropy, which nothing can, and they do not last forever. They make order out of the very flux that would otherwise dissipate it, for as long as the people within them keep moving together.

The game itself entertains this hypothesis in its own idiom. Steban, the Student Communist, reports that many infra-materialists regard the Pale as a manifestation of nostalgia and historical inertia, and that revolution may generate a counter-force against its expansion. Thesis III restates that speculation in thermodynamic terms and strips it of eschatology: the counter-force is not a single revolutionary rupture but the continual production of shared, rhythmic, expensive forms of life.

Thesis IV (ethical). The virtue proper to entropic times is attention to improbable life—the Phasmid principle of Chapter 10—which unites Weil's attention, Murdoch's unselfing, Bloch's hope, and Arendt's natality, and which directs the subject toward the beings that the order of things would let disappear unnoticed.

11.3 *Fidelity, Betrayal, Disaster*

Alain Badiou's *Being and Event* (1988) defined the event as a rupture in the order of being from which a truth may proceed, through the fidelity of subjects who commit themselves to its consequences. His *Ethics* (1993) identified three figures of evil that shadow every truth procedure: the *simulacrum*, fidelity to a false event that mimics a true one; *betrayal*, the renunciation of fidelity; and *disaster*, the absolutization of a truth that seeks to name everything and to force the world into its shape. "Of an Obscure Disaster" (1991) applied the analysis to the collapse of the Soviet state, and *In Praise of Love* (2009) treated love as a truth procedure, the construction of a world from the point of view of two.

The game's events, betrayals, and disasters fall into place under these categories. Harry's love for Dora was an event; the Commune was an event. Measurehead's myth of race is a simulacrum. The cynicism of the occupation, and the cynicism into which Harry may sink, are betrayals. The deserter is disaster: fidelity to the Commune hardened into the conviction that whatever contradicts it must die. The ethical problem the game poses, and which Badiou's categories sharpen, is how to remain faithful to an event without disaster. The theory of dissipative polyphony answers that melancholic fi-

delity, which incorporates the lost event and turns it into a sentence, must be transformed into practices that keep the event's luxury alive in the present—a dance in a church, a partnership in a car, a strike on a dock. The mechanics encode the stakes. White checks belong to reversible time, red checks to irreversible time, and the red check is the ludic form of the event's demand: a decision that cannot be retaken and to which one must remain faithful.

The game's most exacting red check is not a feat of detection but a matter of life and death. Harry finds Ruby hiding in an abandoned building, where she incapacitates him and Kim with a radio device built to help travellers cross the Pale. Learning that Titus has given her up and that Klaasje has framed her for the murder, and with Harry having destroyed the device, she puts her pistol in her mouth, believing there is no other way out. A single red Rhetoric check decides whether she can be talked down. If it fails, she dies; and if Harry then decides he no longer wants to be a policeman, the game ends on a headline recording that an officer responsible for a suspect's suicide has renounced the militia. Irreversible time here is the time of another person's life, and the faculty that can save it is the one the game associates with argument and politics. Rhetoric, so often the voice of ideological seduction in Harry's parliament, is also the voice that can keep someone alive.

Reversible time is partly for sale; irreversible time is not. The Novelty Dicemaker sells hand-made dice that unlock and improve white checks, so that some failures can be reopened by purchase. No die reopens a red check.

11.4 *Friendship as Minimal Commons*

Aristotle devoted two books of the *Nicomachean Ethics* (VIII–IX) to friendship. He held that no one would choose to live without friends even if possessed of every other good, and that the friend is "another self" (*allos autos*, IX.4). Montaigne's essay "De l'amitié" (1580), written in memory of Étienne de La Boétie, could explain the friendship only by saying *parce que c'était lui, parce que c'était moi*—because it was he, because it was I. Derrida's *Politics of Friendship* (1994) meditated on the saying attributed to Aristotle, "O my friends, there is no friend," and on the place of friendship in the history of the political.

The partnership of Kim Kitsuragi and Harry Du Bois is friendship as the minimal commons. It is a structure of two whose exchanges sustain a pattern neither could sustain alone: Kim holds the memory, Harry the intuitions; Kim the procedure, Harry the risk; both the judgment. Esprit de Corps, the faculty that gives Harry glimpses of other officers across the city, imagines the militia as what Benedict Anderson called an imagined community (1983). The partnership makes community real at its smallest scale.

The question with which the game ends—whether Kim will continue at Harry's side—is therefore the question of whether the commons outlasts the case. Aristotle's "another self" receives a precise sense: in a dissipative polyphony, the friend is a voice from outside that the parliament of the self learns to hear as its own without mistaking it for its own.

The game's design makes the partnership load-bearing. Kurvitz has described Kim as a "systemic metaphor" for the game: what Kim does for the officer, the game tries to do for the player. The mechanics make the point literal at the moment of greatest danger: if Harry goes to Ruby's hideout without Kim, she kills him. Kim's own history raises the stakes. He lost his parents at the age of two in the killing that followed the revolution; asked for his position on the revolution, he answers that his position is the abattoir. The man who models patience, procedure, and restraint for Harry is himself an orphan of Revachol's catastrophe, and he admits that he was once a Moralist believer (Winslow-Yost 2025). The partnership can also hold a confidence: after Harry has worked through the thought *Homo-Sexual Underground*, Harry can ask Kim whether he belongs to the homo-sexual underground. Kim first rebukes him for obsessing about other people's sexuality, then says he will spare Harry another twenty hours of thinking about it: yes, he is, and now they should get back to work. The joke glances at the Thought Cabinet's own clock, the hours an idea takes to incubate. The friend relieves the parliament of the self of a rumination by telling the truth and returning to the shared task. Mixed-race and queer within a militia that is itself in part a ghost of the revolution, Kim is, in Rancière's terms, a part the order counts only as an exception, and the place he has made inside the police is the strongest evidence the game offers that the institution can be inhabited otherwise. The commons can also be renewed from below: if Kim is shot in the Tribunal, the child Cuno offers to take his place, announcing in his own idiom that Cuno is a pig now and that the two of them are partners.

The criticism recorded in Chapter 4, that Kim's interiority is subordinated to Harry's recovery, applies here with full force, and the answer this thesis can give is partial. A commons is just only when its exchanges run in both directions, and the game lets Harry give Kim little beyond attention, trust, and the choice not to join in the abuse of others.

11.5 *From Melancholia to Mourning*

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) distinguished the work of mourning, in which reality-testing gradually detaches the libido from a lost object, from melancholia, in which the lost object is incorporated into the ego and the ego is tormented in its stead. Derrida's writings on mourning, from *Mémoires: for Paul de Man* (1986) to the essays collected in *The Work of Mourning* (2001), described a mourning that is never

complete and that remains faithful to the other precisely by not absorbing them. Wendy Brown's critique of left melancholy, discussed in Chapter 5, applied the distinction to politics.

Harry's arc moves, if the player allows it, from melancholia to mourning: from incorporating Dora as the voice of his self-reproach toward letting her be other, a person with a life of her own rather than a wound in his. The deserter's melancholia has hardened into violence; Harry's mourning opens the possibility of action. At this point the isomorphism closes. A self that can mourn can act politically, because it can relate to its losses without being governed by them. A city that can mourn its Commune without vengeance can have a future, and Martinaise ends with that future undecided: a strike that might be settled, a church that might become a club, a fishing village that persists, a cryptid in the reeds. Dissipative polyphony is, finally, a theory of the self and the city that can mourn and dance at once.

The game gives the counsel of mourning to the least likely speaker. At the end of the encounter in the reeds the Phasmid comforts Harry and tells him to move on from the wreck of his life: the improbable creature speaks the sentence that melancholia cannot.

CONCLUSION



How Can We Know the Dancer from the Dance?

This thesis has argued that *Disco Elysium* makes the self, the city, and the cosmos legible as a single dissipative structure, and that what sustains each is not sovereignty but rhythm. Part One showed that the skill system is a theory of the subject as a constitutional polyphony, rooted in faculty psychology, the literary tradition of the plural self, and the bundle theory of personal identity, and that the game's amnesia stages a purgatorial passage from Lethe through *anamnesis* toward Eunoë. Part Two showed that Revachol is Harry's psyche written in larger letters, that its onomastics and history encode the Paris Commune and the post-Soviet transition, that its four ideologies satirize four forms of attachment and four relations to time, and that its police is a spectral institution whose foundation, revolutionary or occupational, the setting itself leaves undecided. Part Three showed that the Pale literalizes the end of history as entropic equilibrium and that disco names, in the game as in history, both a market's brief euphoria and the collective, rhythmic expenditure that resists equilibrium. Part Four formulated the ethics of the Phasmid principle, together with the complication the creature itself introduces, and the theory of dissipative polyphony in four theses.

The argument makes three contributions. To game studies, it offers a demonstration that the systems of a game can compose a philosophical position as rigorous as any argued in prose: the two-dice check, the white and red checks, the passive interjections of the faculties, the Thought Cabinet, the twin meters of Health and Morale, and the

game clock are not vehicles for a theory but the theory itself. To political theory, it offers a thermodynamic critique of ideology and the concept of the dissipative commons, which names a form of collective life—temporary, rhythmic, expenditure-based—that the dominant political vocabularies of sovereignty, revolution, market, and governance cannot describe. To comparative literature, it situates *Disco Elysium* as the culmination of two traditions: the modernist polity of the self, from Stevenson and Rimbaud through Hesse, Pessoa, Musil, and Joyce, and the late-socialist and speculative literature of the Zone, from the Strugatskys and Tarkovsky through Harrison, VanderMeer, and Krasznahorkai.

The argument has limits, and the work has contradictions. A theory that finds hope in temporary commons risks aestheticizing defeat, the danger Benjamin identified in left-wing melancholy. The game is itself a commodity, sold on digital storefronts and subject to the culture industry that Adorno and Horkheimer anatomized in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947), and its satire of capital circulates as capital. Dissipative commons are vulnerable to capture: Studio 54 followed the Loft, and every collective joy has found its merchandiser. The work's own history, recounted in the Coda, shows how quickly a collective enterprise can become the object of a struggle over ownership. Further research might examine the game's reception in the post-Soviet sphere, the politics of its translations, its fan communities as commons in their own right, and the fate of the world of Elysium beyond the studio that first published it.

The last word belongs to the poet whose gyre has turned through these pages. In "Among School Children" (1927), Yeats closes with a question:

> *O body swayed to music, O brightening glance,*
> *How can we know the dancer from the dance?*

The question is rhetorical in Yeats, and *Disco Elysium* answers it literally. We cannot know the dancer from the dance, because there is no dancer outside it: the self is the pattern its voices make in motion, and the city is the pattern its people make together. The centre will not hold; it never did. What can hold, for a time, is the dance.



The Work and Its Owners

The history of *Disco Elysium* after its release belongs to its reading, though it is not the subject of this thesis. In October 2022, Martin Luiga, a co-founder of the ZA/UM cultural association and an editor on the game, announced the association's dissolution and stated that Kurvitz, Rostov, and Hindpere had left the studio at the end of 2021 involuntarily. Kurvitz filed suit against the studio later that month.

On 9 November 2022, in an open letter, Kurvitz and Rostov alleged that Tütreke OÜ, the company through which the Estonian businessmen Ilmar Kompus, the studio's chief executive, and Tõnis Haavel had become majority shareholders, had obtained control of the studio by fraud, using money taken from the studio itself to buy the majority stake, with the support of the minority shareholder Kaur Kender. The studio denied any fraud or financial malfeasance and stated that the employees had been dismissed for misconduct, which it described as neglect of their duties, verbal abuse, gender discrimination, the creation of a toxic work environment, and attempts to sell the studio's intellectual property to other companies (VGC, 9 November 2022). Kender, who had filed his own suit alleging that Kompus acquired control by buying concept material for the sequel and reselling it to the studio for €4.8 million, withdrew it in December 2022 after the sum was returned to ZA/UM, and later called the suit misguided. In March 2023 the studio announced that Kurvitz and Rostov had dropped their unfair-dismissal claims for lack of evidence; Kurvitz and Rostov replied that they would con-

tinue to pursue their legal options, arguing that repaying the money did not undo what they called a crime (Game World Observer, 14 March 2023, updated 17 March). By October 2024 at least four studios employing former ZA/UM staff had announced spiritual successors to the game, and in May 2026 ZA/UM itself released Zero Parades: For Dead Spies, a game in the same style. Writing in The Baffler in November 2025, Gabriel Winslow-Yost described the litigation as still ongoing. According to Wikipedia's account, the direct sequel, code-named Y12, was cancelled in mid-2022, and Locust City, a standalone expansion centred on Cuno and Cunoesse, was cancelled in February 2024 amid layoffs of about a quarter of the studio's staff. Kurvitz and Rostov had founded Red Info in June 2022, and three further successor studios, Longdue, Dark Math Games, and Summer Eternal, announced projects in October 2024; two months after Zero Parades was released, ZA/UM announced layoffs of up to thirty-two staff. The collective that made the game has, quite literally, dissipated into several. This thesis takes no position on the contested legal and factual claims.

The irony has nonetheless been widely remarked. A work about the defeat of a collective enterprise, the expropriation of labour, and the persistence of a revolution's memory became the object of a struggle over who owns a collective enterprise and the world it made. Roland Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) transferred authority over the text from its author to its readers; Foucault's author-function, invoked in the Introduction, described authorship as an institutional effect. The world of Elysium has exceeded every institution that claims it. It lives in the play of its players, the work of its translators, the scholarship and art of its communities, and the new projects of those who built it. It has become, in the terms of this thesis, a dissipative commons: a pattern sustained by many hands, for as long as they keep moving together.

Works Cited

Dates are of first publication or composition; translations are named only where quoted.

Primary Sources

Kurvitz, Robert. *Püha ja õudne lõhn* [*The Sacred and Terrible Air*]. Tallinn, 2013.

ZA/UM. *Disco Elysium*. Lead design and writing by Robert Kurvitz; art direction by Aleksander Rostov; music by British Sea Power. 2019.

ZA/UM. *Disco Elysium: The Final Cut*. 2021.

Philosophy, Theory, and Criticism

Aarseth, Espen. *Cybertext: Perspectives on Ergodic Literature*. 1997.

Adams, Henry. *The Education of Henry Adams* (1907; 1918); "The Rule of Phase Applied to History" (1909); *A Letter to American Teachers of History* (1910).

Adorno, Theodor W., and Max Horkheimer. *Dialectic of Enlightenment*. 1944/1947.

Agamben, Giorgio. *Profanations*. 2005.

Alexievich, Svetlana. *Secondhand Time*. 2013.

Ali, Tariq. *The Extreme Centre*. 2015.

Althusser, Louis. "Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses" (1970); "The Underground Current of the Materialism of the Encounter" (written 1982; published 1994).

Anderson, Benedict. *Imagined Communities*. 1983.

Arendt, Hannah. *The Human Condition* (1958); *On Revolution* (1963).

Aristotle. *De Anima*; *Nicomachean Ethics*.

Avicenna (Ibn Sīnā). *Kitāb al-Nafs*, in *Kitāb al-Shifā'*.

Badiou, Alain. *Being and Event* (1988); "Of an Obscure Disaster" (1991); *Ethics* (1993); *In Praise of Love* (2009).

Bagehot, Walter. *The English Constitution*. 1867.

Bakhtin, Mikhail. *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics* (1929; rev. 1963); "Discourse in the Novel" (1934–35); "Forms of Time and of the Chronotope in the Novel" (1937–38).

Barthes, Roland. "The Death of the Author." 1967.

Bataille, Georges. "La notion de dépense" (1933); *La Part maudite* (1949).

Benatar, David. *Better Never to Have Been*. 2006.

Benjamin, Walter. "Critique of Violence" (1921); *Origin of the German Trauerspiel* (1928); "Left-Wing Melancholy" (1931); "On the Concept of History" (1940).

Bennett, Jane. *Vibrant Matter*. 2010.

Berardi, Franco "Bifo." *After the Future*. 2011.

Bloch, Ernst. *Heritage of Our Times* (1935); *The Principle of Hope* (1954–59).

Bogost, Ian. *Persuasive Games: The Expressive Power of Videogames*. 2007.

Boym, Svetlana. *The Future of Nostalgia*. 2001.

Brown, Wendy. "Resisting Left Melancholy." *boundary 2* 26, no. 3 (1999).

Burke, Edmund. *A Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful*. 1757.

Butler, Judith. *Gender Trouble*. 1990.

Caillois, Roger. "Mimétisme et psychasthénie légendaire." *Minotaure* 7 (1935).

Camus, Albert. *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942); *The Rebel* (1951).

Cesario, Joseph, David J. Johnson, and Heather L. Eisthen. "Your Brain Is Not an Onion with a Tiny Reptile Inside." *Current Directions in Psychological Science* 29, no. 3 (2020).

Clark, Andy, and David Chalmers. "The Extended Mind." *Analysis* 58, no. 1 (1998).

Clausius, Rudolf. "Über verschiedene für die Anwendung bequeme Formen der Hauptgleichungen der mechanischen Wärmetheorie." 1865.

Debord, Guy. *The Society of the Spectacle*. 1967.

Delamare, Nicolas. *Traité de la police*. 1705–38.

Deleuze, Gilles, and Félix Guattari. *Anti-Oedipus* (1972); *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980).

Derrida, Jacques. "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968); *Mémoires: for Paul de Man* (1986); "Force of Law" (1990); *Specters of Marx* (1993); *Politics of Friendship* (1994); *The Work of Mourning* (2001).

Descartes, René. *Meditations on First Philosophy*. 1641.

Du Bois, W. E. B. *The Souls of Black Folk*. 1903.

Dyer, Richard. "In Defence of Disco." *Gay Left* 8 (1979).

Echols, Alice. *Hot Stuff: Disco and the Remaking of American Culture*. 2010.

Eco, Umberto. "Ur-Fascism." 1995.

Fisher, Mark. *Capitalist Realism* (2009); *Ghosts of My Life* (2014); *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016).

Foucault, Michel. *The Order of Things* (1966); "What Is an Author?" (1969); *Security, Territory, Population* (lectures 1977–78); "Self Writing" (1983).

Freud, Sigmund. "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917); *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920); *New Introductory Lectures on Psycho-Analysis* (1933).

Fukuyama, Francis. "The End of History?" (1989); *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992).

Gall, Franz Joseph, and Johann Gaspar Spurzheim. *Anatomie et physiologie du système nerveux*. 1810–19.

Galloway, Alexander R. *Gaming: Essays on Algorithmic Culture*. 2006.

Goffman, Erving. *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. 1956.

Gould, Stephen Jay. *The Mismeasure of Man*. 1981.

Griffin, Roger. *The Nature of Fascism*. 1991.

Groys, Boris. *The Total Art of Stalinism*. 1988.

Heidegger, Martin. *Being and Time*. 1927.

Hobbes, Thomas. *Leviathan*. 1651.

Holquist, Michael. "Whodunit and Other Questions: Metaphysical Detective Stories in Post-War Fiction." *New Literary History* 3, no. 1 (1971).

Hume, David. *A Treatise of Human Nature*. 1739–40.

Hutchins, Edwin. *Cognition in the Wild*. 1995.

James, William. *The Varieties of Religious Experience*. 1902.

Jameson, Fredric. "On Raymond Chandler" (1970); *The Political Unconscious* (1981); *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (1991).

Jaynes, Julian. *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind*. 1976.

Juul, Jesper. *The Art of Failure*. 2013.

Kant, Immanuel. *Critique of Judgment* (1790); *Perpetual Peace* (1795); *Der Streit der Fakultäten* (1798).

Kantorowicz, Ernst. *The King's Two Bodies*. 1957.

Kierkegaard, Søren. *Either/Or* (1843); *The Sickness unto Death* (1849).

Klein, Naomi. *The Shock Doctrine*. 2007.

Lacan, Jacques. "The Mirror Stage as Formative of the Function of the I." 1949.

Latour, Bruno. *Reassembling the Social*. 2005.

Lawrence, Tim. *Love Saves the Day: A History of American Dance Music Culture, 1970–1979*. 2003.

Lepecki, André. "Choreopolice and Choreopolitics: or, the task of the dancer." *TDR: The Drama Review* 57, no. 4 (2013).

Ligotti, Thomas. *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race*. 2010.

Lissagaray, Prosper-Olivier. *Histoire de la Commune de 1871*. 1876.

Lyotard, Jean-François. *Libidinal Economy* (1974); "The Sublime and the Avant-Garde" (1984).

MacLean, Paul D. *The Triune Brain in Evolution*. 1990.

Marx, Karl. *Economic and Philosophical Manuscripts* (1844); *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* (1852); *Capital*, vol. 1 (1867; trans. Moore and Aveling, 1887); *The Civil War in France* (1871).

Maté, Gabor. *In the Realm of Hungry Ghosts*. 2008.

Mauss, Marcel. *Essai sur le don*. 1925.

Merivale, Patricia, and Susan Elizabeth Sweeney, eds. *Detecting Texts: The Metaphysical Detective Story from Poe to Postmodernism*. 1999.

Miéville, China. "Editorial Introduction: Marxism and Fantasy." *Historical Materialism* 10, no. 4 (2002).

Morton, Samuel George. *Crania Americana*. 1839.

Mouffe, Chantal. *On the Political*. 2005.

Murdoch, Iris. *The Sovereignty of Good*. 1970.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872); *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* (1883–85); *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887).

Parfit, Derek. *Reasons and Persons*. 1984.

Plato. *Meno*; *Phaedo*; *Phaedrus*; *Protagoras*; *Republic*; *Theaetetus* (trans. Benjamin Jowett).

Polanyi, Karl. *The Great Transformation*. 1944.

Prigogine, Ilya, and Isabelle Stengers. *La Nouvelle Alliance* (1979); *Order out of Chaos* (1984).

Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite. *Mystical Theology*. c. 500.

Rancière, Jacques. *Disagreement* (1995); *The Politics of Aesthetics* (2000); "Ten Theses on Politics" (2001).

Ricoeur, Paul. *Oneself as Another* (1990); *Memory, History, Forgetting* (2000).

Ross, Kristin. *Communal Luxury: The Political Imaginary of the Paris Commune*. 2015.

Sagan, Carl. *The Dragons of Eden*. 1977.

Sartre, Jean-Paul. *Being and Nothingness*. 1943.

Schopenhauer, Arthur. *The World as Will and Representation*. 1818.

Schrödinger, Erwin. *What Is Life?* 1944.

Shklovsky, Viktor. "Art as Device." 1917.

Slobodian, Quinn. *Globalists* (2018); *Crack-Up Capitalism* (2023).

Sloterdijk, Peter. *Critique of Cynical Reason*. 1983.

Sontag, Susan. "Fascinating Fascism." 1975.

Sorel, Georges. *Reflections on Violence*. 1908.

Spence, Jonathan D. *The Memory Palace of Matteo Ricci*. 1984.

Spinoza, Baruch. *Ethics* (1677; trans. R. H. M. Elwes, 1883).

Stiegler, Bernard. *Technics and Time, 1: The Fault of Epimetheus*. 1994.

Theweleit, Klaus. *Male Fantasies*. 1977–78.

Thomson, William (Lord Kelvin). "On a Universal Tendency in Nature to the Dissipation of Mechanical Energy." 1852.

Todorov, Tzvetan. "The Typology of Detective Fiction." 1966.

Tulving, Endel. "Episodic and Semantic Memory." 1972.

Wallas, Graham. *The Art of Thought*. 1926.

Wallerstein, Immanuel. *The Modern World-System*, vol. 1. 1974.

Weber, Max. "Politik als Beruf." 1919.

Weil, Simone. "Reflections on the Right Use of School Studies with a View to the Love of God" (1942); *Gravity and Grace* (1947).

Wells, Ida B. *Southern Horrors: Lynch Law in All Its Phases*. 1892.

Weston, Jessie L. *From Ritual to Romance*. 1920.

Wiener, Norbert. *The Human Use of Human Beings*. 1950.

Yates, Frances A. *The Art of Memory*. 1966.

Yurchak, Alexei. *Everything Was Forever, Until It Was No More: The Last Soviet Generation*. 2005.

Zapffe, Peter Wessel. "Den sidste Messias" ["The Last Messiah"]. 1933.

Žižek, Slavoj. *The Sublime Object of Ideology*. 1989.

Literature, Myth, and Scripture

Aeschylus. *Oresteia* (*Eumenides*). 458 BCE.

Auster, Paul. *City of Glass*. 1985.

Baudelaire, Charles. *Les Fleurs du mal* (1857; 2nd ed. 1861), including "Le Vin des chiffonniers" and "Le Cygne."

Beckett, Samuel. *Waiting for Godot*. 1953.

Borges, Jorge Luis. "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941); "Death and the Compass" (1942); "Funes the Memorious" (1942).

Cervantes, Miguel de. *Don Quixote*. 1605, 1615.

Chandler, Raymond. "The Simple Art of Murder." 1944.

Chesterton, G. K. *The Secret of Father Brown*. 1927.

Dante Alighieri. *Commedia* (*Inferno*; *Purgatorio*). c. 1308–21.

Dick, Philip K. *Ubik* (1969); *Flow My Tears, the Policeman Said* (1974); *A Scanner Darkly* (1977).

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. *The Double* (1846); *Notes from Underground* (1864); *Crime and Punishment* (1866); *The Idiot* (1869); *Demons* (1872); *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880) (trans. Constance Garnett).

Doyle, Arthur Conan. *A Study in Scarlet*. 1887.

Eco, Umberto. *The Name of the Rose*. 1980.

Eliot, T. S. *The Waste Land*. 1922.

Ende, Michael. *The Neverending Story*. 1979.

Erasmus, Desiderius. *The Praise of Folly*. 1511.

Goethe, Johann Wolfgang von. *Faust I*. 1808.

Hammett, Dashiell. *Red Harvest*. 1929.

Harrison, M. John. *Viriconium* (1971–84); *Light* (2002).

Hávamál, in the *Poetic Edda* (trans. Henry Adams Bellows, 1923).

Heraclitus. Fragments (Diels–Kranz B12, B91).

Hesiod. *Works and Days*.

Hesse, Hermann. *Der Steppenwolf*. 1927.

Hölderlin, Friedrich. "Patmos." 1803.

Homer. *Iliad*; *Odyssey*.

Ishiguro, Kazuo. *The Buried Giant*. 2015.

Joyce, James. *Ulysses*. 1922.

Kafka, Franz. *The Metamorphosis*. 1915.

Kivirähk, Andrus. *The Man Who Spoke Snakish*. 2007.

Krasznahorkai, László. *Satantango* (1985); *The Melancholy of Resistance* (1989).

Kross, Jaan. *The Czar's Madman*. 1978.

Kruchenykh, Aleksei. "Dyr bul shchyl." 1913.

Le Guin, Ursula K. "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973); *The Dispossessed* (1974).

Lem, Stanisław. *Solaris*. 1961.

Lucian of Samosata. *A True Story*; *Dialogues of the Dead*.

Lucretius. *De Rerum Natura*.

Mann, Thomas. *Der Zauberberg*. 1924.

Melville, Herman. *Moby-Dick*. 1851.

Miéville, China. *Iron Council* (2004); *The City & The City* (2009).

Milindapañha (*The Questions of King Milinda*).

Multatuli (Eduard Douwes Dekker). *Max Havelaar*. 1860.

Murdoch, Iris. *The Sea, the Sea*. 1978.

Musil, Robert. *The Man Without Qualities*. 1930–43.

Pessoa, Fernando. Letter to Adolfo Casais Monteiro, 13 January 1935; *The Book of Disquiet* (posthumous).

Pindar. *Olympian* 2. 476 BCE.

Poe, Edgar Allan. "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" (1841); "The Purloined Letter" (1844).

Pynchon, Thomas. "Entropy" (1960); *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966); *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973).

Rimbaud, Arthur. Letters to Georges Izambard (13 May 1871) and Paul Demeny (15 May 1871).

Rumi, Jalal al-Din. *Masnavi*.
Schiller, Friedrich. "An die Freude." 1785.
Simenon, Georges. The Maigret novels. From 1931.
Stabat Mater dolorosa. Thirteenth century.
Stevenson, Robert Louis. *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*. 1886.
Strugatsky, Arkady and Boris. *Hard to Be a God* (1964); *Roadside Picnic* (1972).
Tammsaare, A. H. *Truth and Justice*. 1926–33.
Thomas, R. S. *No Truce with the Furies*. 1995.
VanderMeer, Jeff. *Annihilation*. 2014.
Virgil. *Aeneid*.
Wagner, Richard. *Parsifal*. 1882.
Wilde, Oscar. "The Decay of Lying." 1889.
Wolfe, Gene. *The Book of the New Sun*. 1980–83.
Wolfram von Eschenbach. *Parzival*. c. 1200–10.
Yeats, W. B. "The Second Coming" (1920); *A Vision* (1925); "Among School Children" (1927).

Games, Film, Television, and Music

Baker, Vincent. *Apocalypse World*. Tabletop role-playing game, 2010.
Beethoven, Ludwig van. Symphony No. 9 in D minor, Op. 125. 1824.
Black Isle Studios. *Planescape: Torment*. 1999.
Cardboard Computer. *Kentucky Route Zero*. 2013–20.
The Caretaker (Leyland Kirby). *Everywhere at the End of Time*. 2016–19.
Geography of Robots. *Norco*. 2022.
Ice-Pick Lodge. *Pathologic* (2005); *Pathologic 2* (2019).
Interplay Productions. *Fallout*. 1997.
Jump Over the Age. *Citizen Sleeper*. 2022.
Kubrick, Stanley, dir. *The Shining*. 1980.
Lynch, David, and Mark Frost. *Twin Peaks*. 1990–91.
Lynch, David, dir. *Inland Empire*. 2006.
Obsidian Entertainment. *Pentiment*. 2022.
Pizzolatto, Nic. *True Detective*, season 1. 2014.
Simon, David. *The Wire*, season 2. 2003.
Tarkovsky, Andrei, dir. *Solaris* (1972); *Stalker* (1979).
Tarr, Béla, dir. *Sátántangó* (1994); *Werckmeister Harmonies* (2000).
Troika Games. *Vampire: The Masquerade – Bloodlines*. 2004.

Supplementary Sources

Aquinas, Thomas. *Summa Theologiae* I, q. 78. 1265–74.
Brant, Sebastian. *Das Narrenschiff*. 1494.

Bulgakov, Mikhail. *The Master and Margarita*. Written 1928–40; published 1966–67.

Damasio, Antonio. *Descartes' Error*. 1994.

Dennett, Daniel C. *Consciousness Explained* (1991); "The Self as a Center of Narrative Gravity" (1992).

Foucault, Michel. *History of Madness* (1961); "Society Must Be Defended" (lectures 1975–76).

Freud, Sigmund. "Fragment of an Analysis of a Case of Hysteria." 1905.

Game World Observer. "Disco Elysium co-creator Robert Kurvitz drops dismissal lawsuit against ZA/UM due to 'lack of evidence'." 14 March 2023, updated 17 March 2023. gameworldobserver.com/?p=17991.

Gogol, Nikolai. "Diary of a Madman." 1835.

Gramsci, Antonio. *Prison Notebooks*. Written 1929–35.

Harvey, David. *The New Imperialism* (2003); *A Brief History of Neoliberalism* (2005).

Hayek, Friedrich. *The Road to Serfdom*. 1944.

Hegel, G. W. F. Letter to Friedrich Immanuel Niethammer, 13 October 1806; *Lectures on the Philosophy of History* (delivered 1822–31).

Ivan, Tom. "Ousted Disco Elysium developers look set for court battle with studio owners." *VGC*, 9 November 2022. videogameschronicle.com/news/ousted-disco-elysium-developers-look-set-for-court-battle-with-studio-owners.

Jung, C. G. *Two Essays on Analytical Psychology*. 1928.

Kafka, Franz. "Before the Law" (1915); *The Trial* (1925).

Lacan, Jacques. "Intervention on Transference." 1951.

Levinas, Emmanuel. *Totality and Infinity*. 1961.

Lukács, Georg. *The Theory of the Novel* (1916; 1920); *The Historical Novel* (1937).

Lynch, David, dir. *Lost Highway*. 1997.

Merleau-Ponty, Maurice. *Phenomenology of Perception*. 1945.

Minsky, Marvin. *The Society of Mind*. 1986.

Ovid. *Metamorphoses*, Book X.

Rand, Ayn. *Atlas Shrugged*. 1957.

Reid, Thomas. *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man* (1785); *Essays on the Active Powers of Man* (1788).

Sebald, W. G. *Austerlitz*. 2001.

Tombs, Robert. "How Bloody Was la Semaine sanglante of 1871? A Revision." *The Historical Journal* 55, no. 3 (2012).

Virgil. *Georgics*, Book IV.

Appendix: Sources and Checks for Game Details

The game details cited in this thesis were checked against the community-maintained Disco Elysium Wiki, the FAYDE and Disco Elysium Scribe dialogue databases, and published criticism. Citations given in the text as (Wikipedia) refer to the article "Disco Elysium" and the sources it cites. The lists below record the sources consulted and the checks made.

Sources Consulted for Game Details

Disco Elysium Wiki (wiki.gg): Ruby; Morale; Dolorian Church of Humanity; Disco Elysium.

Disco Elysium Wiki (Fandom and Gamepedia): Ruby, the Instigator; Klaasje; Kim Kitsuragi.

Wikipedia: Disco Elysium; Kim Kitsuragi; Cuno (Disco Elysium).

GameBanshee. Look for Ruby on the Coast.

Kotaku (2021). When My Disco Elysium Character Gave Up, I Was Like, Yeah.

The Sixth Axis (2021). Disco Elysium: The Final Cut review.

Unwinnable (2022). How Disco Elysium's Centrist Path Observes the Player.

TheGamer. On the Horrific Necktie.

The Mary Sue. Kim Kitsuragi Is a Fantastic Example of a Mixed-Asian Character.

Xiyue. Beyond Disco Elysium: Designing race, memory, and meaning decay.

Esports.ru (2025). Report on the Locust City spin-off, noting Mikee W. Goodman's roles.

Critical Sources and Transcript Databases

Winslow-Yost, Gabriel. "The World's Memory of the World." *The Baffler* 81, November 2025. Source for Kurvitz's gloss of the title, the novel's reception and plot, the collective authorship, the Moralintern, the execution wall, the Expression, and several in-game lines.

Kotaku (2020). On the dialogue system and Kurvitz's comparison to Twitter.

Disco Elysium Wiki (wiki.gg). Ruby, the Instigator, with line-level citations of the in-game dialogue.

In-game dialogue databases, through which the Disco Elysium Wiki cites individual lines: FAYDE Browser; Disco Elysium Scribe; Elysia Database. The checks recorded below were made against these databases.

In-Game Lines Checked in the FAYDE Database

The following passages were checked against the game's dialogue in the FAYDE Browser on 26 October 2026, by searching the terms given in parentheses.

Steban, the Student Communist, on the Pale as nostalgia and historical inertia ("historical inertia").

The Insulindian Phasmid on the Pale as a nervous shadow cast by human beings ("nervous shadow").

Harry pawning his sidearm, and Evrart Claire's remark on it ("pawned").

The dream beneath the disco ball and the Bloated Corpse of a Drunk ("disco ball").

The Spinal Cord's dance-floor remark ("dance," said by Spinal Cord).

Kim on Harry's moves on the church floor ("homo-sexual," said by Kim Kitsuragi).

Cuno declaring himself Harry's partner ("partner," said by Cuno).

The Deserter on the Dolorian church, and Rhetoric on the dismantled West Revacholian industrial base ("dismantled").

Lines Checked via the Disco Elysium Wiki

The following were checked on 26 October 2026 against Disco Elysium Wiki pages whose footnotes quote the in-game dialogue, with links to FAYDE and the Disco Elysium Scribe.

Kim's answer about the homo-sexual underground (Kim Kitsuragi; FAYDE entry 290079).

Gary, the Cryptofascist, and Measurehead on Kim, and Kim on how his countrymen see him (Kim Kitsuragi page footnotes).

Kim on the Seven Sisters and the police raid, and Tiago on the raid (Dolorian Church of Humanity; FAYDE entries 9980252, 9980219, 5570465).

The text and mechanics of Kingdom of Conscience and Wompty-Dompty Dom Centre.

The three special voices, Mikee W. Goodman's performance, and the Reptile's voice in the church and at karaoke (Ancient Reptilian Brain).

The Morale ending's Volition cutscene and newspaper (Morale).

Volition on the giant insect (FAYDE search "give up," said by Volition).

Mechanics and Further Lines Checked

Checked on 26 October 2026 in FAYDE and on the Disco Elysium Wiki.

Kim asking whether Harry's racism was meant in earnest (FAYDE search "meant," said by Kim Kitsuragi); the Racist Lorry Driver's greeting to Kim and his accusation of Siileng (Racist Lorry Driver).

Dice rules, white and red checks, and archetypes (Skills); the Dicemaker's dice (Novelty Dicemaker); The Precarious World, thought counts and slots, and Advanced Race Theory (Thought Cabinet).

Drug effects and Electrochemistry's tasks (Drugs); copotypes (Copotypes); the Doomed Commercial Area (Doomed Commercial Area).

In FAYDE: Garte's bill ("damages"); Kim's little notebook ("notebook," said by Kim Kitsuragi); Joyce on the Pale's expansion ("expanding," said by Joyce Messier); the ceiling fan and Pain Threshold on the heart attack ("heart attack"); Raphaël Ambrosius Costeau ("Costeau"); Tequila Sunset and the

hanged man (“Tequila Sunset”); Drama’s ‘sire’ (“sire,” said by Drama); Harry’s rank (“yefreitor”); the generic game-over text (“the,” said by Game Over).

Sources for the Final Verification

Checked on 26 October 2026.

Wikipedia. “Disco Elysium.” Development history, influences, plot, cast, awards, and studio history, with its cited sources.

Adam, Jamie, and Michael McClelland. “Forward-looking return: An interview with Disco Elysium writer Helen Hindpere.” *Platypus Review*, 2024.

Disco Elysium Wiki: Revachol Citizens Militia; Horseback Monument; Lena, the Cryptozoologist’s Wife; René Arnoux; thought effects on the Thought Cabinet page.

FAYDE: Harry and Kim on entroponetics (“entroponetic”); Kim on the king of disco at the roundabout (“disco ball”).

Keywords

Disco Elysium ◆ Robert Kurvitz ◆ ZA/UM ◆ game studies ◆ ludic hermeneutics ◆ procedural rhetoric ◆ ergodic literature ◆ dissipative polyphony ◆ dissipative commons ◆ Phasmid principle ◆ vortical subject ◆ constitutional polyphony ◆ Elysian dialectic ◆ Mikhail Bakhtin ◆ polyphony ◆ heteroglossia ◆ Menippean satire ◆ chronotope ◆ faculty psychology ◆ phrenology and craniometry ◆ triune brain ◆ bicameral mind ◆ heteronymy ◆ Fernando Pessoa ◆ Hermann Hesse ◆ bundle theory ◆ personal identity ◆ Derek Parfit ◆ amnesia ◆ anamnesis ◆ Lethe and Eunoë ◆ Elysium ◆ Virgil ◆ Dante ◆ city–soul analogy ◆ Plato's *Republic* ◆ Paris Commune ◆ communal luxury ◆ post-Soviet studies ◆ Estonian literature ◆ non-synchronism ◆ hauntology ◆ capitalist realism ◆ left melancholy ◆ ideology critique ◆ fascism studies ◆ neoliberalism ◆ centrism and consensus ◆ police theory ◆ Walter Benjamin ◆ Jacques Rancière ◆ choreopolitics ◆ interpellation ◆ entropy ◆ thermodynamics of history ◆ Henry Adams ◆ dissipative structures ◆ Ilya Prigogine ◆ aleatory materialism ◆ *clinamen* ◆ Georges Bataille ◆ *dépense* ◆ disco ◆ *danse macabre* ◆ Dionysian and Apollonian ◆ the sublime ◆ mimicry ◆ Roger Caillois ◆ Ernst Bloch ◆ anticipatory illumination

◆ Iris Murdoch ◆ unselfing ◆ Simone Weil ◆ attention

◆ Hannah Arendt ◆ natality ◆ Alain Badiou ◆ fidelity

◆ friendship ◆ mourning and melancholia

◆ metaphysical detective fiction ◆ Dostoevsky ◆ Grail romance

◆ holy fool ◆ Strugatsky brothers ◆ New Weird

◆ speculative fiction ◆ *Planescape: Torment*

◆ comparative mythopoetics ◆ Georg Lukács ◆ Antonio Gramsci

◆ interregnum ◆ biopolitics ◆ extended mind ◆ Orpheus

◆ W. G. Sebald ◆ race and representation ◆ queer representation

◆ despair